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Gold



Sharmila Dhankar



Preeti Pawar



Jasmine Lamboria



Sakshi Chaudhary



Sachin Siwach



Priya Ghanghas

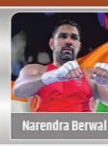


Ankush Panghal

Silver



Neeraj Chopra

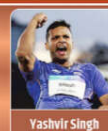


Narendra Berwal

Bronze



Seema Kallraman



Yashvir Singh

State-Level Felicitation Ceremony

for the Medal Winners and
Participants of the Commonwealth Games-2026

Athletes will be felicitated with a total cash prize of **₹13,97,50,000**



Gold Medal
₹1.5 Crore



Silver Medal
₹75 Lakh



Bronze Medal
₹50 Lakh

**Participating
Athletes**
₹7.5 Lakh

Chief Guest

Sh. Nayab Singh Saini

Chief Minister, Haryana

August Presence

Sh. Gaurav Gautam

Minister of State for Sports
(Independent Charge), Haryana

**Haryana's
athletes
won 28%**

**of India's total
medal tally**

Date

August 26, 2026

Time

11:00 AM

Venue

Indradhanush Auditorium, Sector 5, Panchkula

Athletes and Sports officials from across the State will participate in the ceremony
Sports Department, Haryana

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programme



Trade war: Canada declares retaliatory tariffs on \$20 billion worth of US goods

Reuters
Ottawa, August 25

CANADA ON Tuesday announced retaliatory tariffs on \$19.4 billion worth of United States goods, matching dollar-for-dollar new duties imposed by Washington, and unveiled financial support for Canadian businesses and workers caught in the escalating trade war.

The counter-tariffs take effect on US goods from September 8 and will impose duties of 15%, 25% and 50% across 700 products imported from south of the border.

In terms of financial support for affected workers and industries, Canada announced a \$5.4 billion package of new and enhanced measures including support for small and medium-sized businesses, a stream for funding cash flows of companies, and support for workers at risk due to the new tariffs.

From Saturday, President Donald Trump's new 50% tariffs across \$20 billion of Canadian imports took effect after talks between the two countries to avert the tariffs collapsed.

The new tit-for-tat tariffs mark a new low in the Canada-US relationship. "Our dollar-for-dollar rate for rate counter-tariffs as well as a multi-billion dollar support package will pro-

Lake Ontario to 'Lake America': Trump's new idea

Washington: President Donald Trump said Tuesday that he is considering changing the name of Lake Ontario to "Lake America" as the trade war between the United States and Canada intensifies.

"The United States is giving serious consideration to changing the name of Lake Ontario to Lake America in that we don't expect to do much business with Ontario any longer," Trump said Tuesday on social media.

Ontario is Canada's most populous province and is home to country's auto industry. AP

text workers, farmers, families, and businesses," Canada's Finance Minister François-Philippe Champagne said.

The new tariffs are designed so that the impact on Canadian consumers and businesses is minimal and could still hit the US, a government official said.

The 50% tariffs will be on electronics and tools.

CHINA SAYS ITS TIES WITH TEHRAN LAWFUL, SHOULD NOT BE DISRUPTED

Iran vows to resist widened sanctions, says US seeks talks

'Mediator' Pak says 'significant progress' in talks over Strait

Reuters

Cairo, Washington, August 25

IRAN DENOUNCED on Tuesday expanded US sanctions aimed at isolating its economy as an act of "gross lawlessness", expressing confidence that many countries would not join the pressure campaign.

Almost six months into a conflict the US has struggled to resolve, Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent unveiled the measures on Monday but stopped short of the most punishing options.

While he said countries that continued trading with Iran risked being forced out of the dollar-based financial system, he declined to give a timeline or identify which may be targeted, saying he would give them time to comply with new directives.

There have been signals of a potential return to mediation to end the war. Iran and Oman said they had discussed a proposal on Tuesday for a "joint temporary navigational corridor" through the strait and a plan to clear the strait of mines.

US President Donald Trump repeated earlier assertions that all mines in the strait had been



Vessels in the Strait of Hormuz near the beach of Bandar Abbas, Iran, on Tuesday. REUTERS

removed or detonated, adding Iran had been told that any ship or boat placing new mines would be destroyed.

Iran's Foreign Ministry described the latest US sanctions as a threat to international law and the UN charter, saying "the issue is no longer limited to Iran". "No honourable state that values its sovereignty and national interests will accept normalization of such gross lawlessness and systematic bullying," it said.

China has been the biggest buyer of Iranian oil for several years. However, the US blockade of Iran's ports has cut those oil flows to China since Washington resumed it in mid-July.

Trump has said he expects to host Chinese President Xi Jinping next month, and US is keen to avoid any curbs on China's exports of critical minerals.

US Secret Service 'aware' of Iranian video threatening Barron Trump

Washington: The US Secret Service has confirmed it is aware Iranian state media has aired a video that appears to threaten life of Barron Trump, President Donald Trump's youngest son.

"The US Secret Service is aware of the video and investigates anything that can be perceived as a threat toward our protectees," Secret Service spokesman Nate Herring said. "Out of concern for operational security, we do not discuss matters of protective intelligence," she added.

CNN previously reported that the Secret Service had knowledge of the Barron Trump threat. AP

comment from the White House or the State Department.

Iran expressed a general willingness to resume peace talks during meetings between Iranian and Pakistani officials while expressing concern about sanctions, a Pakistani source said. "Pakistan told them the US will reverse these decisions either before, or during a new round of negotiations," the official said.

• BRIEFLY

UNITED STATES

Google expands Gemini AI platform for law firms, lawyers



Alphabet's Gemini logo

ALPHABET'S GOOGLE ON Tuesday expanded its Gemini Enterprise artificial intelligence platform with new tools for lawyers and law firms, accelerating a race among technology companies to meet legal sector demand for AI. The company said its Gemini Enterprise for Legal would help law firms use AI to manage routine and complex work to allow lawyers to focus on high-value services, while keeping their data secure and confidential. Google said it was also unveiling industry tools for the financial services sector. REUTERS

FRANCE

39 injured, 300 homes wrecked as tornado hits

A TORNADO ravaged a small village in southern France, leaving dozens injured, local authorities said Tuesday. Rescue teams were continuing their search after the tornado led to the village of Pomas in ruins. Marie-Hélène Bouissac, the deputy head of the local government, confirmed a total of 39 people were injured, including two in critical condition. AP

CHINA

Artist gets 3 years in jail for satirical statues of Mao

CHINESE ARTIST Gao Zhen was sentenced to three years in prison on Tuesday for "infringing upon the reputation of heroes" over his satirical works of art, including statues of China's former leader Mao Zedong. US-based artist Gao Zhen, part of an artistic duo known internationally as the Gao Brothers, was arrested while visiting family in China in August 2024. AP

• NEIGHBOURHOOD WATCH

PAKISTAN

5 labourers killed by militants in Balochistan

MILITANTS GUNNED down five labourers at a construction site in Balochistan, a provincial official said Tuesday. The labourers, all belonging to the Punjab province, were killed in Saran town in Pishin district of Balochistan on Monday morning. The bodies of these labourers have been sent to their hometown. PTI

SRI LANKA

4 offshore blocks opened for oil & gas exploration

SRI LANKA Tuesday invited international companies to explore oil and gas in four blocks in the Mannar Basin in the island's northwest, according to an official statement. The move is part of Sri Lanka's effort to develop the island's offshore petroleum resources, specifically to address supply disruptions caused by Iran War. PTI

Beijing accelerates South China Sea build-up with new installations

Reuters
Hong Kong, August 25

NEW INSTALLATIONS have been sighted on an islet near Antelope Reef in the South China Sea where analysts believe China is building its largest military base, according to satellite imagery reviewed by Reuters.

Security analysts say while it is too early to gauge definitively the likely function of the three-pronged construction on Yagong Island, it could be the start of an early warning radar facility to support eventual installations

on Antelope Reef.

Vantor, a commercial provider of satellite images, said it took the latest image on August 17, noting in other images that construction started in March and April.

While the purpose of the buildings was not certain, "several structures on Yagong Reef resemble other military radar/early warning facilities seen elsewhere in South China Sea and are likely associated with the ultimate military functions of nearby Antelope Reef," a Vantor spokesperson said.

Reuters reported last week

that China had completed the first phase of construction at Antelope Reef, highlighting the South China Sea as an increasingly militarised arena between China and the United States and its allies — and one that could prove critical in any future conflict over Taiwan.

The Antelope Reef images showed an artificial island nearly 6 km long, with a straight line of coast longer than 3 km that some analysts see as a potential runway. Yagong is far smaller, 14 km to the northeast of Antelope. Both lie within the Crescent Group in the western

Paracels. The Chinese defence ministry did not respond to requests for comment.

China has not acknowledged the construction of a new military base, and state media said said Antelope will meet civilian needs such as weather forecasting, fisheries protection and scientific research.

China has occupied the Paracels since 1974 when it seized them from the navy of the former South Vietnam. Vietnam, which claims the entire grouping as its own, has moved in recent years to expand its own network of bases in the Spratlys.



A satellite view of Yagong Reef in the Crescent Group of the Paracel Islands in the South China Sea. REUTERS

Contempt plea resubmitted by Imran party after SC objections

Islamabad: Pakistan's jailed former prime minister Imran Khan's party Tuesday resubmitted a contempt petition in Supreme Court over violation of its August 18 order to transfer him to a private hospital.

The Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf (PTI) resubmitted the contempt petition hours after the court returned it with objections. The petition was filed by Uzma Khan, a sister of the 73-year-old politician, accusing the government of failing to shift the PTI founder to Shifa International Hospital in Islamabad for treatment.

The apex court had returned Uzma's petition on technical grounds, but the PTI lawyers immediately addressed the concerns and objections raised by the court and resubmitted it. PTI



Rohingya Exodus Anniversary

Rohingya refugees gather at a camp in Cox's Bazar, Bangladesh, to mark the ninth anniversary of their mass exodus from Myanmar following a military crackdown in Rakhine State, on Tuesday. REUTERS

Gaza parents urged to bar kids from flying kites after Israel's warning to Hamas

Reuters
Cairo, August 25

GAZA PARENTS have been warned to stop their children flying kites in the war-ravaged enclave, after Israel threatened a forceful response if the Hamas militant group revives a tactic of launching incendiary kites over the border.

The popular committees, comprising representatives of local non-government organizations and charities that run Gaza displacement camps and shelters, issued the warning in a statement late on Monday.

The announcement was coordinated with Hamas authorities, a source in the militant group said. "We are working tirelessly on the ground and doing everything possible to stop this practice, not to restrict the childhood of our children,

who have already been deprived of the most basic rights to play and live in safety, but to protect their innocent lives."

In 2018, Gazans sent incendiary balloons and kites over the border, causing fires across hundreds of acres of open fields and farmlands, in what they said was in protest at Israeli blockade of Hamas-controlled enclave.

In the past month, several kites that were not reported to be carrying incendiary materials were spotted drifting from Gaza into Israel.

On Sunday, Israeli PM Benjamin Netanyahu warned Hamas that unless that stopped immediately, "those responsible" for launching kites, balloons or drones toward Israel would be targets of assassination and that areas from which they are sent will be ordered to evacuate.

• THE QUALITY THAT GAVE HER ENDURING STAR POWER WAS HER ABILITY TO CONNECT WITH PEOPLE, COMING FROM A SELF-DESCRIBED 'DIRT-POOR' FAMILY, PARTON STOOD IN AS A SYMBOL OF THE WORKING-CLASS AMERICAN

I Will Always Love You: Dolly Parton, queen of country music, actor, dies at 80

Reuters
August 25

DOLLY PARTON was around six when she wrote her first song, *Little Tiny Tasseltop*, an ode to her corn-cob doll with corn-silk hair. Her mother stored it preciously in a shoebox. "I loved that little doll," Parton wrote decades later. "I expressed myself and my feelings through writing."

"I'm sure what I was thinking was, 'Well, Tasseltop has to have a song about her.'"

Parton's wholesome personality, combined with her towering blond hairdos, flamboyant costumes and giddy delight at holding center stage, endeared her to Americans of all backgrounds and helped introduce country music to international audiences.

Over the years Parton hosted a TV variety show, starred in movies, and even created a theme park, Dollywood, a popular tourist spot in her hometown of Tennessee — all in addition to her lauded work as a songwriter. But the quality that gave her enduring star power was her ability to connect with people. Coming from a self-described "dirt-poor" family, Parton often stood in as a symbol of the working-class American and regularly threw her name and money behind causes she believed in.

In response to COVID-19 pandemic, Parton donated \$1 million to vaccine research at Vanderbilt University in 2020, making her an early sponsor of



Dolly Parton takes the stage to accept the Tex Ritter Award at the 51st Academy of Country Music Awards in Las Vegas, Nevada. FILE

the vaccine development.

She conducted a literacy program for preschool children across the United States, as well

as in Canada, the UK, Australia and Ireland, and provided scholarships to high school students in the Tennessee country where

she was born.

The county erected a life-size statue of her in front of the courthouse in thanks, though she declined another proposed statue of her in Nashville in 2021, saying, "Given all that's going on in the world, I don't think putting me on a pedestal is appropriate at this time." It was this ability to stay true to her roots, combined with her drive to work hard and her nonpartisanship, that fueled her appeal among conservatives and liberals in a politically polarized America.

Dolly Rebecca Parton was born on January 19, 1946, in Pittman Center, Tennessee, and grew up in a one-room cabin in nearby Locust Ridge. One of 12

children of tobacco farmer Robert Lee Parton, her difficult childhood gave credibility to her often personal songs thrilled in a distinctive soprano.

Her mother, Avie Lee, would sing constantly — songs from England, Ireland and Wales that told a story. "Mama had this haunting voice, and Lord you would feel it," Parton wrote in her 2020 book *Dolly Parton, Songwriter* co-authored with Robert K Oermann.

Parton got her first real guitar when she was eight. Her mother would say, whenever she had guests: "I want you to hear this song this little thing has made up. It's really good."

She was singing on a local

radio station by age 11, and at age 13 was appearing on Grand Ole Opry, a weekly country music concert in Nashville, Tennessee.

After graduating from high school, she moved to Nashville to pursue a music career and began a famous partnership with country music singer Porter Wagoner, which would include a years-long stint on his TV show and 14 top-ten duets. She penned her hit song *I Will Always Love You* as a farewell to Wagoner when she decided to pursue a solo career.

On the first day Parton arrived in country music's capital, she met Carl Dean, an asphalt paver. They would marry two years later, in 1966.



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After 3 days of protest, IIT-D says changing suicide inquiry panel members

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, August 25

IIT-Delhi on Tuesday evening agreed to change the composition of the committee that will inquire into the death by suicide of a Masters' student, bowing to the demand of students who have been protesting on campus since Sunday.

In a statement, IIT-D said Rishikesh Kumar, who was studying for an MSc in physics, was an "academically bright student" who had been treated for a mental health condition at a specialised hospital, and whose requests for withdrawal from both the January-May and July-November semesters had been approved by the institute.

The protests began after the 31-year-old student allegedly jumped to his death from the

● **CONTINUED ON PAGE 2**

RELATED REPORTS, P.4

WILL BE VISITING INDIA AFTER 7 YEARS AMID EFFORTS TO RESTORE TIES

Xi likely to attend BRICS in Delhi next month with large delegation

Chinese advance team arrives to prepare the ground for visit

Shubhrajit Roy
New Delhi, August 25

CHINESE PRESIDENT Xi Jinping is likely to attend the summit of BRICS leaders in New Delhi on September 12 and 13, *The Indian Express* has learnt. He last visited India in October 2019, months before PLA incursions along the Line of Actual Control in eastern Ladakh triggered a military standoff between the two countries.

It is learnt that the Chinese side has conveyed to New Delhi that Xi is likely to come for the leaders' summit. An advance team from China has arrived for the security and protocol arrangements to prepare for the President's possible visit.

It is expected that Xi will come with a large delegation of officials, businessmen and state-backed media representatives.

Xi's attendance at the BRICS summit is expected to be a significant event. **● CONTINUED ON PAGE 2**



NSA Ajit Doval with Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi in Beijing, Tuesday. PTI

In Beijing, Doval and Wang look to 'make progress on boundary delimitation'

Shubhrajit Roy
New Delhi, August 25

NATIONAL SECURITY ADVISOR Ajit Doval and Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi, who are the special representatives of their countries on the boundary issue, held talks in Beijing Tuesday and the Indian embassy later said they discussed ways to

"make progress on boundary delimitation" while "sustaining the ongoing work on transboundary cooperation".

Before his talks with Wang, Doval met Chinese Vice President Han Zheng and China said it urged India to view and handle their relationship from a "strategic and long-term" **● CONTINUED ON PAGE 2**

Two Indian ships among 45 blacklisted by Iran for Hormuz 'violations'

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, August 25

TWO SHIPS owned and operated by India-based entities feature on the list of 45 "non-compliant" vessels issued by Iran's Persian Gulf Strait Authority (PGSA) on Sunday. The two Indian vessels on the list are LNG (liquefied natural gas) tanker *Disha* and bulk carrier *Maha Roos*, as per the analysis. Apart from these two, some of the other ships have a history of transporting cargo, particularly energy, to India.

Many of the vessels are linked to UAE-based entities, particularly the Abu Dhabi National Oil Company (ADNOC) group. Apart from India, vessels linked to entities based in countries like Saudi Arabia, Qatar, **● CONTINUED ON PAGE 2**

Business as Usual By EP UNNY



INSIDE PAGE 12
SURRENDER IN TWO WEEKS: SC REJECTS TARUN TEJPAL'S EXEMPTION PLEA

Mumbai trans player gets Australia nod for women community cricket

Devendra Pandey
Mumbai, August 25

FORMER MUMBAI Under-19 cricketer Anaya Bangar, who underwent a gender-affirming surgery in March this year, has received clearance to play women's community cricket in Australia.

"It is a great day for me, especially after knowing the fact that I can play cricket. There was a stage when I thought I would never play cricket again." **● CONTINUED ON PAGE 2**



Anaya Bangar underwent gender-affirming surgery in March. ANAYABANGAR/INSTAGRAM

EXPRESS special

Khargone violence trials: Acquittals, dead ends and failing evidence

We are facing difficulty as names of accused generic without father's name or address: Inspector supervising riot cases

Anand Mohan J
Khargone, August 25

ON JULY 27, a Madhya Pradesh Sessions Court acquitted 11 men accused in the 2022 Khargone Ram Navami violence that left more than two dozen people, including Khargone Superintendent of Police Siddharth Choudhary, injured, and one dead.

In the wake of the clashes, the administration razed 16 houses in the affected localities, linking these to irregularities, and 65 cases were registered. Then Chief Minister Shivraj Choudhary vowed, "There is no place for rioters on the soil of Madhya Pradesh... They will not be released. Strictest action will be taken against them."

Four years later, the cases are collapsing one by one, or are stuck without headway, an investigation into court records by *The Indian Express* reveals.

The only three riot cases to complete trial have all ended in acquittal, including the one in which the order came on July 27. As per the Khargone police, four cases have been closed for want of evidence after police failed to trace the accused, while 38 FIRs remain under investigation, with police yet to find roughly 85 accused in them.

Twenty cases are at the stage of submission of evidence by the prosecution, with witnesses being examined.

In the cases leading to acquittal in Sessions Courts, three **● CONTINUED ON PAGE 2**

THE BIG PICTURE
THE COURAGE RUN
Inside the Army's Paralympic Node PAGE 18



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[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Xi Jinping

summit, the most anticipated visit, will add to efforts by New Delhi and Beijing to restore ties that plummeted after the start of the border standstill in 2020.

The last visit in October 2019 when he travelled to Manipalapur near Chennai for the second informal bilateral summit of leaders.

In October 2024, Xi and Prime Minister Narendra Modi met on the sidelines of the BRICS summit in the Russian city of Kazan to start the process of restoration of ties. The disengagement of troops in eastern Ladakh was completed next month.

More than 50,000 troops are still deployed on either side of the LAC in the region and the process of de-escalation and de-induction of troops has not yet Real Creator IAS Edition https://l.me/+2RkV_RG9mJMagI

Doval, Wang

perspective" and "properly manage differences".

India, on its part, said Doval and Han discussed ways to strengthen peace and tranquillity in the border areas and further improve bilateral ties.

A long part of Han's career was spent in Shanghai, under Xi Jinping, and he was CPC secretary of Shanghai during 2012-2017. He is considered a member of the powerful Shanghai Clique.

Doval's meeting with Han and Wang also set the stage for Xi's likely visit to India for the summit of the BRICS leaders on September 12-13.

After the Doval-Han meeting, China's Ambassador to India, Xu Feihong, said, "Han Zheng stated that over the past two years, President Xi Jinping and Prime Minister Modi have met twice—in Kazan and Tianjin—and reached a series of important consensus on the development of China-India relations, guiding the bilateral relationship back onto a track of recovery and improvement."

"As neighbouring major developing nations and key emerging economies, China and India should view and handle their relationship from a strategic and long-term perspective; jointly implement the important consensus reached by their leaders; enhance strategic mutual trust; tap into cooperation potential; strengthen multilateral coordination; properly manage differences; and promote the sustained and stable development of China-India relations," he said.

The Indian embassy in Beijing said, "NSA and VP Han discussed ways to strengthen peace and tranquillity in the border areas and further improve bilateral relations across economic, political and multilateral fora, in accordance with the consensus reached between the leaders of the two countries".

Ahead of their talks, Doval told Wang: "I am happy that over the past year our relationship has been steadily returning to normalcy. The normalcy in our relationship has been a direct result of both sides maintaining peace and tranquillity in the border areas."

After the meeting, the Indian embassy said, "The two sides positively reviewed the ongoing momentum in bilateral relations which is in line with the directions and vision of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and President Xi Jinping. They discussed ways to further expand bilateral cooperation, maintain stability and ensure peace and tranquillity in the border areas, and make progress on boundary

taken place.

In the two years since, the two sides have made significant progress in stabilising relations with direct flights, resumption of visas, easing of curbs on Chinese firms and the revival of the pilgrimage to Kailash Mansarovar.

Sources said the September summit will mark two years of the informal bilateral relations between the two sides, and India is keen to host all BRICS leaders. Barring any unforeseen development, participation at the highest level has been conveyed to New Delhi.

The venue has not yet been announced, but the Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi is likely to be the preferred choice, sources said.

The Prime Minister's Office has conveyed to the participating countries of BRICS that there will be no bilateral visits along with the summit, but there will Real Creator IAS Edition https://l.me/+2RkV_RG9mJMagI

Cricket

delimitation, while sustaining the ongoing work on transboundary cooperation."

The Ministry of External Affairs, in a statement, said, "Under the strategic guidance of Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi and President Xi Jinping, and in a constructive and forward-looking spirit, the two Special Representatives had a candid and in-depth exchange of views on the India-China bilateral boundary question, and agreed to continue their work in seeking a political settlement of the boundary question in the context of their overall and long-term interests."

It said the "Indian side highlighted the importance of maintaining peace and tranquillity in the India-China border areas for the continued development and progress of the bilateral relationship".

"The two sides noted the progress made in implementing the important consensus reached between their leaders in Kazan in October 2024 and Tianjin in August 2025. Both sides expressed satisfaction at the steady resumption of people-to-people and cross-border exchanges, including the ongoing Kailash Mansarovar Yatra and border

trade, and through the three designated border trading passes." The MEA said, adding that the two sides also discussed bilateral, regional and international issues of mutual interest.

The Chinese Foreign Ministry, in a readout in Mandarin, said the two sides engaged in "in-depth discussions" on "advancing border demarcation negotiations, strengthening border control, improving mechanisms, and promoting cross-border cooperation".

"They reaffirmed their commitment to adhering to the political guiding principles reached in 2005, and to working in a spirit of mutual respect and understanding to leverage the Special Representatives' meeting mechanism to seek a fair, reasonable, and mutually acceptable comprehensive solution to the border issue. Both sides will continue to properly handle the border issue through dialogue and consultation, and jointly maintain peace and tranquillity along the border," it said.

It quoted Wang saying that China and India are important neighbours and representatives of major developing countries and emerging economies. "The healthy and stable development of China-India relations is in the fundamental interests of both peoples, meets the common aspirations of the nations in the Global South, and aligns with the trend of the times. China-India relations have transcended the bilateral scope and possess global and strategic significance."

EXPLAINED

The steps taken

Although troops are still massed along the LAC in eastern Ladakh, India and China have been taking a series of steps to restore ties that took a hit following Chinese incursions. These include direct flights, resumption of visas, easing of curbs on Chinese firms, revival of the pilgrimage to Kailash Mansarovar.

be bilateral meetings with the visiting leaders.

Xi comes at a time when some challenges have emerged on the bilateral front — on the issue of visas for Indian business persons travelling to China, and reports of tension along the LAC in Arunachal Pradesh.

Cricket

but thanks to Cricket Australia, it has given me another chance," Anyana, now 25 years old, told *The Indian Express*. Anyana, whose father Sanjay Bangar is a former India all-rounder and was also the batting coach of the men's team, earlier played age-group cricket for Mumbai along-side Test-capped Sarfaraz Khan and his brother Musheer Khan.

Anyana said she wrote to the BCCI last year to check about eligibility criteria for trans athletes but had not received a reply yet. In June this year, she reached out to Cricket Australia. In its reply sent on July 20, Cricket Australia told Anyana that while she could start playing community cricket immediately, she would have to fulfil testosterone-related eligibility criteria to qualify for "Elite Cricket" like Women's Big Bash League (WBBL).

Cricket Australia's "Transgender and Gender Diverse Players in Elite Cricket" policy requires a player's serum testosterone to be below 10 nmol/L (nanomoles per litre) for at least 12 months to be eligible to play.

In 2023, the ICC banned transgender players from the elite women's game if they have gone through male puberty.

A top BCCI official told *The Indian Express* that the board has no policy yet on trans women playing women's cricket. "When it comes to the ICC, they have said no, but I'm yet to decide what can be done in

Khargone

different judges pointed to the prosecution's failure to prove to a jury that the accused was questioned how the accused came to be implicated, and noted that the forensic evidence itself contradicted claims of the use of petrol bombs.

Asked whether the government will appeal against the acquittals or not, the prosecution department said they will first review the judgment.

Hostile witnesses, probe gaps

1 JUNE 13, 2025
The first case to see acquittals, on June 13, 2025, dealt with the burning down of an ancestral house belonging to Mahesh and Vijayalakshmi Mahajan in Khargone's Bhatwadi Mohalla.

The prosecution's case was that Soah, Wasim, Salim Khan (now deceased), and a juvenile had conspired and set alight the house using a petrol bomb, with the family putting its losses at Rs 90,000.

Last Saturday, speaking on the situation with China, External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar said, "I think we went through particularly bad patch between the summer of 2020 and the autumn of 2024, and that was primarily an outcome of the situation in the border areas... At the end of the day, peace and tranquillity in the border areas is a prerequisite for good relations, and the state of the border, to a very large measure, naturally would determine the state of the relations."

"Having said that, I think naturally, if assuming things are stable and the need is more cooperative, obviously, I mean we have very big economies, in many ways, we are markets to each other. We are part of the supply chain. They industrialised much faster and much bigger and much earlier, largely because of many of the policies we advocate," he said.

such cases. As this is the first time such a case has come up, the board is yet to take a stand. Especially on allowing them in domestic cricket," the BCCI official said.

Responding to Anyana's letter, Cricket Australia's Head of Integrity, Robert Hughes, said, "Until we hear from Cricket Australia, we remain eligible to participate in Premier Cricket competitions in any State or Territory of Australia. As Premier Cricket is classified as Community Cricket rather than Elite Cricket under the Policy, your participation in those competitions is not affected by this determination."

"Your eligibility for Elite Cricket from that date (March 2027) is conditional upon your providing a blood test upon your arrival in Australia confirming that your serum testosterone concentration remains below 10 nmol/L and that you continue to satisfy the Policy's eligibility requirements," he said.

"I genuinely couldn't believe that I'll be able to play again. Because of Cricket Australia and its progressive and inclusive policies, which focus on fairness and inclusion in women's sport for trans women, this is a huge step. I feel like I'm not just a player but an athlete like me who want to try but aren't doing because they have to either choose the sport or choose transition," Anyana said. While she is still recovering from the gender-affirming surgery, Anyana said she was in the process of finding a club in Australia to play for.

In social media post in June

investigating officer "has nowhere disclosed in her examination in chief how the number of accused increased from one unknown accused", and that "there is no evidence on record as to when, where, or how a criminal conspiracy was formed".

The electronic evidence fared no better. A pen drive said to contain footage of the arson was seized but never played before the court. The judge held that the prosecution could "deny no benefit from the pen drive", and added that even if it had been played, it would "not have advanced the prosecution's case", since Mahesh, who had produced the pen drive, made no statement about it in his testimony and — after being declared hostile — denied identifying any accused from the footage.

No certificate under Section 65B of the Indian Evidence Act, which deals with the admissibility of electronic records as evidence, was produced to authenticate the recording, and the prosecution offered no evidence that the pen drive had ever been played on a police computer or that anyone had identified the accused in it.

A set of photographs fared similarly. While a Section 65B certificate was submitted by a woman named Vaishnavi for the photographs, the prosecution did not call her as a witness. The judge only after being told riots talks about the device used to take the photographs, such as a mobile phone number, were missing.

The forensic findings undercut the prosecution theory directly. Investigators sent three exhibits to the Sagar laboratory — a glass bottle, burnt wooden remnants from the house and a burnt iron gas stove. The FSL report, quoted in the judgment, found that "no residues of inflammable petroleum hydrocarbons (petrol/diesel/kerosene oil) were detected in any of the articles".

2 OCTOBER 14, 2025

The second acquittal came in the form of the family of Mehroon B in Khargone's Anand Nagar locality. The prosecution's case was that

Ships

Greece, the Netherlands, South Korea, Singapore and Norway are also on the list. A Pakistan-flagged crude oil tanker is among those blacklisted.

Some of these vessels had also faced attacks around the Strait of Hormuz in the months since the West Asia war started. "In light of violations by certain vessels of the Iranian arrangements for transiting the Strait of Hormuz, these vessels will face restrictions in their future transits through Strait of Hormuz, such as fines, seizure, or confiscation," the PGSA said on X last Sunday. To avoid potential issues, it is necessary for cargo owners — to the destination or from the origin — to review the list of the vessels on the PGSA's website, it said.

"Vessels that, from this date onward, engage in ship-to-ship transfers, transshipment, etc., with vessels on this list will

themselves be added to this list. Additionally, vessels wishing to have their names removed from this list must submit their request on long-term charters specifically to info@pgsa.ir," the PGSA said.

The PGSA didn't elaborate on the alleged violations by the vessels, which include crude oil tankers, oil product tankers, LNG tankers, container ships and bulk carriers.

Disha is an LNG tanker chartered on a long-term basis by Petronet LNG, India's largest LNG importer, for bringing super-chilled natural gas. As per shipping databases, *Disha* is owned by the India LNG Transport Company No.1, which is a joint venture between state-owned Shipping Corporation of India (SCI) and a few foreign shipping companies. *Disha* sails under the flag of Malta, and the SCI serves as its commercial manager as well as its marine international safety manager.

At present, in view of the suspension in LNG supplies from

Qatar due to the West Asia conflict, Petronet LNG has suspended operations of *Disha* and two other LNG tankers that are on long-term charters specifically for bringing Qatar LNG, the company management had told reporters earlier this month. The three tankers made regular runs between India and Qatar before the war. Earlier, *Disha* was stranded in the Persian Gulf for over three months as vessel movements through Hormuz came to a near halt amid the conflict. It was finally able to cross Hormuz on June 15. As per shipping tracking data, *Disha* is stationed off the coast of Gujarat.

India-flagged *Maah Roos* is owned by Pune-based BG Shrike Construction Technology, while Mumbai-based Five Stars Shipping is listed as the bulk carrier commercial and international safety manager. As of Tuesday afternoon, the ship was at anchor off the Brazilian coast in South America, as per vessel tracking data.

Requests for comments from Petronet LNG and BG Shrike Construction Technology were not

immediately responded to. In a letter, the constituted authority had said that all ships waiting to transit Hormuz must seek its approval, and that it intended to charge fees for services like maritime security, navigation assistance, environmental protection, and insurance in the future. Tehran has also been insisting that vessels should transit the Strait using routings designated by it.

But the US and its regional allies have opposed Tehran's stance, encouraging vessels to use the Strait's waters hugging Oman as an alternative to Iran-designated shipping lanes, and without insisting that permission from the PGSA. The PGSA released this list of "non-compliant" vessels just days after the US threatened Iran with the "toughest sanctions in history".

Washington is also running out blockade on Iran-linked shipping in Hormuz region.

IIT-Delhi

sixth floor of a building on campus on Saturday.

On Tuesday, day 3 of the agitation, more than 500 students gathered inside the Lecture Hall Complex at the institute with another 2,000 gathered outside. The gates of the institute were secured, and no technical staff, visitors, or family members of students were allowed inside.

Through the previous night, students had held a candlelight vigil on campus. On Tuesday, before the administration conceded their demand on the inquiry committee, they had announced another night of protests and candlelight marches.

Students have stayed away from most classes since Monday. On Tuesday, the administration used megaphones to advise them that continued absence from classrooms could create difficulties in their course work.

The ongoing mobilisation is unusual at IIT-D, one of India's most celebrated educational institutions. Students are demanding accountability for what they say is the eighth suicide of a student on campus since 2023, and have refused to be pacified by the response from the institute.

Students have demanded the resignation of four IIT officials, an independent inquiry into Rishikesh's death, and

compensation of at least Rs 1 crore for his family. In response, the administration announced an inquiry and financial assistance for the student's family, but did not agree to the demands for resignations and a specific compensation.

At a meeting convened at the Lecture Hall Complex at 11.30 pm Monday, the students rejected the administration's response as "inadequate and evasive", and announced that the protest would continue.

On Tuesday morning, IIT-D Director Rangan Banerjee said that the External Inquiry Committee would investigate the "circumstances leading to the tragedy" of Rishikesh's death.

"The committee will discuss with relevant students, faculty and the concerned administrative offices, review protocols and processes, and make recommendations. The committee will request the complete its report within two weeks," Banerjee said.

The five-member inquiry panel comprised Ashok Kumar, the vice chancellor of the Sports University of Haryana who is an IIT-D alumnus and a former police chief of Uttarakhand; Dr. Anshu Sharma, head of the Department of Psychiatry at AIIMS, New Delhi; two student representatives, and the IIT-D Registrar who would be secretary and convener of the committee.

But the students objected to the presence of the former Uttarakhand DGP on the panel, saying he had earlier linked

death emerged in their testimonies against any accused". After they were declared hostile, "the prosecution derived no benefit," the court said, concluding that "the involvement of the accused persons in the offence neither disclosed nor proved in any manner".

Vaishnavi Jain was the only witness who claimed to identify all the 11 accused. But her testimony did not survive scrutiny as her own father, Dinesh Jain, and her brother, Akash Jain, told the court that the father had "their faces covered with cloth".

While Akash said he saw four-five people but could not identify them because of their faces being covered, Dinesh said he watched the mob from 500 to 600 metres away, had no prior acquaintance with them, and so could not be sure who the accused were.

The judge called it "not natural, satisfactory, or reliable" that a witness could identify individuals from behind at that distance, particularly once he had accepted the rioters' faces were covered.

There were also unexplained gaps in the investigation. Vaishnavi's name did not appear as an eyewitness in either the written complaint or the FIR, both of which were lodged two days after the riots — a delay the court said had "no explanation". Her statement was recorded 51 days after the incident. The FIR itself was only six days later, and eventually put on trial; the other five were added later, with the judgment finding no explanation on record for how or why.

The Sagar laboratory's report did not help the police case either, after it found "no residues of inflammable petroleum substances (petrol/diesel/kerosene)" in the seized bottles, fragments and burnt material.

The prosecution's task

Inspector B.L. Mandloi of the Khargone Kotwali Police Station has been supervising the riot cases, with a team of 10 officers, taking over from an STF that was disbanded after the initial investigation.

On why around 85 accused

still remain "absconding", Mandloi says: "We are facing difficulty as the accused names are generic, without any father's name or address. Incidents happened at 13 spots and we can't blindly implicate people. We have to match faces with the CCTV footage and CDR (Call Detail Record) details."

On the slow pace of the trials, Mandloi says: "In at least 23 cases, reports are still awaited from the State Forensic Science Laboratory in Sagur. We are trying to expedite that."

Khargone Superintendent of Police Ravindra Verma says they are trying their best to speed up trials. "I am taking stock and trying to track down the accused in all the cases."

In the Khargone District Court, where the cases are being heard, two special public prosecutors are "handling the complaints."

One of the two, refusing to be named, says: "The witnesses turned hostile since they all live in the same locality and now want to move on with their lives." Even if they provide protection to some witnesses, it is impossible to do so for "hundreds of people," he says. An Assistant District Prosecution Officer (ADPO) associated with the riots cases says he and others are tracking cases in the CJM Court, where the charge sheets are supposed to be filed. "In at least 15 cases I am tracking. The accused may yet be caught, all the residents have fled. These cases are under threat of having closure reports filed."

Another ADPO attached with a Sessions Court says: "We don't even have proper chambers or offices where we can call a witness before the trial to explain their statement to the court. They fail to properly depose and make material contradictions. In at least two-three cases that I am tracking, the accused failed to recollect their statements." The witnesses can hardly be faulted, the ADPO adds. "We can't expect them to have memories of the cases from four years and then recollect minute details of violence which took place one night."

Four years later, not much headway

The violence took place on Ram Navami, April 10, 2022
1 person killed

24 injured, including the district SP

16 houses and 29 shops demolished by the administration after the riot

175 people arrested in initial police action

4 closed for want of evidence

3 trials completed, all acquitted

85 accused yet to be found

23 cases awaiting forensic reports

THE CASES

65 FIRs

38 under investigation

20 at stage of evidence being recorded

THE HOLD-UP

85 accused yet to be found

23 cases awaiting forensic reports

Hasina Fakroo's house built under PMAY (Urban) was demolished. ANAND MOHANI



Hasina Fakroo's house built under PMAY (Urban) was demolished. ANAND MOHANI

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Key IFFCO Chowk road caves in, taps run dry in Gurgaon

Abhimanyu Hazarika
Gurgaon, August 25

WATERLOGGING ON roads and water shortage at homes — this is the double whammy many residents in Gurgaon are facing.

Even as Gurugram Metropolitan Development Authority (GMDA) resolved an initial disruption caused by a master pipeline leak near the key Basai water treatment plant last week, fresh damage caused by ongoing excavation work near Baani Square on Saturday compounded the city's water crisis over the weekend, according to officials. As a result, water supply across sectors 46, 48, 49, 50, 52, 56, 57, and 58 to 76 was affected over the weekend. Aggravating the issue, a section of a service road near IFFCO Chowk on the Delhi-Gurgaon Expressway was down on Tuesday, creating a gaping sinkhole and damaging a critical sewage pipeline.

This was a day after several parts in the Millennium City came to a halt as heavy rain led to waterlogging.

While further clarity was awaited from the GMDA, DLF's Facilities Management Team issued the following advisory to residents across Phases I-4: "As per the latest information received from GMDA officials, the master water supply line at IFFCO Chowk has been damaged, due to which the water supply in DLF City may be affected. The GMDA team is working on the repair on priority to restore the supply at the earliest. We will share further



A service road near IFFCO Chowk caved in on Tuesday. EXPRESS

updates. We request residents to use water judiciously during this period."

Authorities respond

Alerted to the cave-in at 3:15 pm on Tuesday, a team from the Gurugram Traffic Police, led by Traffic Inspector Mahabir Singh, reached within minutes, cordoned off the affected stretch using reflective barricades and signage to divert commuter movement away from the sinkhole, an officer said.

Subsequently, the Traffic Police alerted the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) and the Gurugram Metropolitan Development Authority (GMDA), and then technical teams rushed to the site to assess the subsidence, Singh told *The Indian Express*.

In a statement posted on X, the NHAI Delhi Regional Office noted: "Preliminary inspection indicates possible leakage from the GMDA sewer line beneath the location, resulting in soil erosion and road settlement." The highway authority added that the matter had been

taken up with the GMDA for immediate rectification. A joint engineering team from both agencies initiated inspection and immediate ground stabilization work, officials said.

The NHAI, late at night, added that the draining of the sinkhole is under progress with 4 tractor-mounted pumps, and that traffic has been diverted to another service road along the same section.

On Monday, the city received an average of 75 mm of rainfall, according to the district administration, leaving key intersections near Subhash Chowk, Rail Vihar, and the expressway inundated. The subsequent waterlogging trapped over a dozen school buses for hours, leaving school children stranded. The gridlock also forced the district administration to issue work-from-home advisories for private offices.

The Gurgaon district administration Tuesday invoked the Disaster Management Act to issue a comprehensive SOP regulating school transport during heavy rainfall.

'Millennium City not worth living in'

NEARLY A dozen school buses were stranded for hours in Gurgaon after torrential rain on Monday inundated key roads, including near Subhash Chowk and Rail Vihar. Siddharth Kasid (39), a resident of Unworld Gardens and an employee at a multinational investment bank, waded through waist-deep water on the highway to reach the buses and bring his five-year-old daughter and other children back to safety. He recounts the ordeal to *Abhimanyu Hazarika*.

My daughter studies in UKG. She returns home between 2:15 pm and 2:45 pm. Yesterday, given the downpour, we were expecting an early dispersal. I was working from home.

The school (Heritage Xperiential) sent an email around 12 pm (about an early dispersal). I kept tracking the school bus location on their app. When I went downstairs, the app showed the bus was 35 minutes away. I am a six-foot-tall and the water on the road reached my waist. Looking at the flooded stretch, I realised the bus was never going to make it here.

I kept thinking: How do I get there? We figured out that the bus was stuck in Rail Vihar. Coordinated with Meetu Gupta from our society whose daughter was also stuck. We called the bus driver and finally figured out its exact location. With one of my friends, I started walking on the highway. We were drenched. One of my

phones malfunctioned, and my wallet went for a toss. When we reached the spot, what we saw was harrowing. At least 10 buses were stranded in a row, and inside were very young children.

Because of the ongoing Metro construction, they have broken everything. The walk through the waterlogged debris, spanning more than half a kilometre, felt more intense and gruelling than a trek to Vaishno Devi. We located the bus. Meetu and I took our daughters out and started walking towards our society. I got calls from other parents asking for help. I turned back to get more children.

I brought about six to seven kids back, making them walk in a single line towards the society. I could not have let my kid or anyone else walk unattended and risk drowning. I had to tread treacherously to avoid open potholes; the whole of Gurgaon was an absolute mess. Older students from Class 7 and 8 held onto my hands and my T-shirt; others held their bags, and I carried my daughter in my arms. I dropped my daughter's bag and went back out to help others.

My daughter was terrified and exhausted. Looking at the flooded streets, she asked me innocently, "Is it Holli? Why is there water everywhere?" A moment later, she said, "I'm shivering and hungry," and it broke me. I felt an overwhelming sense of anger and help-

lessness. That anger was towards the authorities.

We pay hefty taxes and exorbitant school fees, and this is how the city is maintained? I hate it now. They should have issued proper warnings and managed the roads. The worst part of the ordeal was the helplessness inside those buses. For security reasons, the bus staff said they couldn't let anyone off without parental consent. I was ready to take the children safely to our society. There was a young UKG kid looking right at me, hoping I would take him out of that bus, but I didn't know his father personally. That broke my heart. That poor child was able to reach home only by 5:45 pm.

The entire rescue took me nearly 1.5 hours. With roads choked and people stranded everywhere, I left home at 2:20 pm and finally returned only at 4:40 pm. My wife was so worried that she, too, had stepped out and started walking towards Subhash Chowk despite the water being above waist level. Both of us were in shock.

The administration and schools showed a complete lack of empathy. There was no real-time communication; no one called or emailed to update us. Gurgaon is simply not worth living in anymore. My family goes through this hell every year despite the high taxes and the hefty rents. We are now seriously mulling moving out of Gurgaon.

Delhi plans to tackle 'legacy issues', focus on waterlogging

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 25



Delhi CM Rekha Gupta

A DAY after heavy rain led to massive waterlogging across Delhi, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta Tuesday took stock of the situation and said that her government is taking steps to address the legacy problems of the Capital with the Centre's cooperation.

Gupta said the city's drainage network is over 50 years old. "Over the past one-and-a-half years, the government has studied Delhi's long-standing problems and begun working on long-term solutions," she said.

Listing the steps taken so far, she mentioned the implementation of Rs 56,000-crore Drainage Master Plan. Longstanding issues related to water supply, sewerage, drainage and waterlogging — not only through temporary measures, but through modern infrastructure, technology, smart metering and real-time monitoring — are in focus, she said. The initiatives, Gupta said, would provide Delhi residents with better, more reliable and more accountable water and sewer services in the coming years.

Meanwhile, PMD minister Parvash Sahib Singh said the waterlogging incidents and hotspots have been reduced in com-

parison to previous years. He said that the traffic police identified 169 waterlogging spots in 2025. Of these, work is currently being carried out at 60 locations. Large drains are also being constructed under the Drainage Master Plan.

"At each spot, work is under progress. The situation is much better than previous years. Now, you do not see any vehicle submerged, despite the increasing population," Singh said, adding that long-term plans are being planned for 21 locations. He also said that if the accumulated water is cleared in 30 minutes, it is not considered waterlogging. "Waterlogging is when water is accumulated for one to two hours," he said.

The drainage network is being revamped as per the Drainage Masterplan, he underlined, adding that waterlogging will not be witnessed at a huge scale after the changes.

CAMPS HAVE TO BE VACATED IN 6 WEEKS

HC paves way for eviction of 700-odd families from slum near PM residence, appoints committee

Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, August 25

THE DELHI High Court on Tuesday granted the residents of the slum near the Prime Minister's Race Course Road residence six weeks' time to vacate their camps and move to Savda Ghevra where they are being rehoused.

The court's direction followed appeals by the slum dwellers. Spread across three camps, the slum is home to 700-odd families.

The division bench of Chief Justice D K Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia, while issuing the direction Tuesday, also constituted a committee headed by former Delhi district judge Man Mohan Sharma to monitor the rehabilitation. The seven-member committee, comprising high-ranking officials from various government authorities, shall "consistently monitor and supervise rehabilitation of the dwellers" ensure that the aims in this sensitive area, are promised to the slum dwellers by the government, with the term of the monitoring committee fixed for a period of six months. Delhi HC has also empowered the Committee Monitoring to issue directions to all the agencies concerned, "which may be required and deemed fit for the purposes of rehabilitating the dwellers of Jhuggi Jhopri bastis in a meaningful manner."

The court also directed the Delhi Urban Shelter Improve-

ment Board to "facilitate transportation of household articles/belongings" of the slum dwellers to Savda Ghevra. Raising their voices against the rehabilitation in Savda Ghevra, which is around 45 kilometres away from the slum, residents had said that the same will deprive them of their livelihoods, with most of them currently engaged in blue-collar jobs in the vicinity of the camps near the PM's residence. The dwellers had also alleged a lack of basic amenities, including schools, in Savda Ghevra.

It was the government's case that the eviction is necessary as "the location of the present camps is adjoining military installations." The government also highlighted a need to strengthen the defence infrastructure. It had said, "In the current global security situation, which involves increased threats and the risk of conflict or war-like conditions, the presence of unauthorised structures that pose a serious risk to national security, public safety, and the protection of vital installations." The government had initiated the process for their eviction in October last year.

The government, represented by ASG Chetan Sharma and the Centre's standing counsel Ashish Dixit has assured the slum's residents one metro card for a year, extendable up to three years, and free bus travel for one member per family for a year.

Govt plans water network upgrade with Rs 2.5k-cr loan

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 25

TOTAL water shortage and leakage, the Delhi government is planning major improvements in the Capital's water supply with the help of a Rs 2,500-crore loan extended by the Asian Development Bank (ADB), through the Union Finance Ministry, said Chief Minister Rekha Gupta Tuesday.

Under the initiative, the government is planning to set up 131 District Metered Areas (DMAs) — sections of water pipe network blocked off from other parts with closed valves — to track water entering the system, reaching consumers and being lost, she said.

ADB will fund 70 per cent of the projects, while the remaining 30 per cent will be funded by the Delhi government. DJB has approved Package-1, worth Rs 805 crore, and Package-2, worth Rs 935 crore, to improve water supply in the command area of the Wazirabad Water Treatment Plant, Gupta said.

The CM said "around 43.96 sq km, nine underground reservoir command areas and eight Assembly constituencies would

be brought under a modern water distribution system".

Around 836 km of water distribution network would be developed that would include nearly 570 km of new or replacement pipelines, Gupta said. She said the government aims at bringing non-revenue water down to 15 per cent through network rehabilitation, accurate metering, DMA-based monitoring and leakage reduction.

"Around 2.15 lakh household service connections would come under the project, with

100 per cent metering of consumer connections" she said.

Besides, she said the government is planning an investment of Rs 11,427 crore in two zones covering West and Southwest Delhi that will benefit around 36.4 lakh people by strengthening nearly 3,830 km of water network. Under the proposal, 25 per cent of funding would come from Centre, 25 per cent from Delhi government and the rest is proposed to be raised through loans, public-private partnership models.

One held for retired teacher's murder at Jangpura home

New Delhi: Four days after a 69-year-old woman was killed and her house ransacked in Jangpura's Pant Nagar, the police arrested a man from West Bengal's Cooch Behar on Tuesday. He is being brought to Delhi, an officer said.

The accused has been identified as Ashrif (24) who previously lived in Jangpura, the officer said. The accused had later shifted to Wazirabad.

An officer privy to investiga-

tion said that Ashrif was well versed with the topography of the area and was aware that the woman lived alone.

"His plan was to leave for Nepal ... He even met his mother who suspected that he had committed a crime. She had asked him to go to the police, but he fled," the officer added. Police said Ashrif had been involved in other cases in the past. He spent three years in jail for a burglary, they said. ENS

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Raebari Road Lucknow-226014
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RISHIKESH KUMAR OF BEGUSARAI IN BIHAR DIED BY SUICIDE AT IIT-DELHI ON SATURDAY

A poet who wrote of freedom: Friends, family struggle to cope with their loss

Sophiya Mathew, Jagmish & Himanshu Harsh
New Delhi, Patna, August 25

AMONG THE most vivid memories of Rishikesh Kumar was that his closest friends at IIT-Delhi carry it to him reciting *shayari*. He would do this in small groups, as well as at large events on campus.

"*Hanne kaafi duniya dekh hai*," he would sometimes tell his juniors in the smaller gatherings.

Rishikesh, who allegedly died by suicide on campus at IIT-Delhi on Saturday, was a compelling Hindi speaker, his friends said.

Even ordinary conversations with him could become so animated and absorbing that strangers would find themselves stopping to listen, they said.

In a statement, IIT-Delhi said Rishikesh had been struggling with his mental health for some time, and had received treatment in hospital. He had also withdrawn from two semesters.

Rishikesh wrote, signed and dated his poems in Hindi. At his last public poetry recital at Rachnashala Studio in Faridabad, the 31-year-old MSC physics



Protesters at IIT-Delhi on Tuesday; (above) Rishikesh with his family. EXPRESS

an All India Rank of 40 in the IIT-JAM examination.

He enrolled in the MSc Physics program at IIT-D in 2025. Alongside his studies, he spent years teaching science and mathematics, first as a freelance educator and later at a coaching institute in Patna, while also teaching online.

Five days before his death, he had received an offer for a permanent faculty position at Unacademy in Jodhpur, according to his brother Abhishek Kumar and mother Asha Poddar.

A dozen of Rishikesh's close batchmates met his mother on Sunday, the day after his death. They were silent at first, but then

the tears came in a flood, they said.

How could someone who was always there for others have found himself in need of help, and received so little of it? This is a question his close friends continue to be haunted by. "Bhai was very talented. No one can believe he's gone. He was my pillar of support," Rishikesh's elder brother, Abhishek Kumar (34), said. "I used to always swell with pride saying '*Chota bhai* is in IIT-D. It was his dream. Woh IIT ka hi deewana tha,' Abhishek said.

Following medical advice that Rishikesh remain under parental supervision, the brothers' mother, Asha Poddar, had been living with him in Katwaria Sarai in South Delhi for more than a month. On Friday night, Asha recalled, Rishikesh had held his head in both hands and cried. "*Maa, mere kaaran tumko torture haina pad raha hai. Mujhe aur nahi jena hai*," he told her. "You are having to suffer because of me. I do not want to live any longer." She had consoled him and told him they would go to hospital and continue his treatment.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Abetment of suicide: FIR filed

New Delhi: The Delhi Police have registered an FIR for abetment of suicide under Section 108 of BNS and launched a probe into the death by suicide of 31-year-old IIT student Rishikesh Kumar.

The FIR, which has been registered against "unknown," was filed against the evening of the incident, an officer said.

A police officer said that the college's chief security officer had reported the incident shortly after it had taken place on August 22.

The FIR was registered following directions from the Supreme Court-led National Task Force (NTF), constituted in March last year to address mental health concerns and prevent suicides in higher educational institutions.

"As per the NTF's recommendation, the Supreme Court directed higher educational institutions to immediately notify the local police about any unnatural death or suicide on campus. The local police must then investigate and submit a report to the court," the officer said. ENS

Double blow to Race Course Club in legal fight against eviction

Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, August 25

IN A setback to the Delhi Race Club, which is fighting to maintain a hold over nearly 53 acres of land in the heart of the Capital, the Supreme Court on Tuesday dismissed its appeal against a High Court order, which had vacated a stay on the eviction proceedings initiated by the Centre.

In another blow, a district court on Tuesday also refused to grant any interim stay on the eviction proceedings. The Estate Officer of the Land and Development Office (L&DO), which comes under the Union Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs, on August 11, issued an eviction order to the Club under the Public Premises (Eviction of Unauthorised Occupants) Act. It directed the club to vacate the premises within 15 days, terminating them to be "unauthorised occupant" of the land.

This order was challenged before the district court. The clubbing sought an interim stay on the eviction proceedings.

On Monday, while keeping the application on interim stay pending, Principal District and Sessions Judge Pitamber Dutt of Patiala court sought a response from the Centre and the Estate Officer on the Club's ap-

peal, keeping the matter for consideration on August 31.

On the other hand, the Club also had a plea pending before the SC, challenging the Delhi HC's decision to vacate the stay in April on eviction proceedings initiated by the government against the Club.

On Tuesday, the plea before the SC was heard by a bench of Justices Satish Chandra Sharma and Vik Singh. The bench, noting that an appeal is already pending before the district court, refused to entertain the plea. It, however, allowed the Club to approach the district court, seeking that the hearing be scheduled earlier.

Following the SC order, the district court heard the Club's interim stay application on Tuesday and refused to grant any relief, reasoning that the Club had "failed to make out any prima facie case" in its favour.

Opposing the Club's request for relief, the Centre, through its standing counsel Ashish Dixit, also pointed out that the Club was not complying with the premises minus any valid lease deed.

The Club, in possession of the land since 1926, was issued a show cause notice by the government for re-entry in 1999. Following a legal challenge, the notice was set aside by Delhi HC in 2012.

Delhi plans to make treated water must for construction

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 25

THE DELHI government is planning to make use of treated water mandatory for construction and horticulture activities under the Reclaimed Water Policy, 2016. Water Minister Parvash Sahib Singh said on Tuesday.

The Delhi Jal Board's (DJB) policy assumes significance, he added, because the Capital treats around 750 million gallons a day (MGD) of sewage sludge. After accounting for environmental flow, there are around 483 MGD available for reuse, only about 120 MGD is presently being reused.

"Around 350 MGD of treated waste water therefore remains available for beneficial reuse. Treated water will progressively replace potable water and groundwater for horticulture, construction, landscaping, washing, industrial cooling and other non-potable uses," said Singh. DJB is initiating detailed stakeholder discussions, said officials, adding that the policy will then be sent to the government for final approval, he added.

The policy was approved by the DJB's recent board meeting. As per the Minister, with new treatment plants under construction, the Capital's sewage treatment capacity will rise to 1,015 MGD.

The DJB also plans to notify areas around compliant sewage treatment plants and sewer networks to facilitate reliable use of treated water, he said.

As audit flags safety lapses, Govt planning Signature Bridge repair

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 25

WITH A recent structural audit highlighting that the iconic cable-stayed Signature Bridge in the Capital needs immediate repair, the Delhi government has ordered a comprehensive rehabilitation and maintenance plan for the city's first asymmetrical bridge.

According to officials, a detailed inspection and condition assessment of the bridge was carried out in July. The audit highlights the need to restore the Bridge Health Monitoring System (BHMS), which has been found largely non-functional, with several sensors damaged, missing or operating in passive mode.

A BHMS is an automated network of sensors and software used to assess the safety, structural integrity, and real-time response of bridges. The audit also flagged erosion and deterioration of foundation protection, particularly around the river-side. "As the underwater and subsurface portions could not be fully inspected due to safety and water-flow conditions, a detailed investigation has been recommended. Repair measures including debris and silt removal, restoration of damaged protective concrete and additional scour protection wherever required will be done," said an official.

The skywalk ramp steelwork has also emerged as a priority area, with severe corrosion, rust scaling, coating failure and cor-

rosion at joints, splices and fasteners highlighted. "Detailed assessment and rehabilitation of affected steelwork will be undertaken," the official added.

The audit also recommends for a proposed overhaul, including structural temperature, strain, wind displacement, acceleration, inclination, corrosion, traffic and force sensors, along with a new data-acquisition system and control-room setup.

The signature bridge was inaugurated in 2018. The construction was executed by the Delhi Tourism and Transport Development Corporation (DTTDC). Following the requests from the DTTDC, the bridge was handed over to PWD earlier this year.

PWD Minister Parvash Sahib Singh said, "Signature Bridge is one of Delhi's most important landmarks. It is important to recognise that the bridge was handed over to PWD only a few months ago, and our government is now addressing the maintenance requirements systematically.

Pointing that his government will not allow past gaps in maintenance to become future risks, Singh said, "A modern bridge cannot depend only on periodic visual inspections. We need technology to continuously tell us what is happening to the structure. Restoring the BHMS will give us real-time monitoring and allow engineers to identify potential issues much before they become serious."

Heaps of garbage cleared, body of teen found three days after he fell into drain

Mishal Mussaddique
New Delhi, August 25

HEAPS OF plastic bottles, construction debris, clothes, and tyres piled up over the years had a drain underneath. On Tuesday afternoon, the body of 15-year-old Mithun Kumar was recovered after part of the garbage clogging the drain in south-east Delhi was cleared.

Mithun, who studies in Class 8, had fallen into an open drain in Jasola, 500 metres away from this spot on August 22. Currents had swept his body to this spot where his body was recovered four days later on Tuesday.

Seeing his body, his mother Anitha collapsed and was taken away to a nearby tent by relatives and neighbours while his father Awadhesh, a labourer, rushed to make arrangements for an ambulance.

The wide drain in South-East Delhi's Jasola runs along the family's home, close to Shaheen Bagh police station. Residents, office-goers, and children walk by it every day.

On Saturday morning, Mithun fell into the drain while on his way to school, said his aunt and neighbour, Kusum. "My son and Mithun used to go to school together. Both his parents work, so they are not around most of the time. I just took my eyes off him for a second that morning. The next thing I heard was a child in the neighbourhood screaming 'Mithun has fallen'," Kusum said.

The search operations carried out by the National Dis-



Mithun Kumar's mother Anitha on Tuesday; (left) the dead body in Jasola. MISHAL MUSSADDIQUE

aster Response Force (NDRF), Delhi Fire Services (DFS) and the Delhi Disaster Management Authority (DDMA) entered the third day on Tuesday.

Frustrated by the lack of breakthrough in the operation, Mithun's father Awadhesh had entered the drain himself on Sunday and began removing the garbage with his hands — the image was heart-breaking.

"If they would have cleared this garbage on the first day itself, wouldn't he have been found then? I feel that he could even have been found alive," said the distraught father.

"Look at his mother's condition. My mother doesn't know she lost her grandson. She's already ill. How will I break the news to her?" Awadhesh said.

A district administration official said that there were several obstructions which delayed the recovery of the body. "The body was stuck in a swamp of clogged garbage and debris. Because of this, we had to make a path for the earth-mover to clear the garbage and this took time," he said.

After the body was recovered around 1:15 pm on Tuesday, it was sent to AIMS. The family hails from Uttar Pra-

des's Budaun. Mithun's final rites will be conducted in Banaur, they said.

Meanwhile, Delhi Jal Board (DJB) officials said that the open drain that the teen fell into carried treated effluents from the nearby Okhla Sewage Treatment Plant.

The drain was previously handled by the Delhi Development Authority and was later handed over to the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD).

On Monday, the MCD suspended a junior engineer over alleged "dereliction of duty". However, MCD officials, including the Deputy Commissioner of the South East Zone, did not respond to queries regarding the lapse they had identified.

Neighbours said that the large open drain flowing near their homes is a constant source of worry for them.

"Such drains have been clogged and haven't been cleared in ages. People walk by these daily without realising how dangerous they are," said Muhammad Amran (18), a neighbour.

"If the drain was clear and clean, this unfortunate incident wouldn't have happened. We ourselves would have rescued the boy," said Babar Khan, a resident of Shaheen Bagh.

On Sunday, while replying to a query sent by *The Indian Express*, the MCD had denied any involvement in the maintenance of the open drain and claimed that it was the Irrigation and Flood Control department's responsibility.

Rejig panel probing police excesses during CJP's NEET stir: Plea in top court

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 25

PETITIONERS SEEKING a probe into the alleged police crackdown on students at Jantar Mantar on Tuesday filed a plea in the Supreme Court (SC) seeking reconstitution of the High-Powered Enquiry Committee (HPEC) set up by it to probe the developments.

A three-judge bench presided over by Chief Justice Kant, however, said that the five-member HPEC headed by former Supreme Court judge R Subhash Reddy is working under the "direct supervision" of the SC. On August 18, the SC also appointed former Punjab and Haryana High Court Chief Justice Ravi Shankar Jha, former Delhi HC judge Justice Sanjay Kumar, former CBI Director Rishi Kumar Sharma and retired Director General of Police, Meghalaya, R B Bishnoi as members of HPEC.

Responding to submission made by the petitioners on Tuesday, the SC said, "Whosoever will work... they will work under the direct supervision of the SC. It's not that we have disposed of the matter. It's pending." Senior Advocate Gopal Sankaranarayanan, representing some petitioners, told the bench, also comprising Justices Jaymya Bagchi and V Mohana, "We have an application regarding the panel. Please list it next week."

● FOR GOPALAKRISHNAN NAIR, ONE OF DELHI'S OLDEST ONAM SADHYA CATERERS, SERVING THOUSANDS IS A BLEND OF PRECISION, TRADITION AND MEMORY

The making of Onam Sadhya: Serving authentic Keralam flavours for 20 years

Anusree KC
New Delhi, August 25

IT'S THAT time of the year! Feasting on traditional multi-course meals laid out on fresh banana leaves defines the Onam celebration for revellers. Salt goes down first, followed by banana chips and sharkara varatti, a sweet Keralam snack made from thick chunks of raw Nendran banana plantains, and pickles of raw mango or pulinji, a sweet-sour-spicy condiment made with tamarind and ginger paste, follows. Then comes the pachadis, a sweet-sour yogurt-based side dish with coconut paste as base; and kichadis, savory, tangy, curd-based side dish.

This is before the vegetable dishes gradually find their designated spot on the leaf — olan, a mild stew made out of ash

gourd; erissery, a curry made out of yellow pumpkin; or kootukari, a thick curry made with vegetables, black chickpeas and roasted coconuts; avial, a mixed vegetable stir fry. Only then does rice arrive, first with lentil or parippu curry and ginger eaten with crushed papad, followed by sambar, then rasam. Finally, comes the dessert — payasam, sweet and thick against the tongue.

Tradition on a platter

One of Delhi's oldest Onam Sadhya caterers, Gopalakrishnan Nair, who is now 74, came to the city at the age of 19. His love for cooking and passion for serving Keralam's tradition on a platter gradually turned him into a foodpreneur. For more than 20 years now, he has been serving Sadhya meals for wed-



Gopalakrishnan Nair preparing payasam for Onam Sadhya. EXPRESS

ding and during Onam celebrations. What started as a small business in 2005 has now been shaped into Taamra Weddings, at the Uttara Guruvayurappan Temple in East Delhi's Mayapuri Vihar Phase-I. Sadhya for Onam demands its own rhythm, he says. "Onam is not just a festival... It's an emotion. Anywhere in the world, even if just three Malayali families come together, it is celebrated with huge vigour," says Gopalakrishnan. For him and his staff, the work to prepare the Sadhya meals for thousands begins on the eve of Thiruvonam. Around 4 pm, his team begins chopping vegetables and preparing the ingredients needed through the night.

The ingredients come from different parts of the country. "The banana leaves come all the way from Tamil Nadu... the banana chips and sharkara varatti from Keralam, from Thrissur and Palakkad. Vegetables like ash gourd are sourced in bulk either from Azadpur, Ghazipur or Kalkaji markets in Delhi," says Gopalakrishnan.

At a large feast, guests are seated in batches, or panthi, with around 125 to 150 people eating at a time. Once one batch finishes, the team has about 20 to 25 minutes to reset before the next group arrives. All this while, the team has to be wary of showers as Onam falls during monsoon.

Kitchen calling Gopalakrishnan says he has mastered logistical precision over decades — his journey into catering began when he came to the Capital in 1970. A resident of Athani, a small town in Angamaly, Keralam, he was the eldest of 10 siblings. He left home in search of work, in order to look after his family. "One of my seniors from school and a dear

friend was working in Delhi. So I wrote to him to find me a job. I was young and eager to do anything. I packed my bags and boarded a train to Delhi. I didn't even know the local language back then," he recalls.

His friend, Parmeswaran Nair, helped him find a job as a cook at an eatery in Defence Colony. "Even though my father owned small hotel back home, I did not know much about cooking. But I knew I had it in me to learn how to cook. In a span of a few days, I learnt how to cook Dosa, Vada and Sambar," he recalls, adding that he was gradually learning the craft of cooking. "I had a good teacher, having perfected the recipe within a week. He adds, "There were no mixer grinder in those days. I had to grind the batter by hand on a stone. Before the shop opened at 7 am, everything had to be readied... sometimes my

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029v2VnR6RQJ0KH6oB0F> friend was working in Delhi. So I wrote to him to find me a job. I was young and eager to do anything. I packed my bags and boarded a train to Delhi. I didn't even know the local language back then," he recalls.

Eventually, Gopalakrishnan entered the corporate world. For many years, he worked as a salesperson with a firm linked to a Japanese brand. But the kitchen kept calling him back. In 2005, he started his first business venture, Pojara Caterers, which then became Taamra Weddings. Initially, he managed his job with the business, before eventually choosing catering full-time.

The orders grew from weddings and receptions to institutional kitchens. In 2010, he opened Kairali Restaurant in Mayapuri Vihar Phase I, which became known for its biryanis and home delivery. It was his son Sajeev who suggested that they close the restaurant and concentrate entirely on large-scale catering. At present, the father-son duo work on events that can involve thousands of people.



नरेन्द्र मोदी
प्रधानमंत्री



सत्यमेव जयते
दिल्ली सरकार



रेखा गुप्ता
मुख्यमंत्री, दिल्ली



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26 अगस्त, 2026 | तालकटोरा स्टेडियम, नई दिल्ली

मुख्य अतिथि

सरदार तरनजीत सिंह संधू

माननीय उपराज्यपाल, दिल्ली

श्री हर्ष मल्होत्रा

माननीय केंद्रीय राज्य मंत्री सड़क एवं परिवहन, भारत सरकार

अध्यक्षता

श्रीमती रेखा गुप्ता

माननीय मुख्यमंत्री, दिल्ली

महिला एवं बाल विकास विभाग, राष्ट्रीय राजधानी क्षेत्र, दिल्ली सरकार

Furnish detailed break-up of appeals before Bengal SIR tribunals: SC to EC

31 lakh of 38 lakh appeals against name inclusion in rolls: Lawyer for petitioners

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, August 25

THE SUPREME COURT Tuesday asked the Election Commission of India to furnish a detailed break-up of appeals before the appellate tribunals constituted to adjudicate cases of those wrongly excluded or included in the West Bengal Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise.

It sought details of the total number of cases pending, cases decided, appeals for inclusion and appeals for exclusion.

Meanwhile, petitioners who have challenged the SIR process told a three-judge bench led by CJI Surya Kant that a reply under the RTI Act showed that of "about 83,000" appeals decided by the tribunals, 75,443 had been restored in the electoral rolls. The bench, which included Justice Joyyama Bagchi and Justice V Mohana, sought to know what consequential steps were being taken for updating the electoral rolls pursuant to the orders allowing appeals.

Senior Advocate Gopal Sanakarayan, appearing for some of the petitioners, told the court that the RTI reply given to Real Creator IAS Edition https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Vn2rYR6dGJKH6d0f

a Member of Parliament "makes absolutely appalling reading". "This is the appellate tribunal report as on August 7. The total number of appeals submitted is 38,10,000. So far, about 83,000 or so are decisions which are finally (made). This may be about 2% of the total, but see the consequence. Just see the decision taken. Included in roll: 75,443."

"We have expressed our gratitude to the appellate tribunals. Your Lordship set up because were it not for that setting up of tribunals, all these people would have been disenfranchised, lost their chance to vote in the legislative Assembly polls, would have remained excluded and other proceedings would have been initiated against them. 75,443 have come in. In Jalpaiguri, 666 have been included in e-roll as a consequence of the appeal, 0 excluded." Pointing out that a huge chunk of the appeals were challenging the inclusion of names in the voter list, Sanakarayan urged the bench to direct the tribunals to prioritise the cases of those excluded.

"Of the total appeals filed, 7 lakh have been filed by individuals who have been removed from the rolls. The remaining 31



A reply under RTI Act shows that of 'about 83,000' appeals decided by tribunals, 75,443 restored in electoral rolls, petitioners told court. Real Creator IAS Edition https://lme/+2RVD_RG9mJlMzgi or 2RVD. And then we will take a call as to whether we prioritise the exclusion and then inclusion because an inclusion is not affecting an individual right, but an exclusion is denying a voting right. It will require some prioritisation. Nonetheless, it will bring down the burden (on the tribunals) to some extent."

CJI Kant said, "Some of the appeals could be cross-appeals also. Then one order impacts both appeals."

Senior Advocate Kalyan Bandyopadhyay, appearing for a TMC member, said a plea had been filed, pointing out that in 31 seats, BJP's winning margin against TMC in the recent Assembly polls was less than the deleted votes. He said that in

one constituency, the margin of loss was 401, and the deletions were 8,785. In another seat, the candidate lost by 15,000 votes and the deletion was 27,000. The CJI asked, "You may have filed an application, but can the court direct fresh elections like this?"

Justice Bagchi sought to know "how many of these deleted persons have filed appeal". The court, he said, is more concerned with the dealing of the deletion appeals by the tribunals.

Bandyopadhyay said the Commission is not putting out the information in public domain. "I am not getting any statistics from anywhere... The municipal poll is coming, they will not be able to cast votes. Then the panchayat poll is coming next year, they won't be able to cast votes. Then Lok Sabha polls in 2029." The CJI then said, "We are with you on this. At least before Lok Sabha elections, everything must be decided."

Bandyopadhyay urged the court to seek a report from the EC on appeals filed in the 31 constituencies. The CJI said, "We are concerned with all the pending appeals, not just in these 31... They need to be adjudicated in a time-bound manner. Last time also, we said, if need be, we will put in place more tribunals."

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Scrap caste census questionnaire, bring new one, Rahul and Kharge tell PM Modi

Asad Rehman
New Delhi, August 25

LEADERS OF Opposition in both Houses of Parliament Mallikarjun Kharge and Rahul Gandhi have written to Prime Minister Narendra Modi over caste census, demanding that the government scrap the existing questionnaire and formulate a new one after consulting stakeholders, including political parties, experts, and the general public.

In their joint letter, Kharge and Gandhi said they do not accept the caste census being conducted in the current manner and urged the Centre to take cues from the caste surveys of Telangana and Bihar. They said social justice policies in India cannot be effectively implemented without accurate data and a precise assessment of the numerical strength and socio-economic status of various castes is possible only if the caste enumeration is conducted.

"Your government has opted for an open-ended question format to record caste details in the census, which is misleading. Under this method, whatever name an individual provides for their caste will be recorded as it is." In India, the same caste is known by different names, sub-castes, and linguistic variations across regions, they added.

The Congress leaders said that if members of the same caste are recorded under different names during the Census, a single caste could end up being fragmented into the thousands of distinct names. This would result in a list of hundreds of thou-

sands of caste names, rendering the entire dataset obtained from the caste census useless. "If the actual population of a community is not accurately recorded, any assessment of its status will also be flawed. This will disadvantage backward, extremely backward, and other marginalised communities, and will impact decisions related to education, employment, welfare schemes, and social justice."

Most importantly, this approach will fail to reveal the size of the OBC population in India, as the term "backward class" is not even included in this census, the lettered. "An easy solution for this already exists: a drop-down list of castes should be created. This is the method adopted for the enumeration of SCs and STs. Such a list can be easily compiled based on existing government lists like those for socially and educationally backward classes and the list from the Anthropological Survey of India."

This same method was employed in the caste surveys conducted in Telangana and Bihar, they said. "We do not accept the caste census being conducted in the current manner. The government should scrap the existing questionnaire and formulate a new one after consulting political parties, experts, and the general public; this would ensure that the true numbers of every caste and community are revealed, making the caste census accurate, meaningful, and beneficial." Along with their letter, they enclosed copies of the caste list from the Telangana Caste Survey (2024) and the caste list from the Bihar Caste Survey (2022).

SC to set up special bench to hear Centre's plea on OBC creamy-layer criteria

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, August 25

THE SUPREME COURT on Tuesday agreed to consider setting up a special bench to hear the Centre's plea seeking clarification on the applicability of its March 11 judgment on OBC creamy-layer criteria to candidates of the Civil Services Examination (CSE) 2025.

The Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT) seeks directions allowing the government to proceed with service allocation of the 958 candidates recommended by the UPSC for CSE-2025 on the basis of the OBC creamy-layer determination applied before the March 11 verdict.

At the outset of day's proceedings, a bench comprising CJI Surya Kant and Justices Joyyama Bagchi and V Mohana was told by Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Centre, that the DoPT has filed a miscellaneous application in a disposed of matter seeking some urgent directions and it has to be decided before a bench headed by Justice P S Narasimha.

Senior Advocate Sanjay

Hegde, appearing for a litigant, said that a bench comprising Justices Narasimha and R Mahadevan had passed the order on March 11 and the instant miscellaneous application has to be heard by the same bench as the judges sit in different combinations now. "We will have to set up special bench," the CJI said, adding that he will speak with the judges and set up the bench.

The DoPT's plea arises from the SC's judgment in a case titled as Union of India vs Rohith Nathan, in which the court, on March 11 held, among other things, that the October 14, 2004, clarifying letter could not override the September 8, 1993, office memorandum governing identification of the OBC creamy layer.

The government, while stating that it is bound by the Supreme Court's ruling, has said that applying the judgment mechanically to CSE-2025 could result in unequal treatment of candidates who were similarly placed but acted differently based on the legal position prevailing when the examination was conducted.

1 bus, many factions: Rahul set for Punjab yatra amid Cong feud

Man Aman Singh Chhina
Chandigarh, August 25

FOR THE Congress, the road to next year's elections in Punjab has been a bumpy one for the past several weeks amid sustained infighting.

From AICC general secretary Bhupesh Baghel, in-charge of the state, being compared to a British colonial officer to former Chief Minister Charanjit Singh Channi being called a "BJP-RSS agent", the fight has been an especially unpleasant one. Now, to set his house in order, the party high command has pinned its hopes on a statewide journey that Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi is scheduled to undertake next month.

However, some in the party remain sceptical. "We are like a family WhatsApp group where everyone has muted each other," said a senior Congress leader. "Now someone has floated the bright idea to bundle everyone together in a bus and travel across the state. I don't know how this addresses the core issue of removing Amrinder Singh Raja Warring as PCC chief."

On Monday, former Chhattisgarh CM Baghel, whose recent visits to Punjab have coincided with intensification in the factional feud between the Channi and Warring camps, briefed Rahul and Wayanad MP Priyanka Gandhi in Delhi about the party's troubles in Punjab and the proposed bus drive.



Lok Sabha LoP Rahul Gandhi

"I met both Rahul Gandhi and Priyanka Gandhi. The main topic was the bus journey planned for Punjab. I wanted to seek permission for the tour, specifically setting the house in order, the party high command has pinned its hopes on a statewide journey that Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi is scheduled to undertake next month."

Sources said as tentative plans, Rahul will first pay obeisance at the Golden Temple in Amritsar before boarding what party optimists have billed the "unity express". The itinerary will cover a 135-km stretch from Amritsar towards Hussainiwala in the first phase, it is learnt.

Congress leaders said the bus yatra, in which all senior state leaders, including state LoP Parag Singh Bajwa, Channi, and Warring, are set to participate, would be a carefully choreographed show designed to convince voters, and perhaps party workers and leaders, that the deeply divided state unit had put the differences behind it.

Poll setbacks to Amritpal: Why BJP, SAD open to tie-up

Liz Mathew & Raakhi Jagga
New Delhi, Ludhiana, August 25

A DAY after asserting that the BJP would contest all 117 seats in Punjab on its own in the Assembly elections slated for early 2027, BJP national general secretary (organisation) B L Santhosh on Tuesday set out an action plan for the state party unit to strengthen the organisation at the booth level.

On Day 2 of his Punjab tour, Santhosh, while taking aim at the ruling AAP leadership, said, "The leaders who lost in Delhi are now running Punjab due to which the state development has come to a standstill. Punjab's industrial sector is witnessing large-scale migration. In contrast, development and progress are taking place in the BJP-ruled UP and Bihar."

Santhosh was addressing the state BJP's zonal meet in Ludhiana, which was attended by party leaders and workers from Ludhiana, Khanna, Jagraon, Moga, Ropar and Maleskot districts. "Driving the AAP out of Punjab and saving the state is the BJP's resolve," he said. Despite Santhosh's pitch for BJP's solo run in the upcoming Punjab polls, the party's backroom discussions for an alliance with the Sukhbir Badal-led Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) are continuing, insiders in the central BJP said.

"The discussions between the two parties are taking place at various levels, but not between the top leaders yet. We can announce a formal electoral



BJP general secretary (organisation) B L Santhosh and party's Punjab chief Kewal Singh Dhillon in Ludhiana, Tuesday. GURMEET SINGH

alliance after a final deal is clinched," a senior BJP leader said. "The mutual interests and compulsions could be a driving factor for both the sides to make efforts to stitch up an alliance which would be formidable."

Party insiders said that while Akali Dal, which has been grappling with challenges ranging from massive erosion in its support base to internal rebellion, are "desperate" to forge an alliance with the BJP, the latter is also conscious of the point that "it cannot win power in the border state without a formidable partner". With the SAD facing crises, Badals are said to be "keen" to join hands with BJP again. "Amid growing disquiet in his party, Sukhbir Badal really wants an alliance with BJP. Fighting alone in the 2027 polls would be a disaster for his party and its future," said a BJP leader.

The rise of Khadoor Sahib MP and Akali Dal (Waris Punjab) De) chief Amritpal Singh,

lodged in a jail in Amritsar's Dibrugarh, have posed a challenge to Badals, with a chunk of panthic votes, which forms the core base of the SAD, likely to shift to the former, BJP sources said.

The buzz about a renewed alignment between BJP and the Akali Dal intensified earlier this month when Sukhbir met Prime Minister Narendra Modi in Delhi during the just concluded monsoon session of Parliament. BJP sources admitted there are differences in the party on the alliance question, with a section arguing this would not help BJP as "Akali votes are not likely to be transferred to the party."

On the BJP-SAD alignment, a state BJP leader said, "The alliance doors are always open, but as of now we are going solo. Look at the extensive programme being planned in every booth, mandal and district." The newly appointed BJP general secretary in-charge of Punjab, Satish Poonia, may visit Punjab next week.

• TVK GOVERNMENT SAYS FERTILE FIELDS & VITAL WATER SYSTEMS CAN'T BE SACRIFICED FOR A RUNWAY; DMK WARNS ABANDONING PROJECT COULD PUSH CHENNAI'S AIRPORT PLANS BACK BY YEARS

Parandur airport: How a policy debate in TN turned into a 'sons-in-law' fight

Arun Janardhanan
Chennai, August 25

THE ARGUMENT was supposed to be about an airport—whether Tamil Nadu could afford to abandon a second airport planned at Parandur, whether its paddy fields and water bodies justified that decision, and where Chennai would find the land for another one.

Then R. Nirmal Kumar, Tamil Nadu's Energy and Law Minister, introduced a son-in-law. "If you look at all those who are now so worried and crying out here, it is for only one thing—either for getting a son-in-law, or for those who took black money there and invested it," he said. The reference was to V Sabareesan, son-in-law of former Chief Minister M K Stalin, whose name has repeatedly figured in political allegations surrounding

G Square, a real-estate company. Nirmal was suggesting that the anger over the TVK government's decision to scrap the Parandur airport was driven not by concern for Tamil Nadu's infrastructure but by financial interests around land. Across the aisle, Thangam Thennarasu, the former finance minister and veteran DMK leader who had been defending the project, rose rapidly to Instagram. TV channels cut vertical videos from Assembly exchanges, mistakes become memes before legislators have left Fort St George.

The House has acquired an audience, and it appears increasingly conscious of it. On Monday, Thennarasu, known for his soft tone and tenor, answered Nirmal in the language of the new medium. "If he wishes to take his reply and the debate to this level, I can also pay in the same currency," Thennarasu said. "If you are going to

begin live-streaming Assembly proceedings, citizens have been watching politics in numbers previously unusual for a state legislature. The August 5 Budget session drew over a million views on prominent YouTube streams alone unlike less than 20,000 views it used to gain on YouTube channels of private TV news channels. "Vijay versus dhyananidhi" clips migrated to Instagram. TV channels cut vertical videos from Assembly exchanges, mistakes become memes before legislators have left Fort St George.

The House has acquired an audience, and it appears increasingly conscious of it. On Monday, Thennarasu, known for his soft tone and tenor, answered Nirmal in the language of the new medium. "If he wishes to take his reply and the debate to this level, I can also pay in the same currency," Thennarasu said. "If you are going to



Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay with farmers protesting against Parandur airport project, at the Secretariat in Chennai on Tuesday. PTI

say 'G Square son-in-law', can I ask for which other 'lottery son-in-law' you are going to take the new airport? That reference was to Public Works Minister Aaditya Arjuna, son-in-law of lottery businessman Santiago Martin.

An infrastructure debate had briefly become a son-in-law exchange. But underneath the theatre was a serious disagreement over one of the most consequential

decisions of Vijay's young government. Nirmal challenged foundations of the previous government's case for Parandur. He said claims that environmental clearance had been obtained were wrong and that an Environmental Impact Assessment (EIA) had not been completed.

"There are a large number of water bodies there," he said, arguing that agricultural land

capable of three crop cycles was among the reasons the project had struggled to advance.

Thennarasu's reply moved the debate back from "sons-in-law" to runways. Parandur, he argued, was not chosen casually. Technical feasibility, high-tension power lines, industries requiring relocation, displacement and land cost were considered," Thennarasu said.

Parandur emerged from comparative studies and eventually received the Centre's nod. His larger argument was about time. "But after all these years of this project, after we have travelled this far, if you abandon it now, when is it ever going to come?" With compensation paid for much of the acquired patta land and acquisition substantially advanced, abandoning Parandur would work against the state's economic growth. Nor could Chennai's existing airport simply absorb

expansion without enormous demographic and geographical complications around Meenambakkam, he said.

Industries Minister S Keerthana then offered the government's most substantive defence of Vijay's decision. The land acquired would not be abandoned. Alternative industrial projects would be developed there "in a manner that doesn't affect the people," generating jobs and economic activity. But her case against an airport rested principally on what the land does. Parandur, she said, supports 3-season rice cultivation—Samba, Thaladi and Sornavari—along with groundnut, sugarcane, pulses and millets.

Farmers there supply rice to the state Civil Supplies Corporation and the public distribution system. "If you ask what kind of land this is, it is a place with perennial water availability—agricultural land where cultivation

can take place even when there is no rainfall," she said.

The Parandur debate is becoming very interesting. To one side, land appears on a planning map: acreage, connectivity, runway orientation, acquisition cost and future passenger capacity. To the other, the land appears as paddy, groundwater, canals, homes and memory. Both are descriptions of the same land. The government is in the uncomfortable business of deciding which reality appears a runway.

But Monday's debate revealed another transformation inside Fort St George. Legislative speech once travelled outward slowly through reporters' notebooks, eventually reaching the public in snippets and carefully selected political clips. Now, the citizen can watch the hesitation before an answer, the interruption, the laughter, the minister jumping up and the minister telling him to sit down. That changes politicians too.

RAIN, MISTY HILLS, AND CULTURAL THRILLS: DISCOVER GUJARAT'S MONSOON TOURISM

Beyond deserts and coasts, Gujarat comes alive during the rains with stunning green getaways.



For many travellers, Gujarat is synonymous with lions, heritage cities, the white desert and a vibrant coastline. Yet, with the arrival of the monsoon, the state reveals a completely different side. Hills disappear beneath drifting clouds, waterfalls spring to life, forests glow in countless shades of green, and ancient pilgrimage trails become some of the most scenic journeys in India.

From mist-covered hill stations and tranquil village retreats to sacred mountains and iconic landmarks, Gujarat's monsoon season offers a diverse range of scenic, cultural and spiritual experiences, attracting visitors to destinations across the state.



SAPUTARA MONSOON FESTIVAL



If there is one destination that truly captures the essence of the monsoon in Gujarat, it is Saputara. Nestled in the Sahyadri ranges of Gujarat's Dahod district, the state's only hill station transforms into a picturesque retreat during the rainy season. In FY 2025-26, it welcomed nearly 1190 lakh visitors. Enveloped in mist and surrounded by dense forests, Saputara offers the perfect balance of adventure and tranquility. Visitors can enjoy activities such as paragliding, ziplining and trekking, or simply take in panoramic views of cloud-covered valleys, rain-fed streams and lush green landscapes. Every bend in the road reveals another postcard-worthy vista. A short drive from Saputara, the Gira and Giramal Waterfalls are amongst some of Gujarat's most spectacular monsoon attractions. Together, they welcomed nearly 3 lakh visitors last year. As cascading waters plunge down rocky cliffs amid vibrant greenery, the waterfalls offer a captivating setting for photographers, nature lovers and families.

Those wishing to explore beyond the popular circuit can visit Don, Gujarat's highest village, which attracted over 1.80 lakh visitors last year. Surrounded by verdant hills, Don offers sweeping valley views, cool weather and an authentic countryside experience that provides a refreshing escape from city life.

Monsoon, Culture and the Soul of the DANCES

Monsoon in South Gujarat is beyond lush landscapes. Rather, it's a celebration of the region's rich culture, traditions and community life. During the season, Saputara's popular Monsoon Festival brings the region alive with vibrant tribal performances, local handicrafts, traditional music and authentic regional cuisine. The festival offers visitors a unique opportunity to experience the customs, artistry and cultural heritage of Gujarat's indigenous communities.

The journey becomes even more rewarding with several attractions nearby. The beautifully maintained Waghai Botanical Garden, the spiritually significant Shabari Dham and Pampa Sarovar, together welcomed over 6.45 lakh visitors last year, offer a serene blend of mythology, devotion and natural beauty.



OSAM HILLS

Where the Monsoon Meets Mythology

In the heart of Saurashtra, Osam Hills stands is one of Gujarat's most picturesque monsoon destinations. Steeped in Mahabharat mythology, the hills are believed to be where the five Pandavas stayed during their exile. Legends also speak of Bhim meeting Hidimbini (also known as Hidimbā) here, adding to the significance of this landscape. Surrounded by rolling grasslands, seasonal streams and mist-laden slopes, Osam Hills offers a refreshing retreat for nature lovers and trekking alike. During the monsoon, the landscape transforms into a lush green expanse, with cascading waterfalls and sweeping viewpoints, making Osam an

Beyond the Beaten Path: Gujarat's Hidden Green Escapes

Away from the well-known tourist circuits, Gujarat is home to a collection of lesser-explored destinations that come alive during monsoon.

Hafeshwar is one such gem, recognised by the Ministry of Tourism as one of India's Best Tourism Villages. Surrounded by tranquil waters, rolling hills and dense forests, Hafeshwar offers an authentic glimpse of rural Gujarat. Nearby Turkheda Hills provide spectacular viewpoints, made even more captivating as low-hanging clouds blanket the landscape. Further south, Wilson Hills offers one of Gujarat's most scenic monsoon drives. Welcoming nearly

3.80 lakh visitors last year, the hill station is known for its winding roads, breathtaking viewpoints and endless stretches of greenery. The journey itself becomes part of the experience, with mist-covered forests and sweeping vistas unfolding at every turn.

STATUE of UNITY

A Monument Surrounded by Nature's Splendour

Standing tall amidst the verdant Narmada Valley, the Statue of Unity continues to be one of India's most visited attractions, welcoming over 6785 lakh visitors during FY 2025-26. While the world's tallest statue remains the centrepiece, the destination has evolved into a complete family holiday experience. Visitors can stroll through the vibrant Valley of Flowers, discover rare species at the Cactus Garden, explore the Butterfly Garden, enjoy close encounters at the Jungle Safari and Animal Park, or experience the thrill of river rafting on the Narmada. During the monsoon, the entire region is transformed into a lush green landscape, with replenished water bodies creating a serene yet spectacular charm to the destination.



ideal destination for those seeking an offbeat escape away from the crowds.

Nature enthusiasts can also explore Polo Forest, which welcomed over 115 lakh visitors last year. Home to ancient temple ruins nestled amidst dense woodland, flowing streams and rich biodiversity, Polo Forest offers a captivating blend of history and nature, making it one of Gujarat's most enchanting monsoon destinations.

PAVAGADH

Spirituality Blends with Scenic Beauty

Few destinations capture the beauty of Gujarat during the monsoon quite like Pavagadh. Located within the UNESCO World Heritage Site of Champaner-Pavagadh Archaeological Park, the revered Mahakali Temple welcomed over 1 crore visitors last year, making it one of Gujarat's most visited pilgrimage destinations.

As monsoon clouds envelop the historic hill, the landscape is transformed by cascading waterfalls, lush greenery and centuries-old fortifications. Whether ascending by ropeway or along the traditional pathways, visitors get stunning views of rain-soaked valleys and historic monuments that dot the hillsides.

What sets Pavagadh apart is its seamless blend of spirituality, history and natural beauty. During the monsoon, every step unfolds as a journey through centuries of heritage, deep-rooted faith and some of Gujarat's most captivating landscapes.

UPARKOT FORT

Centuries of History, Cloaked in Monsoon Beauty

Just a short distance from Girnar stands the historic Uparkot Fort, one of Gujarat's oldest surviving fort complexes. The site witnessed a significant rise in tourism, welcoming over 515 lakh visitors during 2024-25. Dating back more than 11 lakh visitors in 2024-25. Dating back more than two millennia, Uparkot Fort is home to remarkable architectural landmarks, including Adi Kadi Vav, Navghan Kuvo, ancient Buddhist caves and imposing fort walls that narrate the story of a rich and enduring past.

The monsoon lends the fort a distinct charm. Moss-covered stone walls, rain-fed water structures and lush greenery create a captivating setting for exploration. From its elevated vantage points, visitors can take in sweeping views of Junagadh city and the mist-covered Girnar Hills beyond, making Uparkot one of Gujarat's most rewarding heritage destinations during the monsoon.

GUJARAT

A Monsoon Like No Other

While travellers often look to the Himalayas or the Western Ghats for their monsoon holidays, Gujarat offers an equally captivating alternative. Here, cloud-kissed hill stations, sacred mountains, heritage forts and world-famous landmarks come together to reveal a different side of the state during the rains.

It is a season when waterfalls cascade down verdant hills, forests come alive, pilgrimage routes become scenic journeys and every destination is transformed by the beauty of the monsoon. Whether seeking nature, culture, spirituality or adventure, visitors will find that Gujarat's monsoon destinations offer some of India's most memorable rainy-season experiences.

Traveler's Checklist: Monsoon Must-dos

- ☒ Experience tribal music, dance, and craft at the Saputara Monsoon Festival.
- ☒ Take a scenic drive to Gira and Giramal Waterfalls.
- ☒ Ride the ropeway up Pavagadh amidst drifting monsoon clouds.
- ☒ Try white-water river rafting on the Narmada River near the Statue of Unity.
- ☒ Trek the mythological, lush green trails of Osam Hills.

ISSUED BY GOVERNMENT OF GUJARAT



The Indian EXPRESS
— FOUNDED BY —
RAMNATH GOENKA
— IN 1932 —

BECAUSE THE TRUTH
INVOLVES US ALL

In Pune, a stage and a space, new and old

SPEAKING TO an audience of young women from a Pune stage, Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi said women should not be defined by their relationships with men because they belong to themselves. He spoke of routinised violence, including the “violence of denied opportunities”, and the “various forms of control” women are subjected to, daily. The formulations were not new — what was new and found resonance in the auditorium was that they were being articulated from a mainstream political stage, and Gandhi made room, on that stage, for women to tell their own stories. Of course, the Congress leader was not just tweaking the woman-unfriendly script in a male-dominated politics. He also used the post-Jantar Mantar occasion to make a jab at a political opponent pushed on the defensive. His mention of the Manusmriti, and UP Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath’s almost immediate counter-strike, showed that the mark had not been missed. But overall, the Pune performance opened up a space that, ironically, had once been made visible by Narendra Modi. In his very first 1-day address as Prime Minister in 2014, he asked why parents who impose restrictions on their daughters use a different yardstick for their sons: Have they ever asked their sons what they are doing, where they are going?

But if Rahul Gandhi struck a different note in Pune, his party, in the CWG, struck a different note on the national stage. The party will not versing all six starcast of “Vande Mataram”, the resolution said, only two songs, as it had decided to do in 1937. The old-ness of Congress’s new position comes not just from its attempt to turn back the clock. It comes, also, from the fact that it follows a stale Congress pattern — of scoring a secular point without really working for it. After all, what stopped the party from opposing the amendment that gives “Vande Mataram” the same statutory protections as the national anthem, in Parliament? In the Lok Sabha, the vote was 15-15, with the Congress in only about 15 minutes, after only two members spoke on it, and DMK was the only party that registered its criticism. Now, why does Congress not challenge the law in court, instead of sullenly refusing to? And what’s the playbook for its three CMs for official functions? Congress’s new and old politics comes at a time when the success of the students’ agitation is still rippling across parties. The crowds at Jantar Mantar have left behind a sense of new possibilities — and a dare for mainstream parties. The young have asserted their presence, they want to be heard, all parties must find new ways of seeing, new ways of listening, new ways of speaking.

Warmer oceans are sounding a warning

THE WORLD’S oceans are usually at their warmest in March and April. In March 2024, global sea-surface temperature simmered to a record 21.09 degrees Celsius. That high was surpassed last week. On August 22, a rapidly intensifying El Niño and global warming combined to spike marine temperature to 21.1 degrees Celsius. The new record, along with the upending of the ocean calendar, is a warning: Global heating is moving climate into unfamiliar territory. The last two months’ data indicates that what happened on August 22 was not an anomaly. June’s average sea surface temperature across the extra-polar oceans was the highest ever recorded for that month. The July record was also surpassed. By July 31, the oceans had heated to 0.04 degrees below the previous all-time high.

The oceans are among the greatest buffers against climate change. According to the IPCC and NASA, oceans absorbed more than 90 per cent of the excess heat generated by global warming and helped to delay its most catastrophic consequences. But this sequestering influence has come at a cost. Warming places stress on marine ecosystems, disrupts food webs. It also affects the oceans’ capacity to regulate weather. A heatwave has overwhelmed Europe this summer, several parts of India experienced floods even though the monsoon was erratic, and unseasonal snowfall disrupted life in South America. Ocean warming also contributes to sea-level rise. By the end of 2025, global average sea level was about 11 centimetres higher than in January 1993.

Every climate record strengthens the case for mitigation — cutting fossil-fuel consumption, accelerating the transition to clean energy and reducing greenhouse-gas emissions. That imperative remains important. However, even as emission reduction plans become more ambitious, adaptation to weather vagaries — which has historically played second fiddle to mitigation in climate policy — needs to be on a stronger footing. Even if emissions were brought down sharply, the consequences of past warming will take years to disappear. India, with a coastline of more than 10,000 km, needs to invest in protecting people who live along the shores, restoring natural barriers against raging waters, improving drainage in urban centres and developing climate-informed agriculture and water management systems. The challenge from the warming oceans is clear: Improving climate resilience cannot be postponed.

The ginger CFO of Gundavali Metro station

THE MOST recent entrant to the global ranks of cats with jobs is a ginger tabby usually found lounging at Mumbai’s Gundavali Metro station. After a commuter posted its photo on social media, tagging the Maha Mumbai Metro Operation Corporation, the organisation confirmed its appointment as Chief Feline Officer (CFO), responsible for “station inspections, commuter observation and sitting exactly where everyone can admire them”. Going by the surge in the CFO’s photographs online, on that last count at least, it’s a job well done.

The unnamed ginger of Gundavali will not be the only cat to take its CRA seriously. There’s Larry, the Chief Mouser of Number 10 Downing Street who, having suffered a prolonged whisper campaign about his laziness, set the record straight by killing and eating a mouse right in front of the reporters stationed outside his office for former PM Keir Starmer’s press conference. Palmerston, the late “diplo-cat” stationed in the UK’s Foreign and Commonwealth Office, developed a fearsome reputation as an efficient mouse catcher.

Mumbai Metro’s CFO can draw inspiration more directly from the evisceration of a rather staid cat, at a cat cafe, who lived up residence at a Japanese railway station in 2007 and stayed until the end of her ninth life in 2015. Tama, who was given the position of “honorary permanent station master”, attracted so many visitors that she was credited with boosting the revenues of the railway company — which had been in the red until then — by 10 per cent and putting it back on track. For the ginger cat of Gundavali, those are some big paw prints to follow.

THE MASTER Plan for Delhi 2047 (MPD-2047) sets out a new approach to how the city should grow over the next two decades. It seeks to accommodate 3.2 crore people and provide 40 lakh additional homes, much of this through redevelopment of existing areas and higher-density construction around public transport. Notably, it reduces the minimum area needed to redevelop housing complexes from 40,000 sq m to 3,000 sq m. This reduces the redevelopment threshold from about 10 acres to less than one acre, enabling regeneration at a much smaller and more manageable scale — from the size of a large housing colony to that of a small apartment complex. I support it.

Regeneration schemes in unauthorised colonies may receive a floor area ratio (FAR) of 350, while the High-Density Corridor along Urban Extension Road-II (UER-II) allows a FAR of 400. Both changes are necessary because Delhi has limited land and a growing population. Redevelopment cannot be based indefinitely on outward expansion. The proposals for affordable and rental housing, a Unified Metropolitan Transport Authority, unified parking management, and designated areas for 24-hour activity are also forward-looking.

Compact and mixed-use development along UER-II — a 75-km western arc from Alipur on National Highway 44 (NH-44) to Mahipalpur on National Highway 48 (NH-48), passing through Bawana, Rohini, Mundka, Bakkarwala (near Nangoli), Najafgarh and Dwarka — could expand housing and bring people closer to employment. But more floor space means more residents, vehicles, sewage, waste, and greater demand for water and electricity. Unless this is accounted for, new people will move to the al-

ready congested parts of Delhi in search of jobs, worsening the congestion. Planning must consider not just plot capacity but also the hinterland’s ability to support more livelihoods and visitors.

Years in administration taught me that constructing buildings is the easier part, particularly when private developers are involved. The harder task is expanding trunk water mains, arterial sewers, pumping stations, stormwater drains, substations, cables and public roads outside the colony gates. Gurugram provides an apt warning. Golf Course Road, lined by some of India’s most expensive gated communities, has repeatedly suffered waterlogging, showing that excellent private construction cannot compensate for inadequate public infrastructure.

MPD-2047 describes its approach as “infrastructure-led”, but its own water requirements reveal considerable uncertainty. It estimates potable-water demand of 1,600 million gallons a day (MGD) by 2047 against the present availability of about 1,000 MGD. The proposed augmentation of 401 MGD would still leave a gap of about 199 MGD. More importantly, 275 MGD is expected from the Renukaji, Lakhwar and Kishau projects, which the Plan itself calls “highly tentative” and dependent on interstate cooperation.

On drainage, too, the Plan isn’t clear. At one place, it says the Delhi Drainage Master Plan is under preparation; elsewhere, it calls for implementation of the Irrigation and Flood Control Department’s Drainage Master Plan. Before large-scale densification begins, Delhi needs to know which plan applies and what it reflects the new density projections.

While the new Master Plan



SHAILAJA CHANDRA

refers to upgrading physical and social infrastructure, it does not specify that essential infrastructure must precede development. Accepted planning practice requires the opposite: Before additional FAR is sanctioned, the capacity and land requirements for water, sewerage, drainage, power, roads, transport and public facilities should be assessed for the entire area under development. MPD-2047 should have made higher density conditional on these requirements being secured in advance.

More than 20 years ago, as Delhi’s chief secretary, I attended Raj Niwas meetings where DDA officers discussed issues related to the previous Master Plan. The departments handling water, sewerage, drainage and roads ran in their own worlds, oblivious to the DDA’s Master Plan. MPD-2047 has involved wider consultation, including with the principal implementing agencies. But consultation is not coordination. These bodies must agree on capacity addition, budgets, sequencing and timelines with one authority answerable for ensuring that the works are completed before high-density development begins.

The plan prioritises the regeneration of unauthorised colonies. That is a necessary, and humane, approach: Residents cannot indefinitely be denied safe buildings, sewers, drains and public facilities. But many existing structures predetermine effective structural, fire and seismic safeguards. Higher FAR must, therefore, be accompanied by credible safety audits, emergency access, open spaces and upgraded networks.

Preventing new unauthorised colonies is another urgent need. The plan proposes GIS mapping, remote sensing and drone surveys

to detect illegal development, and suggests disincentives against it. But detection is not enforcement. The Plan does not clearly identify which authority must act on the first alert, within what period, or what consequences follow when an illegal subdivision grows because of collusion or negligence. Unauthorised colonisation has proliferated over the last 60 years. Without a clear chain of responsibility, prevention in name could again lead to recurring amnesty when pressures mount.

MPD-2047 recognises the unequal distribution of Delhi’s green spaces and refers to green-blue infrastructure, parks, walking and cycling. Yet, as density rises, it sets no clear standard for access to usable neighbourhood green space. Parking reforms will achieve little if road parking remains free and pavements remain clogged. The Plan specifies how much more can be built, but is less precise about the public infrastructure and spaces that must accompany that growth.

How, then, should MPD-2047 be read? It is strong in recognising Delhi’s need for redevelopment, additional housing, public-transport-led growth and new economic activity. It is promising on rental housing, integrated mobility and regeneration. It is aspirational on parks, walking, cycling and public spaces, tentative on water and drainage, and incomplete on sequencing, enforcement and direct accountability.

This is not an argument against builders, migrants, high-rise housing or the improvement of unauthorised colonies. It is an argument for implementing the Plan in the right order. Before building higher, Delhi must first strengthen the city beneath its buildings.

The writer is former chief secretary, Delhi and former secretary, Ministry of Health

Simpler mining tax model can mean more revenue for states



S MAHENDRA DEV

IN SEPTEMBER 1974, at the Two Continents restaurant in Washington, economist Arthur Laffer drew a hump-shaped graph on a napkin to argue that tax rates and government revenue have an inverted-U relationship. His argument was simple: When governments cut high tax rates they have the potential to increase total revenue, while an increase of tax rates beyond a particular level would inversely reduce collections. Since then, the world has seen the Laffer Curve play out on multiple occasions.

In India, the most recent example of this was in the case of GST 2.0 where the rationalisation in tax rates further boosted demand, thereby increasing revenue collections. The recent passage of the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Act, 2026, in Parliament is another attempt at focusing on maximising revenue to states rather than increasing taxes, and adds to the mining reform journey that began 12 years ago.

India had the talent, enterprise and mineral wealth to grow. A missing element was a system that could unlock value. Before 2014, mineral blocks were allotted at discretion, approvals took years, and investors stayed away. India’s mining sector was a closed system, marked by opacity, inefficiency and corruption, with the burden ultimately falling on state finances. Today, every block is allocated through transparent, competitive auctions. Once allocated, progress is monitored end-to-end. There is a plan for the welfare of mining communities, for scientific closure of mines and a vision for sustainability. This shift from discretion to certainty is the same principle this Act now extends to taxation.

At the heart of this amendment is an effort for the establishment of a simple uniform and predictable tax system so that misaligned fiscal choices do not fracture the national market for minerals. Mining is a long-term, capital-intensive, and labour-intensive activity. For such an industry, certainty in the fiscal environment is a vital prerequisite.

Minerals are the building blocks of the wider economy. Critical minerals will increasingly determine our technological, Real Creator IAS Edition https://whatapp.com/channel/0029Vn2VrB6rGjOKH6oBd0F

energy and strategic capabilities. The Act enables the creation of an integrated national market for minerals. A strong cooperative federalism framework enables states to grow stronger as part of one national economy. A predictable fiscal framework will allow mineral-producing states to attract investment, expand production, and develop downstream industries, while giving businesses across the country greater certainty and competitiveness. Greater investment means more exploration, increased production, and expanded downstream industrial capacity.

Today, however, mineral producers face a complex fiscal landscape, with up to 14 types of taxes, charges, fees, and levies across different states. The recent legislation addresses this fragmentation. It will keep India’s mineral market integrated, protect essential sectors from uncompetitive taxation, and help mineral-rich states realise the full value of their resources. All this is being done by retaining the state’s own revenue pool from mineral production.

Mining reforms over the past 12 years have boosted the state’s mineral revenues. Since the auction regime began in 2015, states have received more than Rs 7 lakh crore, which is almost 90 per cent of total revenue, from both coal and non-coal sector, through royalty, auction premium, DMF and GST. The recent amendments retain this revenue-sharing formula with 90 per cent of every rupee earned from mineral production continuing to be retained by states.

Even with rich domestic resources, an uncompetitive mineral market can make India import-dependent. Therefore, national taxation is vital for conserving foreign exchange, strengthening our supply chains, and reducing dependence on imports, important in a world of geopolitical uncertainties.

India’s mining sector has moved decisively from a system of untapped potential to one of transparency, competition, investment, and national purpose. The task ahead is to build higher, to explore, produce, process more and add greater value within India.

The writer is chairperson, Economic Advisory Council to the Prime Minister



ABHINAV MOTHERAM

Fair pricing could help sustain UPI network

UP’S SCALE has made the question of who pays for it more important. Its success rests on a simple bargain: Consumers pay at no visible cost, merchants accept payments without card machines or a merchant discount rate (MDR). But as more companies absorb much of the expense, offset only partly by public subsidy. That arrangement is being reconsidered. A report tabled this month by the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Finance cited an industry estimate of about Rs 20,700 crore in annual operating costs, against a Rs 2,000 crore allocation under the zero-MDR regime. The Department of Financial Services said it was examining two options: Restoring MDR for certain high-threshold transactions or merchants, and phasing out government support through a tiered incentive structure.

India must decide how share the network’s costs according to capacity to pay. It must also decide how aggregated, privacy-safe payment signals can be put to public use under clear standards. Start with what drove adoption. My research with Sharon Buteau finds that more formalised merchant ecosystems are associated with higher UPI use. Once basic connectivity is in place, business ecosystem development matters more. That should guide how any MDR is designed. A fraction of a percentage point may be manageable for a supermarket chain, but consequential for a street vendor. It may barely register in districts where UPI acceptance is entrenched, but could slow merchant onboarding where the network is still forming. A uniform rate would misread both merchant and geographic asymmetries.

A workable principle follows: Keep UPI free for consumers and small merchants, while allowing a capped MDR for larger commercial users and higher-value transactions. Incentives should remain available where acceptance networks are still developing. The thresholds should be based on merchant margins, administrative feasibility and likely effects on local adoption. MDR need not be the only source of revenue. Firms can build commercial services around UPI while the underlying payment remains free. Payment data also has public value. At UPI’s scale, anonymised and aggregated transaction signals can indicate where spending is growing, adoption remains thin and formalisation may be taking root. PhonePe’s PulsePro is an example of how commercial payment intelligence can support public planning. A recent MoU with MetLife will integrate its metrics into PM Gatishakti for infrastructure planning, economic analysis and urban and rural development. Payment intelligence can identify where connectivity has outpaced merchant development, digital commerce has outpaced formalisation and infrastructure has not translated into women’s digital participation.

This is a start, but policymakers need an ecosystem-wide view. UPI data and official statistics can provide a clearer view of local commerce, including informal activity. India built UPI by combining public infrastructure with private innovation. The same principle should guide its use. Private firms can develop services, while public institutions set standards for privacy, access and public use. Fair pricing can help sustain the network; responsible data use can improve how India understands its local economies. Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RG9mlJmJg1 Motheram is consultant, NITI Aayog. Views are personal

40 YEARS AGO August 26, 1986



Volcanic gas kills 2,000

GAS SPOILING from a volcanic lake in north-western Cameroon killed at least 2,000 people and sent thousands of others fleeing for their lives, officials said. Soldiers in masks established the preliminary death toll as they made their way into the stricken region, the information minister, Georges Ngango, said.

Curfew in Shiddarbaha

TERRORISTS SHOT dead one person, while indefinite curfew was clamped in Shiddarbaha town of Faridkot district and the police

arrested two suspected terrorists in Amritsar. Curfew was clamped in Giddarbaha town as mobs turned violent after the cremation of two of the three victims of another terrorist shoot-out near Mosla.

Civil disobedience in Pakistan

OPPOSITION PARTIES said they would launch a nationwide civil disobedience campaign to oust President Zia-ul-Haq as the police continued to hunt and arrest opposition leaders. The Movement for the Restoration of Democracy (MRD) said in a statement that it would start a civil disobedience campaign in Sep-

tember to remove Gen Zia from power and force elections. Prime Minister Mohammad Khan Junejo ruled out early elections before the scheduled 1990 polls and said the government would not deal with the Opposition.

Vaidya case suspects arrested

TWO YOUTHS, suspected of involvement in the Vaidya assassination, were arrested by the Goa and Maharashtra police respectively. A 27-year-old whose description, as per the police, closely matches Sukhi, a member of the notorious Jinda gang, is in the custody of the Margao police awaiting identification.



Our Central Asia strategy needs less romance, more realism



RAJA MANDALA
BY C RAJA MOHAN

WHEN THE Soviet Union dissolved in 1991 and five new republics emerged in Central Asia, there was extraordinary enthusiasm in Delhi about reconnecting with a region that had deep historical ties with India. But India's lack of direct access, limited national capabilities, and persistent geopolitical headwinds have complicated that engagement.

India was not alone in imagining a grand reconnection between Central and South Asia. After the 9/11 attacks, the Bush administration bet that Afghanistan's long-term stability could be secured by reconnecting the two regions. In 2006, Washington reorganised the State Department to bring the Central Asian states together with Afghanistan and the Subcontinent in a new South and Central Asian bureau. The hope was that Afghanistan could become a natural bridge between the two regions. That vision proved difficult to realise amid Afghanistan's internal and external conflicts and the enduring tensions between India and Pakistan.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi, who travels to Central Asia this week for a bilateral visit to Uzbekistan and the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation summit in Kyrgyzstan, will find a region very different from the one he toured in 2015. Four broad trends stand out.

The first is the growing geopolitical agency of Central Asia. Long viewed as five vulnerable landlocked states — Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan — on the periphery of Russia and China, they are acquiring greater internal coherence. Since 2018, the five have met regularly at the summit level in the consultative meetings of the heads of state of Central Asia. They have now signed a friendship treaty among themselves and plan to give it some

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organisational substance and turn the region into a genuine Central Asian community. The Central Asia Five invited Azerbaijan to form the C-6 that links Central Asia more closely to the Caucasus and Türkiye.

Equally important has been the settlement of the long-running border disputes in the Fergana Valley among Uzbekistan, Kyrgyzstan, and Tajikistan. Growing intra-regional trade has reinforced the new political cooperation. Central Asia is becoming more of a region in its own right rather than merely the sum of five post-Soviet republics.

Second is the diversification of great-power relations. The traditional 'Great Game' framework — external powers competing for control over a passive Central Asia — is utterly inadequate. In 2025, Central Asian leaders held summits with the EU, China, Russia, the United States and Japan. Central Asia has never been more courted — and perhaps never less amenable to exclusive relationships.

Russia remains an important partner in security, but the Ukraine war and China's rising economic influence have weakened Moscow's former dominance. Washington has returned with a new emphasis on commerce, critical minerals and energy corridors. Europe, Japan and others are also expanding their engagement. Central Asia's answer

India cannot match China's infrastructure spending, Russia's geographic advantages or Türkiye's direct access across the Caspian. Nor does it need to. Sustained political attention should be matched by a practical economic agenda

is the familiar 'multi-vector' strategy — not unlike India's own multi-alignment. It engages all and commits exclusively to none.

The third trend is Central Asia's growing entanglement with the Greater Middle East. Although predominantly Muslim, the region's political and cultural orientation was long shaped by its Russian and Soviet past. That balance is changing. At the Central Asian summit with the US in Washington last November, Kazakhstan announced its accession to the Abraham Accords. Azerbaijan, Kazakhstan and Uzbekistan signed the charter of Trump's Board of Peace at Davos in January. Gulf capital has become increasingly important across Central Asia. Türkiye has transformed the Organisation of Turkic States from a largely cultural forum into an instrument for wider political, economic and defence cooperation.

The Iran war has complicated Central Asia's traditional southern access to the open seas and increased the importance of alternative routes westward across the Caspian towards Azerbaijan, Türkiye and the Mediterranean. The region's geopolitical horizons are widening well beyond the old Russian-Chinese framework.

Fourth is the diminution of the Afghan question. The much-feared export of revolution after the Taliban's

return to power five years ago has not materialised. Central Asian states including Tajikistan, which was most fearful of the Taliban, have moved towards pragmatic engagement with Kabul. Meanwhile, they have cracked down hard on the radical forces at home. But new problems are arising, for example on the management of the shared waters of Amu Darya.

Where does all this leave India? Delhi enjoys considerable goodwill in Central Asia, but geography continues to constrain its ambitions. India has no direct land access. Pakistan blocks the obvious overland route, while Afghanistan remains unstable. Chabahar and the International North-South Transport Corridor offered an alternative, but the growing conflict between Iran and the US has complicated their prospects. India's one hard-built connectivity node in the region now sits idle.

The changing regional dynamic therefore calls for a less romantic and more modern Indian approach.

India cannot match China's infrastructure spending, Russia's geographic advantages, Europe's financial resources or Türkiye's direct access across the Caspian. Nor does it need to. Sustained political attention should be matched by a practical economic agenda focused on areas where India can contribute. Delhi must also consider whether greater diplomatic flexibility towards Pakistan, Türkiye and Azerbaijan can improve its room for manoeuvre in the region.

Above all, India must recognise the political character of the new Central Asia. Its states do not want another patron; they want multiple partnerships that expand their room for manoeuvre. Modi's visit should be less about grand schemes and more about ensuring a modest, sustained and steadily expanding Indian presence in Central Asia that is increasingly confident of playing its own game.

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Repairing ties with Nepal: A strategy of two hands, 10 fingers



SAFI AHSAN RIZVI

NEPAL is scheduled to lose its Least Developed Country (LDC) status on November 24, but has sought a three-year deferral from the UN, citing delays in transition. While it is likely to receive the deferral, given Nepal's high credibility in the comity of nations, the deadline will come again. In 2024, it adopted the Smooth Transition Strategy (STS) to ensure sustainable graduation from LDC status by 2030, while recognising that remittances currently support consumption, reserves and imports, but have not yet engendered domestic investment or a surge in exports.

The appropriate move to further the STS could be a Nepal-India two-hand strategy: Economics and technology. Recent bilateral engagements appear to have eased aberrations in relations. Now is the most opportune time to jointly strive to move Nepal out of its low-investment, remittance-led growth, onto a higher, sustainable economic paradigm.

LDC status brought preferential tariffs, market access and concessional financing. Withdrawal would affect labour-intensive, high-growth export sectors such as garments, synthetic textiles and carpets. The WTO expects a -9 per cent increase in tariffs, while the UN's International Trade Centre estimates a loss of -4 per cent in exports. Nepal possesses two key safety valves to mitigate the impact. One, macroeconomic buffers stronger than many comparable economies, and two, bilateral tariff agreements with India, including the foundational agreement on a fixed NPNR rate of 1.6 since the 1990s. These factors have contributed to Nepal's monetary stability, especially during the Global Financial Crisis (2008), Taper Tantrum (2013), and the Covid pandemic (2020-21). Nepal has grown at about 4 per cent annually for three decades, supported by low debt, 18 months' worth of FX reserves and \$15bn in annual remittances. However, the most prominent risk to a promising economy remains its low-investment trap.

To diversify, Nepal opened up to the BRI in 2017, perhaps worried about over-dependence on its southern partner. It now conducts one-sixth of its trade, mostly imports, with and through China. However, Himalayan heights make northern connectivity expensive and prone to weather-related disruptions. Many China-backed projects are delayed, in contestation over the grants-versus-debt question.

India and Nepal have one of South Asia's most unusual relationships. Exceptionally intimate in geography and society, with an open border. The challenge is to embed arrangements that expand Nepal's choices while assuring India that intense economic and technology integration will not create new security vulnerabilities. The relationship should be seen through shared river basins, power grids and data flows. Indian policymakers must address Nepal's concern of economic dependence on a 'Big Brother' with care, humility and large-heartedness. The scars of the last decade have receded, given the political change in Nepal and multiple exchanges since May. The older ambition of progressing from free trade towards a customs union and eventually a common market is an unfinished strategic idea and must be the guiding ambition. India must be Nepal's most reliable partner, replacing perceptions of unfair dominance with the joint two-hand, 10-finger strategy. The economic hand: Stable rules for commerce; secure and smooth supply chains; single windows for PEVC funds; public and private JVs with balanced equity share; and a deeper Nepalese capital market. The technology hand: Optical fibre connectivity; interoperable digital public infrastructure; power transmission; space-tech; joint disaster risk reduction.

Three risks must be resolved simultaneously. First, over-securitising the border causes unnecessary impediments to legitimate access and trade and creates a rentier class and illegal trade. An open border need not be an insecure one. Technology and intelligence-led enforcement are the way. Second, reverse adverse perceptions that India turns economic dependence into a vulnerability through free travel, tourism, television, movies and music. Finally, 'death by process' should be put to death: A problem that is as old as the relationship itself.

Many fingers of the above formulation are already in effect. While high-level exchanges are limited, several important technical meetings on river waters, railway connectivity, customs, energy, borders, UP-NP payment mechanisms and technologies have been held. Momentum has been built and trust re-established. Speed is of the essence, with stability and continuity. India and Nepal will remain where they are, whether every argument is forgotten or amplified. What gets built in the meantime is the only variable. So let's put the two hands and 10 fingers to work.

The writer is a former IPS officer



LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Petty politics

DENYING CLEARANCE to Ravin Rishi after London and forcing him to skip Boston may be within MEA's remit, but weaponising small print looks petty ('It is wrong to cancel Telangana CM's US visit', IE, August 25). His itinerary, which included meetings with New York Mayor Zohran Mamdani and US Vice President JD Vance, was flagged as going beyond investment and education outreach. Yet a state that is attempting to build Hyderabad as a global hub needs wider doors. Curtailing an opposition chief minister makes the Centre look heavy-handed and sends a dispiriting signal at home and abroad.

— K Chandan Kumar, Bengaluru

Carney vs Trump

THE CONCLUDING part of the editorial — 'a middle power is saying no to a superpower a rare phenomenon in the Trump era' — says it all without mincing words ('In saying no to Trump, Carney does right thing', IE, August 25). Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney has dauntlessly called US President Donald Trump's bluff (read: Weaponisation of tariffs) by asking his negotiators to walk away from the ongoing trade talks. But the fact also remains that it may not turn out to be a cakewalk for Carney either. But then, for him, salvaging Canadian prestige and honour seems to outweigh even the impending costs of confrontation with Trump, the most unpredictable head of state the world over.

— Kumar Gupta, via email

CANADIAN PM Mark Carney said his country could not accept US terms for a trade deal, and would slap retaliatory tariffs on steel and dairy products in response to heavy duties imposed by Washington ('In saying no to Trump, Carney is doing the right thing', IE, August 25). Canada's response shows how countries navigate a world in which long-standing alliances offer less protection and economic ties themselves become sources of leverage.

— S S Paul, Nadia



SADAF HUSSAIN

IN 2014, I happened to be in Kerala for work during Onam. I did not know much about the festival then, and certainly did not know what awaited me when friends took me to a home in the neighbourhood for tea. A banana leaf was laid before me, glossy green and still wet from a rinse. Then came the food, ladled and spooned onto the leaf: Avial, olan, thoran, pachadi, pickles and curries sat next to warm rice. My friends guided me through what remains one of my most memorable meals.

And now, come Onam, the banana leaf becomes a familiar sight across Delhi. Restaurants prepare for packed sittings, home chefs open their kitchens, and WhatsApp groups begin exchanging recommendations on where to find the best sadya. Malaysians celebrating the festival are naturally at the heart of it, but around the tables are also non-Indian families, young diners who discovered the feast on Instagram, and food enthusiasts who have learnt to book well in advance. And then there is the trusted route into any regional cuisine, those incredible friends who know exactly where to eat a good sadya.

The scale is no longer anecdotal. In 2025, Kerala House in New Delhi planned to serve sadya to approximately 3,000 people over three days, or 800 to 900 people a day. Across Delhi-NCR in 2026, food guides listed at least 20 restaurants offering special Onam sadyas,

Delhi already understands this way of entering another community's celebration.

Durga Puja draws people who plan their pandal visits around Bengali food. Ramzan evenings send diners towards the old city

with spreads running to 20 or 30 preparations. A few years ago, Thomas Fenn, the co-founder of Mahabali in Saket, told *The Indian Express* 'Onam approaching, Delhi's restaurants and home chefs prepare to roll out sadya spread', August 29, 2022) that it was serving 350 to 400 festive meals a day.

Sadya's popularity also tells a longer story about Delhi's relationship with food from southern India. That relationship did not begin with the current crop of restaurateurs. Andhra Bhavan's canteen has been serving diners since 1991. The snaking lines outside it have been a familiar Delhi sight for years. Karnataka Food Centre in RK Puram has long had its weekend queues, while Kerala House's Samridhi canteen, operating since 2013, was serving 200 to 250 lunches on an ordinary day by 2019.

The change is also visible in how Delhi talks about food from the south. For years, idli, dosa, vada and sambar dominated the menu and the popular imagination. Now the city's appetite has widened. Appam, puttu, kothu parotta, gongura, pesaru, bisi bele bath or Mangalorean ghee roast are increasingly familiar. Even idli and dosa are no longer seen as one standard dish, with diners recognising different styles and regional variations.

Sadya is particularly good at opening that door because it refuses easy abbreviation. A single banana leaf can hold 20 to 30 preparations, bringing together different vegetables, grains, curries and payasams.

Sadya also brings people closer to the festival. Chef Marina Balakrishnan has described it as being 'beyond food', referring to the families and communities that come together around the meal. In Delhi, this extends beyond the Malayali community. For many diners, sadya becomes their introduction to Onam, the story of Mahabali, the pookalam, the banana leaf and the tradition of eating together.

Delhi already understands this way of entering another community's celebration. Durga Puja draws people who plan their pandal visits around Bengali food. Ramzan evenings send diners towards the old city's kebabs, breads and sweets. Onam is finding its own place in this shared festive calendar.

Food historian K T Achaya traced how what Indians eat carries histories of travel, trade and cultural exchange. Anthropologist Claude Lévi-Strauss saw food as a language through which societies express themselves. As a city discovers new food, it also begins to understand where it comes from, the traditions around it and the people who have created it with them. I arrived at my first sadya in Kerala without knowing what would land on the banana leaf. Today, thousands in Delhi seek out that leaf every Onam. In learning another region's food, a city also learns about the people who call it home.

Hussain is a chef and author

How to make a solar-heavy grid stable & affordable



**JAIDEEP SARASWAT
AND VRINDA GUPTA**

INDIA HAS become the world's third-largest installer of renewable energy, hitting its 50 per cent non-fossil capacity target five years early and setting a fresh goal of 60 per cent by 2035. The 500 GW target for 2030 looks achievable. India has solved the easier problem: building renewables at scale. The harder one is integration, keeping an increasingly solar- and wind-heavy grid stable and affordable.

Solar output peaks around midday, often when electricity consumption is low. This mismatch is driving renewable energy curtailment — the forced reduction of clean

power generation because the grid cannot absorb it. India reportedly curtailed over 8,000 million units of solar generation in the first half of 2026. Transmission bottlenecks contribute, but part of the problem is simpler: There is not enough demand when solar generation is at its highest. And unlike traditional thermal generators, solar and wind plants are inverter-based. As their share rises, grid operators must manage weaker grid conditions, reduced system inertia, and a need for flexible resources that can rapidly respond to changes in renewable generation.

The instinctive response is more battery storage, but the economics are still challenging. A recent Uttar Pradesh tender for four-hour battery storage came in at Rs 6.45 per unit, with under subsidy support. That compares with about Rs 4.67/kWh for coal power and Rs 3.65/kWh for solar alone. India needs

to broaden the conversation. The most effective battery may not always be a battery, but flexible demand and smarter electricity markets. The priority should be increasing electricity consumption when renewable generation is abundant. If surplus solar cannot be stored economically, it should be used productively. Industrial electrification offers an opportunity by creating large, predictable, daytime demand. Many industries want to procure renewable power but face a fragmented landscape of technology providers.

Solar output peaks around midday, often when electricity consumption is low. This mismatch is driving renewable energy curtailment

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RG9bnlJmZg1
financiers, and regulators. Specialised energy transition service providers can act as single-window facilitators, helping industries electrify processes, improve efficiency and procure renewable energy at scale. Most vehicles remain parked during daytime. Time-of-use tariffs can encourage charging when renewable power is plentiful, while workplace charging can turn office campuses into flexible demand centres.

India's rooftop solar programme has reached millions of households. The next phase should pair rooftop systems with small-scale storage and smart controls, enabling households to consume more of their solar generation and respond to grid conditions. Distributed flexibility can deliver system benefits at a lower cost than concentrating storage in a few utility-scale projects.

Rather than treating curtailment as a pol-

icy failure, India should develop market mechanisms that fairly compensate generators when their demand is required to reduce output to maintain system stability. Congestion management and balancing markets can improve predictability, reduce disputes, and offer flexibility. Success will depend on creating demand that follows renewable generation, mobilising distributed flexibility, and building markets that reward balancing. Getting it right would let India's renewable achievement double as a template for grid integration elsewhere, while embedding electrification as the default choice across industry, transport, and homes.

Saraswat is associate director, Clean Power, Electric Mobility and Emerging Technologies, and Gupta is associate director, Energy Transition at Vasudha Foundation

PM reviews cyber fraud cases, calls for building awareness

Express News Service New Delhi, August 25

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi on Tuesday reviewed cyber fraud cases, including incidents of digital arrest, and said that prevention must be strengthened through a sustained focus on training, awareness and education.

The review was done during the 53rd meeting of PRAGATI, the IT-enabled, multi-modal platform for Pro-Active Governance and Timely Implementation.

Chairing the PRAGATI meeting at Seva Teerth, Modi called for regular capacity-building of personnel involved so that emerging modes of cyber fraud are identified and acted upon swiftly.

"During the review of cyber fraud cases, Prime Minister stressed the need for continuous and targeted public-awareness campaigns, particularly for senior citizens, youth and other vulnerable sections, to help them avoid common fraud techniques, warning signs and safe digital practices. He also called for regular capacity-building of personnel involved so that emerging modes of cyber fraud are identified and acted upon swiftly," the Prime Minister's Office (PMO) said in a statement.

The Prime Minister also reviewed six key infrastructure projects across the Railway, Road and Power sectors, which are spread across several states and have a cumulative investment of more than Rs 30,000 crore, the PMO said.

"The projects, significant for strengthening the country's infrastructure, supporting industrial and economic activity and improving public services, were reviewed with particular emphasis on adherence to timelines, inter-agency coordination, resolution of pending issues and expeditious completion," the statement read.

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One-third of India in severe rain deficit as monsoon enters last leg

ANJALI MARAR Bengaluru, August 25

NEARLY 35 per cent of the country's geographical area remains in a significant rain deficit even as the southwest monsoon approaches its final leg.

The rainfall data maintained by the India Meteorological Department (IMD) stated that the country-wide rainfall for the season (since June 1) was 554.2mm — 13 per cent short of expected levels for this time of the year.

Notably, the cumulative rainfall departure from normal has consistently remained negative throughout this season.

That said, rainfall activity over the central region, between Odisha and Gujarat, has remained prominent during the July-August period, in part due to the recurrent development of low pressure systems in the Bay of Bengal and their subsequent landward movement.

"The spatial distribution of rainfall has been largely skewed, especially at district levels," said O P Sreejith, senior meteorologist at IMD.

About 412 districts across 14 states and Union territories in the south peninsula, northeast, and some parts of eastern and northwest India have recorded a deficit in rain — amounting to the aforementioned 35 per cent.

What is worrying is that even states that receive either extremely high or extremely low rainfall are experiencing below-average season rainfall this year.

For instance, Goa's normal rainfall till the third week of August is 2,562mm. However, this season (till August 24), it has recorded only 1,713.2mm — a deficit of 33 per cent.

Similarly, in Kerala, where normal rainfall for the same period is 1,671.4mm, only 1,283.3mm of rainfall has been recorded this season — a 23 per cent deficit; and in Punjab (normal rainfall is 338.2mm), 226.9mm — a 33 per cent deficit in the season so far.

Rajasthan's normal rainfall (till August 24) is 345mm. The desert state, where the monsoon arrives last and exits first, has received 268.3mm — a 22 per cent deficit.

Recently, Assam faced one of its worst floods, and yet, 19 of the state's 35 districts report a rain deficit.

In Meghalaya (— 58 per cent below normal), the southwest Khasi Hills district has either received no rainfall, while all the other 10 districts are either in rainfall deficit or 'large' deficit category (rainfall -60 to -99 per cent below normal).

Elsewhere, in Bihar, just three — Khatwa, Lakhisarai and Siwan — of the 35 districts have received normal rainfall. The others are experiencing a rain deficit this season.

Meanwhile, in Andhra, all the districts, including regions of Yanam and Rayalaseema, remain in a rain deficit. A contrasting picture prevails in the neighbouring Odisha, where all 30 districts have received normal or above rainfall this season.

The prevailing low pressure system over Jharkhand will keep the monsoon active over west Uttar Pradesh, west Madhya Pradesh and Chhattisgarh till August 29, as the IMD has forecast the system to move further north-west in the coming days. Konkani, Madhya Maharashtra, Marathwada in Maharashtra, Goa, Kerala, coastal Andhra Pradesh and the Gujarat region will experience widespread heavy spells till the end of this month, the IMD has forecast.

Emergency beacon of sunken ship, life boat recovered, but no clue of 22 sailors

SUJIT BISOI Bhubaneswar, August 25

THREE DAYS after a cargo ship sank off Odisha coast, an emergency beacon of the vessel and a lifeboat were recovered from the Bay of Bengal Tuesday. However there is no trace of the MV Ocean Winner crew.

Since Saturday night, the Indian Coast Guard has been conducting a search for the 22 of 24 missing crew members of the Panama-flagged cargo ship.

ICGS Varad patrol vessel of the Indian Coast Guard recovered an emergency beacon from the search area. On verification, it was confirmed to have been associated with MV Ocean Winner, said officials.

"During an aerial search, a naval aircraft detected a distress transmission and guided ICGS Varad towards the reported location. The ICGS Varad recovered the emergency beacon," said Coast Guard spokesperson Commandant Amit Uniyal.

The rescue team located the lifeboat at 7 am on Tuesday. A boarding team inspected the lifeboat; however, no survivors were found. Coast Guard sources also confirmed that the MRCC Beijing, the Maritime Search and Rescue Centre of China, has also been coordinating with the Indian Coast Guard in the search and rescue operation. It has deployed two of its merchant vessels to help intensify the operation.

According to officials, 20 of the 24 crew members of the ship, including the two survivors, are Chinese nationals. While three are from Myanmar, one is from Bangladesh.

"The search for the remaining missing crew members is continuing with sustained efforts, with Coast Guard assets, aircraft and merchant vessels maintaining an extensive search of the area," said Uniyal.

Additional Coast Guard assets and merchant vessels in the area are being deployed and coordinated to intensify the search operation. MV Ocean Winner sank around 230 nautical miles (425 km) from the Paradip coast of Odisha late on Sunday night. Officials said the vessel tilted and sank within eight minutes.

On the condition of the two rescued seafarers, an official source said they are on the Coast Guard ship and being brought back to the mainland. Officials said they are likely to be brought to Paradip from where they will be repatriated to China in coordination with the Chinese embassy. The Directorate of maritime administration, India's apex maritime regulatory body, may also record statements of the two rescued crew members.

UN panel flags 'human rights violations' in India, urges Delhi to suspend, review NRC

Express News Service New Delhi, August 25

A UNITED NATIONS (UN) human rights panel has raised concerns about violations against ethnic minorities in India, and urged New Delhi to protect them from alleged abuse, torture, extrajudicial killings, and stripping of citizenship.

In its report released Tuesday in Geneva, the UN Committee on the Elimination of Racial Discrimination (CERD) criticised the implementation of the National Register of Citizens (NRC) in Assam, and raised concerns about the subjecting of Bengali-speaking Muslims to "systematic and structural racial discrimination".

It called for the suspension of the NRC and urged New Delhi to review its legislative framework, and "urgently address discrimination, hate speech, and hate crimes against Rohingya, Bangladeshi-speaking Muslims, migrants, and asylum-seekers".

The Election Commission of India's Special Intensive Revision (SIR) process was also called out in the observations, with the committee raising concern that Bengali-speaking Muslim voters were reportedly disproportionately impacted in West Bengal and Assam.

Tender Notice No. 19 of 2026-27

Tender is invited by Executive Engineer, National Highway Division, Dr. Rajendra Prasad Road, Kashviwananah Plot, Rajkot, Ph.No.0281 2446605 as under. Tender Documents are available on web site mbnprocure.com and tender can be filled online only.

Sr.	Name of work	(1) Estd. Cost.	(2) EMD	(3) Tender Fee
1.	Collection of Toll From Toll Plaza Near Bamanbore Junction (By using Computerized Toll Collection System (ETC/ Manual System) and near Bagodara on Ahmedabad-Kandla Road NH - 47 (old NH - 8A)	(1) 29,54,82,500/- (2) 1,47,74,125/- (3) 18000/-		

Tender Documents & time table of E-Tendering will be available on above web site after 27/08/2026 and last date of submission bid online up to 28/09/2026. Any modification/correction will be displayed on website only.

INF-RAJ-744-26-27

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Raul Shaikh S/o Mr. Tarul Shaikh R/o Jhuggi No.42, JJ Colony, Bawana, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case registered vide FIR No. 528/2022 U/S 356/379/34 IPC, PS Kashmere Gate, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest their upon issued that the said accused Raul Shaikh can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said Raul Shaikh has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused Raul Shaikh of FIR No. 528/2022 U/S 356/379/34 IPC, PS Kashmere Gate, Delhi is required to appear before the court (or before me) to answer the complaint on or before the date of 05.10.2026.

By Order,
Sh. Vaibhav Garg
Judicial Magistrate First Class-11
(Central), Room No. 138
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/11430/N/2026(Court Matter)

BIHAR STATE POWER TRANSMISSION CO. LTD., PATNA
(A subsidiary company of Bihar State Power (Holding) Company Ltd., Patna)

CIN- U74110BR2012SC018889

Head Office, Vidyanagar, Bawana, Patna- 800021
Email address- operation.maint@bptcl.bihar.gov.in
Mob. No. 7763817721 Website- www.bpsptcl.in

Tender Notice (NIT) No. - 36/PR/BSPTCL/2026
(Through e-procurement mode only -www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in)

Online-Tenders are invited by Chief Engineer (O&M) for the following:-

Description of work	Estimated Cost (Rs.)	E.M.D. (Rs.)	Cost of B.O.Q. (Non-Refundable) (Rs.)	Bid Processing Fee (Rs.)	Completion period
Services of Drone for inspection and thorough patrolling of important Transmission lines in BSPTCL.	6.85 Cr	13,71,000	11,800	11,800	12 (Twelve) Months from NOA.

Start date of Online Sale of Bid Documents/ request of Bid Documents

From 11:00 Hrs. of 01.09.2026

Date of Pre-bid meeting

On 11:00 Hrs. of 08.09.2026

Last date of Online Submission of bid along with Tender Cost & processing fee

Up to 17:00 Hrs. of 22.09.2026

Last date of submission of EMD and hard copy of receipt of BSPTCL processing fee & tender cost

Up to 18:00 Hrs. of 22.09.2026

Date of opening of Techno-Commercial Bid (Part-I)

After 16:00 Hrs. of 23.09.2026

Date of opening of price part

To be notified after Technical Bid Evaluation (www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in)

1. The Cost of EMD may be paid through either Online or offline mode. In case, Cost of EMD is opted to be paid through Offline mode, Bank Guarantee/Demand Draft for EMD in favour of "Accounts Officer, BSPTCL, Patna" must be submitted to Chief Engineer (O&M), BSPTCL, Vidyanagar, Patna positively up to 18:00 Hrs. of 22.09.2026 failing which the tender shall be summarily rejected. For online submissions of Cost of EMD, bidder must submit details of intimation to this Office by 18:00 Hrs. of 22.09.2026.

E-tendering introduced in BSPTCL for tenders above Rs. 25 lacs. For registration link to www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in and E-procurement Help Desk Toll free No: 1800 572 6571, Email id: eproc2support@bhar.gov.in

Working Hours: 8AM to 7PM (All days in week except few selected state holidays).

While participating in e-tendering process, the contractor shall have to get their registered to get user ID, Passwords and digital signature. This will enable them to access the Website: www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in only.

For further details please visit website state.bihar.gov.in/prdbrhar

PR-010369 (B & C) 2026-27

नारी की मार, ब्याद कर सुखी परिवार

Chief Engineer (O&M)

BMSICL Bihar Medical Services & Infrastructure Corporation Limited,
3rd floor, Swasthya Bhawan, Behind IGIMS, Sheikhpura,
Adjacent to State Health Society, Patna 800014.
Phone/Fax: +91612 2383397, 91612 238338, Mo. No. 854402332, 997159020

Tender for the Procurement, Rate Contract and Supply of Medical Equipment for different Govt. Health Institutions of Bihar.

Notice Inviting Tender: No.-BMSICL/2026-27/ME-514

(Only through E-Tender on website-<https://eproc2.bihar.gov.in>)

The Bihar Medical Services and Infrastructure Corporation Limited, Patna invites e-bids from interested parties for Procurement, Rate Contract and supply of Medical Equipment for different Government Health Institutions of Bihar as listed below:-

Sl. No.	Equipment Name
1	Fluoride Ion Meter

Tender Schedule

Re-Tender Reference No. BMSICL/2026-27/ME-514

Date of Pre-Bid Meeting 01st September 2026 at 15:00 Hrs in Conference hall of BMSICL, 3rd Floor, Swasthya Bhawan, Behind IGIMS, Sheikhpura, Adjacent to State Health Society, Patna (Bihar) All Pre-bid queries to be submitted through e-mail on bmsicltendering@gmail.com upto 03rd September 2026 till 17:00 Hrs. (Note: No Pre-bid queries will be entertained after the above mentioned dead line)

Last date and time of submission of online bids 24th September 2026 upto 17:00 Hrs.

Last date and time for submission of original documents of EMD 25th September 2026 upto 14:00 Hrs.

Date, Time and Place of opening of Technical Bid 25th September 2026 (at 15:00 Hrs.) on the website of <https://eproc2.bihar.gov.in> the office of BMSICL

Date and time of opening of financial Bids To be announced later on <https://eproc2.bihar.gov.in>

Validity of Tender 180 Days

Cost of the tender document Rs.11,800/- (Eleven Thousand Eight Hundred Rupees only) Non-refundable.

Tender Processing Fee Rs. 590/- (on the website of <https://eproc2.bihar.gov.in>)

1. To participate in E-Tendering the tenderer will have to be registered with E-Tendering service provider. For this he/she has to submit the following documents: 2nd Floor, Canara Bank, Calcutta, Khajuraho, Ashiana road, P.S - Shastri Nagar, Patna-800014, Toll Free No.-18005726571; Email-ID: eproc2support@bhar.gov.in can be approached.

2. Any queries and questions regarding the tender should be addressed to MD BMSICL (either through letter or through e-mail- md-bmsicl-bih@nic.in or bmsicl.equipment@gmail.com or contact no. 9612-2219634/35) up to 7 days before closing of online bid registration.

3. All communication, addendum/corrigendum related to this tender will be issued on the website of <http://eproc2.bihar.gov.in>

4. Managing Director, BMSICL reserves the right to reject any or all the applications without GM (Procurement) BMSICL, Patna

PR. No. 010563 (B&C) 2026-27

For further details please visit : www.state.bihar.gov.in/prdbrhar

अगर मन में हो एच.आई.वी. अस्वा यौन रजित से से जुड़े सवाल तो तुम्हें 1097 पर कर कॉल।

DPHQ UDHAMPUR

No: CB/Look Out Notice/2026/57077-86 Dated: 24.08.2026

LOOK OUT NOTICE

As requested by Dy.SP Hqrs. Udhampur that on 21.08.2026, applicant namely Sukh Dai W/O Naresh Kumar R/O Sarosop No.1802/6, Dhandal, Tehsil Ramnagar District Udhampur lodged a missing report at P/S Udhampur to the effect that her son missing Gurdeep Singh, age 33 years is missing since 10/12 days. The applicant has conducted his search, but he has not been traced out. Accordingly, a missing report has been entered by P/S Udhampur vide DDR No. 23 dated 21.08.2026 and search started. The Photograph with descriptive roll of missing person is as under

Photo	Description :-
	Name:- Gurdeep Singh Age:- 33 yrs. Complexion:- Wheatish Height:- 5 feet & 7 inches Body built:- Healthy

It is therefore requested that a sharp lookout may please be maintained and if traced out or any clue leading to the whereabouts of said missing person is received an information may kindly be shared on the below mentioned Telephone Nos./Fax/e-mail address for further course of action.

Email: spoudh@jkpolice.gov.in
Fax: 01992-270027
Phone: 01992-2270210
PCR Udhampur: 01992-276915
P/S Udhampur: 01992-270725

Sd/-
RO NO. DIP/J-8800/26, DATED 25.08.2026. SSP Udhampur

GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA
OFFICE OF THE ADDITIONAL CHIEF ENGINEER,
P.H. CIRCLE, BHUBANESWAR.
Mobile No: -9437704019/7008499980
E-mail: sephbbsr@gmail.com

NATIONAL COMPETITIVE E-BIDDING SYSTEM (NCEBS) - Procurement
INVITATION FOR BIDS (IFB) NO. ACE/PC/PHBBSR-82-2026-27 Dt.28.08.2026

01	No of the work	01 No (One no work) Establishment Water Testing Lab at various WTPs and in the ULB having no WTP to ensure good quality drinking water under State Plan SULAIA
02	Estimate cost	Rs.624.76 Lakhs
03	Period of completion	60 (Sixty) Days
04	O & M Period	01 (One) Year
05	Class of contractor	Agencies/Firms having experience and expertise in Establishment of Water Testing Laboratories acceptable as per the NABE guidelines
06	Date & Time of availability of bid documents in the portal	From 11:00 AM of Dt.29.08.2026 to 5:00 PM of 17.09.2026
07	Last date / time of receipt of bids in the portal	5:00 PM of 17.09.2026
08	Last date & time of sealing / clarification	5:00 PM of 05.09.2026
09	Date & Time of opening of bids	At 12:30 PM of 18.09.2026
10	Name and Address of the Officer Inviting Bid	Additional Chief Engineer, P.H. Circle, Bhubaneswar

Further details can be seen from the e-Procurement portal "<https://www.tendersodisha.gov.in>"

Sd/-
Additional Chief Engineer
P.H. Circle, Bhubaneswar

OIPR-13001/130391/26-27/0002

दिल्ली भवन एवं अन्य सन्निर्माण श्रमिक कल्याण बोर्ड

Delhi Building & Other Construction Workers Welfare Board

ए' विंग, 7 वीं मंजिल, विकास भवन-II, सिविल लाइन्स, दिल्ली-110054

'A' Wing, 7th Floor, Vikas Bhawan-II, Civil Lines, Delhi-110054

Telephones-23813773, 23613045, E-mail- bchwq.del@gmail.com

NOTICE INVITING TENDER

Online bids are invited from eligible Central/State Public Sector Undertaking (PSUs) for selection as Project Implementing Agency for implementation of the Delhi Building Workers Health Scheme for registered beneficiaries of DBOCWW Board.

Interested PSUs may download the tender document, eligibility criteria, and terms & conditions from the GeM portal: www.gem.gov.in vide bid no. GEM/2026/B/7936479 DATED 20.08.2026.

Last date of submission: 31.08.2026

Sd/-
Secretary,
DIP/Shabdarth/Classified/0195/26-27
DBOCWW Board

Govt. of Bihar

Bihar State Text Book Publishing Corporation Ltd.

INVITATION FOR BIDS (IFB) Short E-Procurement Notice

Bihar State Text Book Publishing Corporation Ltd. invites e-tenders under the Two-Bid System on the Government of Bihar e-procurement platform from all eligible Offer Printers having infrastructure within the State of Bihar, as stipulated in the eligibility criteria of the tender document, for the printing and supply of Work Books and Unit Test Note Books, with delivery to all 38 District Headquarters of Bihar. Bidders are advised to refer to the bid document for details regarding the scope of work, estimated cost, applicable statutory charges, and the nature of printing services required.

The bidding process shall be conducted in accordance with the terms and conditions set forth in this Bid Document. The provisions of the Bihar Financial Rules, 1950, as amended from time to time, and the Bihar Purchase Preference Policy, 2024, as amended from time to time, shall be applicable.

Date Sheet and other details are given below:

No	Name of the work	Date & Time for Pre bid Meeting	Tender Fee/EMD	Online publication of bid document	Date & Time for Pre bid Meeting	Tender Fee/EMD	Online publication of bid document
1	Name of the work	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs
2	Tender Notice No	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs
3	Tender Fee/EMD	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs
4	Online publication of bid document	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs
5	Date & Time for Pre bid Meeting	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs
6	Tender Fee/EMD	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs
7	Online publication of bid document	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs
8	Date & Time for Pre bid Meeting	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs
9	Tender Fee/EMD	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs
10	Online publication of bid document	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs
11	Date & Time for Pre bid Meeting	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs	01.09.2026, 15:00 Hrs

1) Tender Processing Fee (Non-Refundable) Rs. 1,180/- (Rupees One Thousand One Hundred Eighty) only to be paid online.

2) EMD (Refundable) Rs. 3,00,000/- (Rupees Three Lakh) only to be paid in the form of Demand Draft/ Bank Guarantee/FDR issued by a Scheduled/Nationalized Bank in favour of Bihar State Text Book Publishing Corporation Ltd., Payable at Patna.

3) Tender Fee/EMD

4) Online publication of bid document

5) Date & Time for Pre bid Meeting

6) Tender Fee/EMD

7) Online publication of bid document

8) Date & Time for Pre bid Meeting

9) Tender Fee/EMD

10) Online publication of bid document

11) Date & Time for Pre bid Meeting

For further details please visit website state.bihar.gov.in/prdbrhar

PR-010571 (B & C) 2026-27

Managing Director

नारी की मार, ब्याद कर सुखी परिवार

Bihar State Text Book Publishing Corporation Ltd.

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Wasim S/o Shabbir R/o Alvi Nagar, Loni, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case registered vide FIR No. 41/2018 U/S 397/392/411/34 IPC & 275/45/59 Arms Act, PS Kashmere Gate, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest their upon issued that the said accused Wasim S/o Shabbir can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said Wasim S/o Shabbir has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused Wasim S/o Shabbir of FIR No. 41/2018 U/S 397/392/411/34 IPC & 275/45/59 Arms Act, PS Kashmere Gate, Delhi is required to appear before this court (or before me) to answer the complaint on or before the date of 29.10.2026 at 10:00 am.

By Order
Sh. Joginder Prakash Nahar
Additional Sessions Judge (CT)-01
Central, Room No.230
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DP/11631/N/2026(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

SEE SECTION 84 BHARTIYA NAGARI SURKSHA SANHITA

Whereas a complaint has been made before me that accused person namely Chandan Kapoor S/o Sh. Shyama @ Kamal Kapoor Raghuvver R/o H.No. B-59, Vijay Vihar, Ph-II, Rohini, B.D. Public School ke Samne Wali Gali, Delhi, have committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence under FIR No. 753/2016 Dt. 24.12.2016 U/S 498A/406 IPC., has been registered at PS: Sultampur, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said, Chandan Kapoor cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said, Chandan Kapoor has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused Said, Chandan Kapoor of FIR No. 753/2016 Dt. 24.12.2016 U/S 498A/406 IPC., has been registered at PS: Sultampur, Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before 05.10.2026.

By Order
Ms. Neha Goel
G.F., Room No. 18, Rohini Court Delhi

DP/11612/OD/2026
(Court Notice)

MM, (Mahila Court No.2), (North-West)

GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA TENDER NOTICE

Sl. No.	NAME OF THE WORK/NOTICE NUMBER	NAME OF THE WORK/NOTICE NUMBER	OPENING DATE AND TIME	AMOUNT / TENDR (IN HRS.)	MINUTE OF THE BOARD	NOTICE OFFICER/CONTACT PERSON
1.	HARYANA MEDICAL SERVICES CORPORATION LIMITED	NOTICE INVITING TENDER FOR THE SUPPLY OF MEDICAL EQUIPMENT AND AUTO CLIMATE LAMINATES ON 15 YEARS AUTO CONTRACT 44-INTENDING AGENTS WITHIN 15 DAYS OF REQUIREMENT.	28.08.2026 09.00.00	3,79,42,270/-	www.tendering.in	eprocurement@bhar.gov.in

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT : www.haryanaprocurement.gov.in or www.tenders.hry.nic.in

No. 48596/HHR

NORTHERN RAILWAY TENDER NOTICE

Invitation of Tender through E-Tendering (E-Procurement Systems)

Description	N.T.	29, 30, 31, 32, 42, 43, 44, 45 & 48-2026-27-WV
Annual Zone work for repair and maintenance of staff quarters and service buildings in GGN-RE section (East) and Rewari Local Heritage shed in the section of SSEW/IGNADEN/ADEN/DEE. Similar nature of work:- Any Civil work other than track work.	29	30
Annual zone work repair and maintenance of staff quarters and service buildings in the section of SSEW/DEE. Similar nature of work:- Any Civil work other than track work.	30	31
Annual zone work for repair & maintenance of staff quarters & supply of building material for day to day maintenance in the section of SSEW/IGNADEN/ADEN/DEE. Similar nature of work:- Any Civil work other than track work.	31	32
Annual zone work for repair and maintenance of the station building and service building at HZM & DSJ station in the section of SSEW/HZM/ADEN/DEE. Similar nature of work:- Any Civil work other than track work.	32	42
Annual zone works for repair and maintenance of the staff quarters and service building in the section of SSEW/HZM/ADEN/DEE. Similar nature of work:- Any Civil work other than track work.	42	43
Annual zone work for repair and maintenance of Staff Quarters & Supply of Building materials for day to day maintenance in the section of SSEW/TKD/ADEN/DEE. Similar nature of work:- Any Civil work other than track work.	43	44
Annual zone work repair and maintenance of station building and service building at DEE & DEC station in the section of SSEW/DEE/ADEN/DEE. Similar nature of work:- Any Civil work other than track work.	44	45
Annual zone works for repair and maintenance of the staff quarters and service building in the section of SSEW/HZM/ADEN/DEE. Similar nature of work:- Any Civil work other than track work.	45	48
New Delhi - Palwal-Tripura 19 km of IV line in section of Section of ADEN/TKD under S/DEW/IV. Similar nature of work:- CRT/RT/RT/RT/RT including raising of track, screening, de-bussing of track, pro & post works for track maintenance machine like lamping machines/ ballast screening/regulating machines & TTR by T-28.	48	

Approx. Cost of work

29	30	31	32	42	43	44	45	48
₹	₹	₹	₹	₹	₹	₹	₹	₹
6999999.50	5999998.35	8499996.72	8999991.05	6999980.78	10999989.82	5999970.07	6999995.70	34867462.02

(It should be in the form of net banking or payment gateway only. Note- FDR will not be accepted as tender invited on IREPS as per Railway Boards letter no 20/1025/CE-1/CT/1 dated 31.08.2016)

Earnest Money Deposit

29	30	31	32	42	43	44	45	48
₹ 145000.00	₹ 120000.00	₹ 170000.00	₹ 180000.00	₹ 140000.00	₹ 220000.00	₹ 120000.00	₹ 145000.00	₹ 697400.00

Period of work

29	30	31	32	42	43	44	45	48
12 Months	12 Months	12 Months	12 Months	12 Months	12 Months	12 Months	12 Months	09 Months

Date and time for submission of tender and opening of tender

Upto 15.00 hrs on 17.09.2026 Opening of tender at 15.00 hrs. on 17.09.2026

Website particulars notice board location complete details of tender can be seen. Above tender available on IREPS site and address of the office from where the tender form can be purchased etc. www.ireps.gov.in

No. 128-W/28/OET/2026-27-W/VNIT-28, 30, 31, 32, 42, 43, 44, 45 & 48-2026-27 Date: 25.08.2026

SERVING CUSTOMER WITH A SMILE

2953/2026

NORTHERN RAILWAY E-AUCTION NOTICE

The Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager/8, Northern Railway, Delhi Division, New Delhi invites e-Auction through IREPS (<https://ireps.gov.in/>) for allotment of contracts of General Minor Units (GMUs) and Special Minor Units (SMUs) for Catering Units at following railway stations/locations:

S.N.	Auction Catalogue No.	Date & Time for e-Auction	Railway Station	Lot No.	Type of Unit
1			Samalkha	Catg-DLI-SMK-GMU-87-25-1	
2			Okhla	Catg-DLI-OKA-GMU-170-25-1	
3			Tuglakabad	Catg-DLI-TKD-GMU-169-25-1	
4			Sampla	Catg-DLI-SPZ-GMU-150-25-1	
5				Catg-DLI-SPZ-GMU-149-25-1	
6			Mohiuddinpur	Catg-DLI-MUZ-GMU-154-25-1	
7			Mandawali Chander Vihar Halt	Catg-DLI-MWC-GMU-113-25-1	
8			Sujra Halt	Catg-DLI-SUJR-GMU-112-25-1	
9			Tilak Bridge	Catg-DLI-TKJ-GMU-111-25-1	
10			Taj Nagar	Catg-DLI-TNJR-GMU-176-25-1	
11			Patel Nagar	Catg-DLI-PTNR-GMU-142-25-1	
12			Sunehra	Catg-DLI-SFA-GMU-107-25-1	
13			Vivek Vihar	Catg-DLI-VVB-GMU-109-25-1	
14			Shahabad Markanda	Catg-DLI-SHDM-GMU-131-25-1	
15			Rathdhana	Catg-DLI-RDDE-GMU-155-25-1	
16			Muradnagar	Catg-DLI-MUD-GMU-91-25-1	
17			Uchana	Catg-DLI-UCA-GMU-110-25-1	
18			Partapur	Catg-DLI-PRTP-GMU-156-25-1	
19			Daya Basti	Catg-DLI-DBSI-GMU-116-25-1	
20			Delhi Azadpur	Catg-DLI-DAZ-SMU-122-25-1	
21			Palwal	Catg-DLI-PWL-SMU-166-25-1	
22			Tuglakabad	Catg-DLI-TKD-SMU-117-25-1	

Website particulars where complete details of E-Auction can be seen <https://ireps.gov.in/> (E-Auction-Leasing)

All contractors who intend to participate in the e-auctions conducted through E-Auction Leasing module of IREPS should fulfil following mandatory requirements before they can submit their bids:

- Registration on IREPS for E-Auction Leasing module – Active IREPS User Account for E-Auction Leasing Module.
- Payment of One Time Registration Fee; Current Account in State Bank of India; Integration of SBI Bank Account with IREPS Account; Lien Marking of Funds; Updates of Turnover Details.
- A new mechanism namely **Virtual Account Number (VAN)** has been introduced now for E-Auction Leasing module, which can be used by the bidders as an alternative to Lien Marking Mechanism.
- The bidders are free to switch between Lien Marking Mechanism (if activated) and VAN mechanism at any point of time, before entering the bidding room. VAN mechanism does not require the bidder to have a current account in State Bank of India. The users are free to transfer money from any of their existing bank accounts in any bank to their VAN account, which enables them to participate in IREPS E-Auctions.
- Contractors who do not have IREPS account for any module of IREPS can

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If there are questions of current or contemporary relevance that you would like explained, please write to explained@indianexpress.com

CORPORATE

What the \$1.5-bn TCS-Porsche deal says about Indian IT sector's health

George Mathew
Mumbai, August 25

AS THE Artificial Intelligence (AI) boom sends tech stock valuations soaring, most leading brokerages have taken a contrary view of India's IT sector and its readiness to tap into the AI opportunity window. Over the past months though, IT companies based in India, home to the world's largest pool of software engineers, have mounted a small fightback, largely through the inorganic acquisition or foreign partnership route. Does it mean Indian IT companies have suddenly returned to a boom cycle?

What is the latest such deal?

A move by India's largest IT company, Tata Consultancy Services (TCS), to strike a strategic partnership with German sports car maker Porsche AG to offer AI services across its mobility value chain is the latest such deal. TCS will establish a dedicated AI Mobility Centre of Excellence for Porsche to drive innovation across manufacturing, engineering, operations and customer experience. The idea that TCS will "industrialise AI at scale" for Porsche is a reputational boost for the software maker.

Over the last 24 months, other major Indian IT firms, including Wipro, HCL Tech and Infosys, have also signed high-profile deals in the West.

THE DEALS

Over the last 24 months, major Indian IT companies have signed high-profile deals in the West.

While TCS's deal with Porsche AG is worth \$1.25 billion (around \$1.5 bn), Infosys has a \$1.2-bn deal with Microsoft, and Wipro has a \$1.1-bn deal with NHS Business Services.

Wipro has a deal with the Olan Group worth around \$1 bn, while HCL Tech has signed a \$114-bn contract with an unnamed European company.

have been dealing with cautious client spending, delayed discretionary projects, high interest rates and, increasingly, uncertainty over what generative AI means for traditional application-development and outsourcing work, according to analysts.

The bottom line is that clients are cutting or scrutinising ordinary IT spending, but they are still funding large projects that promise cost reduction, automation, AI adoption and business transformation.

Will this boost revenue, profits?

The enormous contract values can be misleading. A \$1.2 billion contract doesn't mean the IT company gets \$1 billion of revenue immediately. For example, Infosys's \$1.2-billion NHS contract is spread over 15 years. That's roughly \$80 million a year on a simple average basis, before considering the actual revenue-recognition structure.

"Indian IT companies can win spectacular contracts and still report mediocre growth for several quarters. This is because after contract signing, transition, implementation, revenue recognition and margin contribution take time. And large deals often involve substantial upfront investment in hiring, training, transition, platforms and acquisitions," said an analyst.

The real question for investors is not whether Indian IT companies are winning billion-dollar contracts, but whether those wins are translating into a genuine and sustained recovery.

"For a genuine IT-sector recovery, I would want to see three things: deals wins translating into sustained revenue growth, margins improving despite AI-related pricing pressure and clients increasing discretionary technology spending rather than merely spending on cost-cutting or mandatory transformation," an analyst said.

Until those trends become visible, these billion-dollar contracts are best viewed as green shoots rather than proof that the Indian IT boom has returned.

Background of the case

The petitioner, a minor student at a school in Prayagraj, had studied there from Class VI to Class X wearing a headscarf, with photographs and ID cards on record

showing her in uniform, scarf included, through those years. She argued that she had worn a headscarf throughout her years at the school without objection and sought permission to continue doing so.

The school said that the scarf violated the dress code and that other students from her own religious community followed the code without it. Admitting her with the scarf would affect "the administration of the School".

The Assistant District Inspector of Schools, in a report to the District Magistrate, noted that the school is self-financed and has autonomy over its internal discipline and dress code.

The student, who belongs to the Muslim Shia community, told the court the scarf is part of her faith. She pointed out that the school allows students to wear "formal and decent" attire and argued that singling out the scarf effectively treated it as improper. She said that such refusal violates her right to free expression under Article 19(1)(a) and

and institutional identity," the choice of uniform lies primarily with the school.

On the religious claim, the court described the petitioner's case as a "bare assertion". It noted that no authoritative religious text, expert material or other evidence had been placed on record to establish that wearing a headscarf inside the classroom was obligatory upon her or that not doing so would alter the fundamental character of her faith.

The petition, the court observed, relied largely on the fact that she had worn the headscarf since childhood and throughout her years at the school.

The court also noted that in the photographs placed on record, no other girl student was wearing a headscarf, including students whom the school said belonged to the same religious community as the petitioner.

It held that permitting students to depart from a prescribed uniform, "even a little bit... would militate against the idea of a uniform. It would transfer the authority

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GOVERNANCE

Why govt jobs are few: The narrow selection pipeline



SHYAMIMAL YADAV

THE DREAM of a *sarkari naukri* (government job) holds a powerful draw in India. Every year, crores of people apply for a far fewer number of job vacancies in the central and state governments.

Behind this appeal — among youth, technocrats, and even those in professions such as medical and engineering — are economic realities such as the lack of private jobs, social psychology and career benefits that private-sector employment can rarely match. The lack of systemic support for entrepreneurship also makes government jobs a secure haven. The recent protests over paper leaks and government exams, especially in Jharkhand, are a reflection of this appeal.

Size of government workforce

Besides technocrats and government staff such as doctors, the government workforce is primarily divided into three groups (Group A, B and C). There was earlier a Group D category (peons) as well, but it has been merged with Group C.

According to data from the Department of Expenditure's website, the total number of employees in the Union government — including Union Territories and missions abroad — as on March 1, 2023 was 30.62 lakh, against a sanctioned strength of more than 40 lakh. This is just the number of permanent employees, not including contractual employees and consultants.

The Union government spent Rs 2.95 lakh crore on the salary of these employees in 2023-24. More than 80% of this figure went towards defence, railways, postal services and home affairs.

While there is no accurate figure of all government employees of the Centre and states, it is estimated that this number is more than 1.5 crore — including the civil administration, armed forces, police, healthcare workers, teachers and others.

Central recruitment

Central government recruitments are carried out by agencies such as the Union Public Service Commission (UPSC), Staff Selection Commission (SSC), the Ministry of Defence (including the Army, Navy and Air Force), the Ministry of Railways, public sector undertakings and universities,

HISTORY

The century-long evolution of the demand for a Gorkha state

Sweety Kumari
Kolkata, August 25

THE UNION Ministry of Home Affairs on Saturday constituted a high-level committee to prepare a framework for a "permanent political solution" to the Gorkha issue. This came after a meeting of Gorkha leaders, Home Minister Amit Shah and West Bengal government representatives in Siliguri.

Roots in differential treatment

The Gorkhas' movement for a separate administrative identity is among the oldest of its kind in India, going back over 100 years. Darjeeling and its adjacent areas — including Kalimpong, Kurseong, the Terai, and the Duars — are culturally, ethnically, and linguistically distinct from the rest of West Bengal. Its residents speak Nepali and have faced racial profiling. This persistent alienation has fueled a deep-seated identity crisis, driving the demand for a separate state to affirm their identity as Indian citizens.

But its origins go further back. The movement began in 1907, when the Dar-

jeeling Hillmen's Association, led by Sonam Wangyel Laden La, submitted a petition to the Minto-Morley Reforms Committee seeking to separate Darjeeling and Jalpaiguri from Bengal.

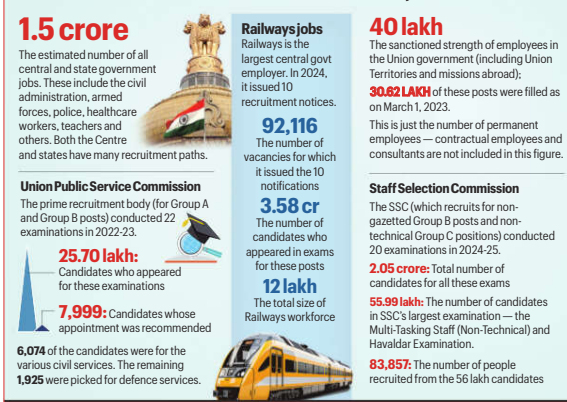
It highlighted the differences between the populations of Darjeeling and the plains, and argued that a legislative body composed mostly of representatives from the plains could not be expected to understand or appreciate the needs and aspirations of the hill people.

Joined by other groups, members of the movement later presented a case to the Simon Commission (1929) and British official Sir Samuel Hoare and Lord Pettkick Lawrence for an alternative governance system, like a Chief Commissioner's Province, for direct rule. By 1947, the undivided Communist Party of India (CPI) formally submitted a memorandum for "Gorkhachand" to interim leaders Jawaharlal Nehru and Liaquat Ali Khan.

The Gorkhaland movement

In the 1980s, the demand for a separate

CENTRAL GOVT RECRUITMENT: LIMITED JOBS, MANY ASPIRANTS



SOURCES: DOPF REPORTS, PARLIAMENT QUESTIONS, SSC AND UPSC ANNUAL REPORTS, RAILWAYS ANNUAL REPORT

among others. Every year, several crore people attempt to enter the central government service through one of these routes. Only around 1.20 lakh make it each year.

UNION PUBLIC SERVICE COMMISSION

The UPSC, the prime recruitment body, primarily selects Group A and Group B civil servants — high- and mid-level officers. Its most prominent exam is the Civil Services Exam, which is aimed at recruiting officials for 19 civil services including the Indian Administrative Service (IAS) and the Indian Police Service (IPS).

In 2022-23, 25.70 lakh candidates appeared for the 22 examinations conducted by the UPSC. The body recommended the appointment of only 7,999 candidates — 6,074 candidates for civil services and 1,925 candidates for defence services. Most UPSC examinations have three tiers — prelims, mains and personality tests.

STAFF SELECTION COMMISSION

The SSC carries out recruitments for most non-gazetted Group B jobs (mid-level supervisory and administrative posts) and non-technical Group C positions (clerical, technical and support posts) in various ministries and departments of the central

State govt jobs

States have their own recruitment system. State Public Service Commissions select Group A and Group B officials (high and mid level officials).

States' Staff Selection and Subordinate Selection Commissions select Group C staffers (clerical and support posts).

government, as well as their attached and subordinate offices. The SSC also recruits assistants and lower divisional clerks for various ministries and attached offices based on their requirement.

Group C jobs make up the bulk of central as well as state government jobs.

In 2024-25, the SSC conducted 20 examinations in which a total of 2.05 crore candidates appeared. Its largest examination was the Multi-Tasking Staff (Non-Technical) and Havaladar Examination which saw 55.99 lakh candidates appearing at 279 venues in 130 cities. Of that 56 lakh, only 83,857 people were recruited.

RAILWAYS: LARGEST EMPLOYER

The Railways is the largest central government employer, with a workforce of more than 12 lakh. It maintains an annual recruitment calendar and conducts all India examinations (since it's a central entity).

According to a July 22 Lok Sabha answer, 5.56 lakh people were recruited through these exams between 2014-15 to 2026-27 (up to June 30, 2026).

During 2024, the Railways issued 10 recruitment notices for 92,116 vacancies. The number of candidates appearing in tests to fill these? 3.58 crore.

State recruitment

While recruitments for Union Territories are made by central government agencies itself, the recruitment for three all-India services (IAS, IPS, Indian Forest Service or IFS) have a centre-state nature — the UPSC allots recruits state cadres and they work under state governments. A limited percentage of officers are always on central deputation to serve under the Union government.

State governments also have their own recruitment system — the State Public Service Commissions to select Group A and Group B officials for services such as the Provincial Civil Service (PCS), Provincial Police (PPS), and State Forest Service, among others. The nature of the all-India services is such that officials from state services, after a particular year in service, are elevated to positions in IAS, IPS or IFS. A mix of IAS, IPS and PCS and PPS of respective states run the government administration on the ground.

Like the UPSC, these state commissions have similar three-tier systems of recruitment. In several states, however, recruitment controversies have erupted from time to time. Jharkhand is just the latest case. According to a rough estimate, all state public service commissions recommend nearly 25,000 to 30,000 candidates every year based on vacancies.

There is no compiled data available for the total number of state employees. In Uttar Pradesh, for instance, there are nearly 16.35 lakh government employees, including nearly the police force of around 4 lakh.

Tamil Nadu has an estimated 12 lakh state government employees. The figure is nearly 5.50 lakh in Kerala, around 4 lakh in Odisha, and nearly 4.5 lakh in the Union Territory of Jammu and Kashmir.

The West Bengal Government recently promised to recruit 1 lakh employees to fill its vacancies.

SUBORDINATE SELECTION COMMISSIONS

As most government employees are in Group C, many such posts — including police constables and sub-inspectors — are filled through separate recruitment bodies such as state Staff Selection Commissions, Subordinate Selection Commissions and Police Recruitment Boards.

Holding these exams is a challenge as paper leaks have become a phenomenon. But for several youth, faced with a lack of private sector jobs, it is also the only option. A few years ago, over 48 lakh candidates applied for 60,244 police constable positions in Uttar Pradesh — which means 80 candidates for each post.

of the region's tourist economy.

Changed political landscape

The fallout from the 2017 protests permanently altered hill politics.

State action forced Bimal Gurung underground, creating a rift that led party leaders Anil Thapa and Binay Tamang to form a breakaway faction aligned with the ruling Trinamool Congress (TMC).

This development permanently split the Gorkha votes between TMC-backed local administration and BJP-aligned national candidates. In the June 2022 GPTA elections, held after 10 years, Thapa's newly formed Bharatiya Gorkha Prajatantrik Morcha (BGPm) won 27 of 45 seats to take control of local governance, while the BJP and Gurung's GJM boycotted the process.

However, the BJP has maintained a strong grip on parliamentary and state contests, winning the Darjeeling Lok Sabha seat in 2019 and 2024, as well as securing victory across all three assembly seats (Darjeeling, Kalimpong, and Kurseong) in the 2026 West Bengal Assembly elections.

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/r2RDV_RG9mJmZgl to determine School discipline from the institution to individual students."

speech, expression, profession, etc.), or 21 (protection of life and personal liberty).

After the case reached the SC, a two-judge bench in October 2022 delivered a split verdict. Justice Hemant Gupta held that "a student... cannot claim the right to wear a headscarf to a secular school as a matter of right," saying that students are required to follow a prescribed uniform in state-run educational institutions.

Justice Sudhanshu Dhillia dissented, saying that "a girl child has the right to wear hijab in her house or outside her house, and that right does not stop at her school gate... To say that these rights become derivative rights inside a classroom, is wholly incorrect."

The matter was referred to the Chief Justice of India to constitute a larger bench. Since there is still no authoritative SC ruling on the issue, the Allahabad HC treated the Karnataka judgment, along with similar HC decisions, as "persuasive authority of great value."

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THE COURAGE RUN

Inside the Army's Paralympic Node



For nearly a decade, an Army centre has been handpicking soldiers with life-altering injuries and training them in competitive sport. AMIT KAMATH travels to Pune's Paralympic Node, now the recipient of a national award, where soldiers do what they do best — put up a fight. It helps that some of them end up on a podium.

PHOTOGRAPHS: ARUL HORIZON

AT 19, Hokoto Sema had to learn to walk again. Three days before he was to join his dream assignment, the Para (Special Forces), the elite special operations unit of the Indian Army, Sema was injured in a land mine blast in Jammu and Kashmir while on a patrol with his original unit, 9 Assam Rifles. He spent the immediate months after the incident lying down on a hospital bed, his left leg amputated below the knee.

"All that I had imagined as my future had changed overnight. Ambition *Khatam*, *Chalega kaise?* Kya future (Forget ambition, you think about how you'll walk, what the future holds?)?" he says. "I was young and heartbroken. I kept thinking, would I ever walk again?"

These days, the 42-year-old Sema, who has a prosthetic limb, is doing a lot more than walking. His career has taken flight: at the 2024 Paralympic Games in Paris, Sema returned with a bronze medal in the men's F57 shot put event. With a long list of medals to his name, Sema is one of the star athletes of the Army Paralympic Node (APN), a centre of excellence that handpicks Army men with permanent, life-altering injuries and provides them with specialised training in sport.

Sema's colleagues at the Node are equally distinguished: at last month's Commonwealth Games in Glasgow, Soman Rana won gold while Shubham Juyal claimed silver in men's F57 shot put — the same category that Sema competes in.

Set up in 2017, the Node's role and contribution in helping soldiers do what they are instinctively built for — putting up a fight when life throws them at the deep end — was recognised when it was named for the 2025 Rashtriya Khele Protsahan Puraskar, which will be handed over by President Droupadi Murmu on August 29, 2026. Since the award was instituted by the Government of India in 2009, several major corporations, sports boards, and NGOs have received the honour. "The goal of the Army Paralympic Node is to give people with amputations or severe injuries a ray of hope. We help them accept whatever has happened and then give them a direction for the rest of their life," says Lieutenant Colonel Daljit Singh, who is the Officer in Charge of the centre.

Life at the Node

If it takes a village to raise a child, it takes an entire ecosystem to build a high-performance athlete.

Since the Node can only select athletes from a small pool of Army personnel who have suffered body-altering injuries, much of the talent scouting happens at two institutions in Pune — the Army's Artificial Limb Centre (ALC) and the Spinal Cord Injury Centre (SCIC) that's based in Military Hospital Kirkee.

The Node was the brainchild of Colonel (Retd) Gaurav Dutta, whose left leg had to be amputated after he stepped on a mine in 2001. As he started competing in triathlons with an artificial limb, Dutta realised the potential of sport in shaping the lives of Army men who suffered from life-changing injuries. Dutta became the Node's first Officer in Charge when it came up in 2017.

• The Node's star athletes

GLASGOW COMMONWEALTH GAMES, 2026

- Gold by Soman Rana in shot put F57
- Silver by Shubham Juyal in shot put F57

PARIS PARALYMPICS, 2024

- Bronze by Hokoto Sema in shot put F57*

PARA ASIAN GAMES, 2023

- Gold by Dharmaraj Solairaj in men's long jump T64*
- Silver by Soman Rana in shot put F57

- Silver by Ajay Kumar in 400m T64
- Silver by Suraj Singh in men's doubles compound archery

- Silver by K Narayana in rowing
- Bronze by Unni Renu in men's high jump T64

- Bronze by Hokoto Sema in shot put F57

- * stands for Field, T stands for Track. The numbers denote the classification and level of amputation

Long jumper Dharmaraj Solairaj won gold at the Para Asian Games in 2023



While the Node is headquartered in Pune, the 53 Paralympic athletes it trains are currently spread across four cities: track-and-field athletes, archers, swimmers, triathletes, rowers and sports climbers train in various facilities in Pune, shooters at the Army Marksmanship Unit in Mhow, taekwondo athletes are based in Bengaluru and the canoeists and kayakers train in Bhopal. The funding, training and technical aspects of athletes are looked after by the Mission Olympic Wing of the Army, and the administrative aspects are taken care of by the Bombay Engineers Group and Centre Kirkee.

Every week, coaches from the Node and Officer in Charge Daljit Singh visit the two centres, the Artificial Limb Centre and the Spinal Cord Injury Centre, with an eye out for athletes they can potentially recruit. But much before they can train the soldiers into world beaters, or even decide who to pick as they scout for talent, the team has to listen to young men grappling with the physical and mental trauma of losing a limb.

"Hum sapne dikhathe hain (We show them dreams)," says Subedar Harendra Yadav, who works as a swimming and triathlon coach at the Node. What he means is that he and the others teach young men, many of them teetering on the edge after a devastating blow, to dream on.

"People who have congenital issues from birth are already used to it by the time they are adults. But for these athletes, it's a shock. Life changes in the blink of an eye," says Subedar Anuj Kumar, who is an archery coach at the Node.

Training athletes once they get here is the easiest part of their job, says Subedar S K Mortaja, who is a sprints coach. "The biggest fight is convincing injured soldiers to come to the Node for the first time. Motivating someone whose life has just changed overnight is the challenging part," he says.

It helps, though, that they are dealing with soldiers. "Faizli aadmi mentally strong hote hain (Soldiers are mentally strong). Once they are at the Node, they can do anything they set out to do."

Node coaches usually pick potential athletes and sportspersons based on their body structure — those with a more muscular build are, for instance, chosen for



Athletes of the Army Paralympic Node training at the Army Sports Institute in Pune: swimmer Kapil Kumar, who competes in the 100m, 200m and 400m freestyle events; at the Artificial Limb Centre, Pune, injured soldiers relearn the mechanics of everyday life

sprint events. Those handpicked to compete are also given peer-to-peer counselling, where someone already training at the Node speaks to a soldier who has just had an amputation.

There have been times when the coaches have had to spend several months talking to a potential candidate before he can join the Node. They even reach out to families and commanding officers of the injured Armyman to build their case.

Ajay Kumar, a blade runner who competes in the 400m T64 running event, needed a lot of cajoling to join the Node. Part of the Chatak Platoon in the 12 Dogra, Ajay lost a limb in a mine blast in Uri in 2017.

His initial days of walking with a prosthetic limb were so painful that "everything from my leg to my brain would hurt". Running was the last thing on his mind, and he rebuffed attempts by the Node coaches to enrol him. Eventually, he gave in. Today, he's a silver medalist at the Para Asian Games in 2023.

Days at the Node are geared towards one singular purpose: win medals for the country. Athletes train twice a day and have regular gym sessions.

"We do training in the morning from 7 to 9.30 am, then again in the evening from 4 to 7 pm," says Sub Major Rakesh Rawat of the 15 Jat Regiment, a sitting thrower coach at the Node.

Rawat explains the impact these hard yards in training can have.

"Shubham Juyal joined us at the Node three years ago. He had never lifted weights. No weight training ever. We taught him the technique behind holding the weightlifting bar. Last month, he won a Commonwealth Games silver medal at

Glasgow in shot put," says Rawat.

'Dream of flying'

On a wall-mounted board inside the Army's Artificial Limb Centre in Pune hang a curious mix of implements. On one side of the wall are an axe and a steel sickle, its teeth glistening in the light. Next to them are everyday items, a few forks and spoons. Completing the set of about 50 items hanging from the wall are Captain Hook-style metallic hooks. These are various activity-specific attachments that the centre has for people who have lost a hand.

A few metres away from this wall of assorted metal instruments is a gas stove, a mixer-grinder and a refrigerator. In an adjoining room is another wooden board hanging from the wall — called the Daily Living Training Board — with various door fittings, latches and electric switches next to faucets. A dressing table with a mirror, with combs on the dresser, too, finds a place in this room.

It's a space where Army men injured in combat are taught to start from the beginning, relearning the mechanics of everyday life — turning a doorknob, opening a refrigerator and picking up a bottle of water.

Outside these rooms is a bigger gym-like space for athletes with prosthetic lower limbs, with walkways with bars on either side to hold on to, a machine that calculates the force each foot exerts on the ground while walking, another with steps on one side and a slope on the other for athletes to learn how to climb stairs and walk down slopes.

With a 500-strong team that includes psychologists, family counsellors, physiotherapists, limb makers and surgeons, the scope of the Artificial Limb Centre is much wider than its name suggests. The centre also refits those who walk in through its doors with, as the shotput athlete Sema put it, "*hansla aur himmat* (morale and courage)". Helping an injured soldier get into a prosthesis and then helping them walk, and even compete, is one of the ways of ensuring that dark thoughts do not take hold.

"We give people who come here a way to a productive and functional life. In some cases, we get them into either recreational or competitive sports. At the Artificial Limb Centre, we have our in-house operation theatre, where we do amputations, and also help with early mobilisation. Usually, people wait for six months but we are able to get patients back on their feet within a week of the amputation," says Brigadier CN Satish, Commandant at the Centre.

The centre has also pioneered prostheses such as the Phoenix Foot (a prosthetic that provides natural ankle movements with shock-absorption capability) and the Rowing Foot (a foot that offers rowers a range of movement). The Rowing Foot was developed specifically for rowers such as K Narayana, who competed at the Paris Paralympics in 2024 and won a silver medal at the Asian Para Games in 2023.

"About 80 per cent of our work here is with regular amputees, who don't compete in elite sport. We first make them pain-free, then make a leg or an arm for them, make them walk, then do advanced activities. We try to push them into some trials here and whoever is a potential candidate for para sport, we send them to the Paralympic Node," says Colonel GP Reddy, a surgeon at the Artificial Limb Centre. "The athletes we send to the Node are our pride. It's the institute's pride that we are able to put them on an international platform and help them win the country medals."

The unofficial motto for anyone coming there, as Reddy puts it, is, "*Chalna nahi hai, daudna hai. Aur udne ka target rakho* (The aim is not just to walk, but to run. And dream of flying)."

'It's all written in your stars'

On a Thursday morning at the Army Sports Institute in Pune, athletes of the Node are training hard, chasing that ambition — to fly. Fittingly, their two training sessions a day are punctuated by the sound of airplanes taking off from an airstrip nearby.

Some of the athletes are on the running track, their blades making rhythmic clicks on the track as they chase a time on the clock. Others are in an adjoining gym, chasing personal bests with heavy weights.

With the Paris Paralympics and the Commonwealth Games behind them, they have a new target in sight: the Para Asian Games in September, where at least 10 athletes from the Node will compete for medals.

Close to the ASI campus, at Training Battalion 208 the Bombay Sappers, throwers Sema and Rana are sweating away. Sema was a 'Sipahi' when the blast happened. Today, he's a Subedar in the Army, with an Arjuna Award and an Ati Vishisht Seva Medal to his name.

"*Libhe rakha hota hai kundali* (It's all written in your stars). If the blast had not happened, I would not have competed in elite sport, all these accolades would not have come to me and I would not have made India proud in so many competitions. *Life main sab kuch milta hai* (I have got everything in life)," he smiles.

Training athletes is the easiest part of their job, says Subedar S K Mortaja, who is a sprints coach. "Motivating someone whose life has just changed overnight is the challenging part," he says

ए- निविदादाता अपनी निविदाओं में समस्त कर एवं जीएसटी/टीडी सहित दरें अंकित करें। जलकॉर्ड कर देय नहीं होगी। निविदा सामग्री विस्तृत जानकारी website: www.onlineupsida.com स्थित डू-डिंक यूएलसी की वेबसाइट www.etender.up.nic.in पर उपलब्ध है।

परिधि इन्फोक (सिविल) निगम लिमिटेड-पंच, आगरा

'The verdict on whether India has game in AI will come only 10 years from now'



SANKHADEEP BANERJEE

(From right) Rajan Anandan, Managing Director, PeakXV Partners; Pratyush Kumar, co-founder, Sarvam AI; Soumyarendra Barik, Special Correspondent, *The Indian Express*, and Anant Goenka, Executive Director, The Indian Express Group

Anant Goenka: Do you agree that India is sitting out the AI game? What do you have to say to people who say that?

RAJAN ANANDAN: The reality is that global capital is leaving the Indian equity markets because we don't have pure-play AI companies and that is true. However, when you look at what is happening in the innovation ecosystem in the private markets, especially at early stages, it couldn't be further from the truth.

India is early in the AI game. 2026 is the year that India entered the AI race. First, computing was a big constraint. But starting at the AI summit in February in Delhi, we've had over \$400 billion of AI capex announced by Reliance, Adani and Tata, the hyperscalers Google and Amazon, AWS specifically, as well as a whole bunch of Indian companies. Compute this year will start getting unlocked.

Second, this is the first year where several Indian ground-up models have been launched. Sarvam has launched models trained ground up in India. You have BharatGen from IIT Bombay.

Third, we're beginning to see the first big category of enterprise AI infect. Voice AI will be the first billion-dollar revenue category for Indian enterprise.

Fourth, we're seeing an explosion of application-level innovation, both for consumer AI in entertainment, travel, healthcare and education as well as at the enterprise level.

So essentially, if you look at it across the stack, this year we've really started seeing movement from models launching to big capex investments. But when you think about whether India will win or not, we should think back to the other big technology waves we've seen. In 2016, India wasn't in the top 100 countries when it came to digital payments. Today, 55 to 60 per cent of real-time payments are in India. It takes a decade. In AI, it could happen sooner. The verdict on whether India has a game in AI or not will come eight to 10 years from now.

Anant Goenka: What do you think gives India the right to win on any of these layers of the stack (energy, chips, infrastructure, models, and applications)? Because of the amount of capital, expertise and skills, China and America seem to dominate and in the chipset, it's Korea and Taiwan.

PRATYUSH KUMAR: AI is one of those technologies where, if you plot it on two axes — how much economic value there is from the technology and how much of a frontier tech it is — on both, AI is off the chart. We are in a post-AI world. We are never going back to not using LLMs. There's no way India will not win in AI.

AI is a horizontal technology. So India will win. The question is when and how, because it is frontier tech. Each of those layers of the cake requires cranking up on innovation. You can't just suddenly get up and say, 'Let me train a model.' It takes expertise, engineering, compute and capital. These are all gating conditions.

Anant Goenka: Demand is not the

AI experts Pratyush Kumar and Rajan Anandan on India's race to build AI, the case for smaller, cheaper home-grown models and the looming challenge of jobs and reskilling in an AI-led economy. They were in conversation with Anant Goenka and Soumyarendra Barik

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problem, it's the business model that seems to be struggling from a global perspective. When you focus only on India, how will you do it at a lower cost than them?

PRATYUSH KUMAR: Take voice AI. A company wants to reach out to its customers and answer questions they have, maybe offer them products. This needs to be low latency. It has to be superb in terms of expressiveness. You feel like you're talking to a human.

Right now, Sarvam models are five times cheaper than GPT mini and nine times cheaper than a Gemini Flash. Those are the alternatives you would use from frontier labs.

So the argument that you are making that there are global companies thinking for the whole world and they will build one-size-fits-all AI for the whole world is actually an argument against optimising things, for use cases for languages and for context and reducing the cost. We are already there and you just saw that on the coding side of things.

The Chinese models are now significantly cheaper than what is available from the frontier labs, having spent and I think China is a great model. We should celebrate it more, having had much fewer GPUs than the US. It's significantly more than India currently, but actually went and built a competitive model.

So, as I said, there's a critical mass to the innovation to the infrastructure and capital once you cross that it's a level playing field for taking problems and optimising for them which we're already starting to do in the market.

Soumyarendra Barik: If Google, OpenAI or Anthropic are looking at

global deployment, how prudent is it to focus on India? Is there a limit to that strategy?

PRATYUSH KUMAR: Absolutely not. There is context of India, but the techniques, algorithms, infrastructure and talent are not specifically focusing on only Indian problems. What matters are the areas we will focus on and hyper-optimise for.

There is this whole thing about frontier AI: Let's get the world's tasks in one place, build massive models and spend lots of money. We're going to try a different approach: Get the tech ready, get the talent ready, focus on verticals and solve for them, even company-wise and use-case-wise.

RAJAN ANANDAN: India is taking a different approach to the frontier labs and the hyperscalers like Google. They're saying, 'Let's go build bigger models.' With a 10-trillion model, a single training run costs you billions of dollars. But you don't need a model bigger than 100 billion parameters for 90-95 per cent of what you need to do with AI in your company. Those smaller models don't need a lot of money to train. You can build almost all of what India needs with smaller, affordable models.

Anant Goenka: Tell us why you think India can win in each of the five layers of the stack.

RAJAN ANANDAN: Power is really important. It's compute intensive. What do data centres need? Power. If you're in a nation with expensive power, you're not going to have AI, because of renewables, has an advantage. In the next five years, long-term storage gets solved. Nuclear will happen; just a matter of time.

Chips, we're very early. India's focus initially was to try to get a few fabs going. That is happening, but these are all 28-nanometre fabs, so they're not for advanced AI chips. We are off the list.

About data centres, I think there's a shot that 10 years from now, the leading Indian hyperscalers will actually be Indian companies. It'll be the Reliances, the Adanis, the Tatals.

In infra, we have a real shot. It's just a matter of time where we get there.

For models, we need 10 companies like Sarvam. Today, we have a handful. Sarvam is obviously the leading company.

On applications, ChatGPT, Gemini, maybe a few other leading AI apps will actually be Indian innovators.

Soumyarendra Barik: We have increasingly been hearing the phrase sovereign AI. What exactly does that mean and why is it important to define the work we're doing within that context of sovereignty?

PRATYUSH KUMAR: On the models piece, the number one priority should be to ensure that we solve today's problems with whatever is available. But the sec-

ond point is that we need to intensify our R&D commitment. Building models is about having the accumulated judgment and talent to build models and play in the game in the next decade. This is a very long game. Unless we recognise that we need the core innovation layer at the centre of it, the gap will widen. We should move super fast deploying whatever is best out there on price and accuracy trade-offs. But we need to have our own story which we rely on and continue to compound. Sovereign seems to be about nationalism. The problem with AI is that not only are you importing it, not only are you not enabling internal innovation, you're actually leaking data.

Anant Goenka: Are you getting support from the government?

PRATYUSH KUMAR: The government has been thinking right about a bunch of things. They've been progressive about what we should do in AI. The Rs 10,000-crore fund that the India AI Mission put together was a step in the right direction. But there's more to be done.

Anant Goenka: Let's get to jobs. Indian middle class 1.0 was created by the public sector; 2.0 after the private sector reform. Railways, defence and the five big IT companies account for millions of jobs. What happens to them with AI?

PRATYUSH KUMAR: There will be a period like we are facing now when there is a lack of clarity on matching business outcomes to people and skills.

The world is in a flux. Technology is moving so fast that people have not reacted to it fast enough. Therefore, there is a concern whether it's going to be a job-less growth. My feeling is that there will be a whole lot more to do.

RAJAN ANANDAN: If you take a 30-40-year view, we are going to go through the same transition. We are going from an agricultural to an industrial society, and we're going to go to an AI-based economy.

The largest companies have never been the source of employment growth. IT services will not hire lots of people because they will leverage AI. But I am pretty bullish about the IT services industry because most enterprises need lots of help to AI-transform themselves.

There will be significant dislocation. Take Voice AI: call centres, simple calls, outbound calls, a lot of that gets automated. Those employees have to get reskilled and upskilled. I do think upskilling is going to be the single biggest thing.

We have the world's largest youth population. Twelve million Indians enter the workforce every year. We have to create 100 million jobs in the next eight years.

Anant Goenka: Do you feel it was the anxiety around AI that was

showing in Jantar Mantar, during those protests?

RAJAN ANANDAN: I don't know exactly what was going on, but we have a million Indians who turn 18 every month. We have to solve that. If we don't create opportunities for 100 million Indians over the next decade, you're possibly going to see things like this happen.

PRATYUSH KUMAR: I think this technology is moving too fast for the rate constant of institutions to change. That's a structural problem — educational institutions, work institutions, government policy, legal.

Anant Goenka: Bill Gates told us that the idea of a job is from an era of scarcity which we will no longer be in. Is the idea of a job archaic to you?

RAJAN ANANDAN: Bill Gates doesn't live in India. We went to the wrong quorum. Honestly, I don't know. Bill is probably absolutely right that our current definition of what a job is is going to change. There are going to be different kinds of roles. I hope that we have UBI (universal basic income) someday, but I think we're far from that.

Anant Goenka: Are we at a fork where most of the internet will be for machines by machines and a smaller part for humans?

PRATYUSH KUMAR: It's very hard to talk about numbers. I have switched off from any of these predictions because there's enough to do already. But everything that we do in the world will get intermediated by intelligence. We sort of go up the level of abstraction. Now, the level of abstraction is going to be intelligence everywhere. I don't imagine myself doing a deal with banks anymore. It will be my agent doing a deal with the bank's agent.

Soumyarendra Barik: Before ChatGPT or Claude, there was a unique way that you would message and I would message. Today, people sound the same. Is there something human about us that we're leaving behind?

PRATYUSH KUMAR: In terms of modalities — audio, image, text — and in terms of access, the floor at which humans touch technology has changed. Technology has come down to how we work, which is natural language and day-to-day access.

Imagine somebody trying to manage their finances who would otherwise have to learn Excel. You can just say, 'I have to save this much money till Diwali. I earn so much. I need so much. How much should I keep saving?' It will give you an answer.

So I think LLMs are enormously humanising. The challenge is that they're on the mechanistic side of that development. One of India's biggest contributions could be to humanise this even further — to understand what really drives human emotions, what drives sustainable pleasure. We're on a very, very powerful technology where every human, no matter their background, can come and actually use technology with much lower barriers.

INDIA'S BIGGEST CONTRIBUTION COULD BE TO HUMANISE AI EVEN FURTHER

EVERYTHING WE DO IN THE WORLD WILL GET INTERMEDIATED BY INTELLIGENCE



Rajan Anandan and Anant Goenka (centre) in conversation with guests at Adda in Mumbai



Akil Hirani, Managing Partner, Majmudar & Partners



Arun Nanda, Managing Trustee, Adhata Trust; Founder & Former Chairman, Mahindra Holidays & Resorts Ltd



Rajeev Gupta, Director, Arpwood Capital Ltd (Left); Jollydeep Kaur, Head of Marketing, Nxtgen Cloud Technologies; Shyam R Singhania, Founder & Chairman, Enar Group



Saurabh Dhoot, Founder, Nucleus Energy Group



Abhijit Mishra, Managing Partner, Nurture Resources LLP



(L to R) Somnath Mukherjee, Chief Investment Officer, ASK Wealth Advisors; Aditya Mishra, COO & Head, Wealth Management at ASK Private Wealth; Suketu Shah, Chairman, Vagabond Holdings



ADITYA MISHRA
COO & HEAD, WEALTH MANAGEMENT,
ASK PRIVATE WEALTH



SOMNATH MUKHERJEE
CHIEF INVESTMENT OFFICER, ASK
WEALTH ADVISORS

What is the threat posed by AI in terms of cyber security and how real and near is it, especially when it comes to public infrastructure or banking infrastructure?

PRATYUSH KUMAR: If I were to have a riskometer, I would say dwell on 10. What is the problem? It is that the models are now significantly more capable and they can run for long durations of time. So they can chain together vulnerabilities that themselves would be innocuous but find specific things that otherwise human hackers would not. At Sarvam, we have been both playing attack and defence because we are being attacked, given that we have interesting things with us and we are also building these systems. Cyber security, like coding, was a critical use case. We will have to spend a lot more ensuring every line of code, whether written by humans or AI, leads to reliable and safe systems.



DHANANJAI BAGRODIA
INVESTMENT MANAGER,
ALCHEMY CAPITAL

What do you actually use AI in your daily life for?

RAJAN ANANDAN: There's an app, that you perhaps don't know of, called Equal AI. It's not one of our companies. It answers your phone. You know how you get so many calls. If the app doesn't recognise who is calling, it answers the phone for you, says it is the agent and takes notes. If it is urgent, it tells you that it is critical. Few weeks from now they are going to launch a bunch of other features where it will actually do things for you. For instance, every time you have e-commerce orders, you get an SMS and the delivery person keeps calling you, hassling you. The app agent will take the call for you and take care of the delivery.



SUKETU SHAH
CHAIRMAN, VAGABOND HOLDINGS

In every field, AI is going to come in. What are the risks of AI?

RAJAN ANANDAN: In the 1800s, India was 25 per cent of global GDP. By 1947, we were 2-3 per cent. Lots of things happened in between, but we basically missed the industrial revolution. That's what happened to India. The way I think about this is that we have to be in the winner's circle. There are few countries in the world that can credibly say they could, because they don't have the talent, scale or economy that can even afford to spend what we are putting into R&D for deep tech. The risk really is that we don't move fast enough as a nation... that we don't aim to be in the winner's circle. This is the industrial revolution, repeat. It'll happen faster, be more consequential and there will be winners and losers in the global race of AI.



GV Giri, President & Head of Research, IIFL Capital Services



Jeetu Panjabi, CEO, EM Investco Capital Advisors



Vanessa Pukal, Consulate General of Canada, Mumbai



Vibha Kagzi, Founder & CEO, Reachiv



(Right) Nisarg Gagrani, Founder, Lakshya Capital with Aniket Dey



Sunil Kumar Alagh, Managing Director-SKA ADVISORS PVT



Sunil Mishra, MD & CEO, Growth Businesses, ANAROCK



Manish Jain, Co-founder, MProfit



Nandan Mehta, TCS, Corporate Affairs

RAPID FIRE WITH ANANT GOENKA

RAJAN ANANDAN

RAJAN ANANDAN & PRATYUSH KUMAR

PRATYUSH KUMAR

● **The one AI startup no one has heard of today, but you believe everybody will soon know of?**
Supernova.

● **BharatMatrimony, Byju's... one lesson from each of the above investments.**

Corporate governance is critical. The startup ecosystem grew very fast — in 2019, we had fewer than 10 or 12 unicorns, and went to about 100 in three years. In that period, a couple of companies didn't have the rigour but that has now settled.

● **Exits from Peak XV or Peak XV's exits — which do you spend more time thinking about?**

The IPO market in India is extraordinary. Until 2019-20, we had no IPOs. This year, India has had over 100 IPOs, despite the war and the pressure on capital markets — both SME and mainboard. It's interesting, especially for venture capitalists, because we invest in companies and then, 10 or 15 years later, we exit them.

● **Do you believe the future of exits is going to be IPOs?**

IPOs will accelerate, but we'll also see strategic mergers & acquisitions.

● **Retail investors are saying they will wait for the post-IPO because a lot of the growth has been eaten up by everybody before the company comes to IPO. Companies are seeing a fall after listing and then an entry. Is that going to be a trend?**

I don't think it'll slow down. What you will see is valuations getting adjusted. The reality is: You are in Bombay, there are four or five large asset-management firms that basically have to decide

whether you can have a successful IPO or not, and they set a price. They're looking for good businesses at good prices.

● **The one biggest risk in investing in any AI company. Tough to justify valuations, shrinking product life cycles, big tech doing it cheaper or faster, a volatile regulatory environment, or something else?**

If you're an application-layer company, the big question is: What are the model companies doing? You have to have enough of an edge and just keep going faster. If you're a model company, you're competing with the best in the world. The premium on scale, execution and innovation is 10 times more today. The bar has gone up dramatically. That's what it is. We don't worry about that. The price is what it is. Either you're in the company or you're not. I don't worry as much about regulation.

● **The most compelling argument is that AI valuations are not a bubble. Valuation is a concern. We are certainly not in a cheap AI market.**

● **Your advice to Indian capital that wants to invest in the AI wave?**

Try to get into Sarvam. Look for interesting companies at the application or model layer. There aren't as many companies in the tooling layer but there are a lot in the infrastructure layer.

● **The one company you most regret not investing in?**
Anthropic

● **The one foreign AI company you keep pointing towards internally.**

PRATYUSH KUMAR: The bet Anthropic made on focusing on coding was amazing.

RAJAN ANANDAN: Yes, coding.

● **One-line advice to an aspiring AI founder in India today.**

PRATYUSH KUMAR: Buckle up.
RAJAN ANANDAN: Get going.

● **What would you tell a researcher who has to choose between working at Sarvam in India or Anthropic in the Valley?**

PRATYUSH KUMAR: There is a certain speed that you get with size. And Sarvam is just taking off. There's so much more to do here. Exciting stuff to be done. It's just the agency to do stuff. Because there's speed, you get to do a lot more.

RAJAN ANANDAN: See, \$1.5 billion to \$100 billion... \$1.5 billion was the last round. That's about 60x. Anthropic would have to be a \$60 trillion company. Which of those scenarios would you bet on?

The one policy framework that aligns Indian AI companies like Sarvam with global AI companies like Google and OpenAI?

PRATYUSH KUMAR: We should all aim towards a world of abundance and positive outcomes. I think this concerns everybody.
RAJAN ANANDAN: India is a wide-open playing field. That's why it's an exciting market, because we believe that if you win in India, you win.

● **Is there one policy fault line that disconnects Indian AI companies from foreign AI companies?**

RAJAN ANANDAN: Currently, I can't think of any.
PRATYUSH KUMAR: Not really.

● **What do you think will be the AI application that will change the following sectors?**

Personalised-to-one interaction.

Best AI solutions provider globally.

We need to make it something that people want to go back to.

We need to solve epidemics at scale but personalised to each person.

Robotics. I think that's coming.

One, we need to be globally competitive on the supply chains. And secondly, massively adopt technology.

Great systems company.

Biomodal. He tends to both surprise on the positive and the negative equally.

Smart company.

Don't know enough.

Definitely don't know at all. But when I go to the Bay Area, it's

I think, just a little bit getting into something touchy.

● **Sam and Elon have agreed on something after a long time,**

● **which is that they're living in the singularity. Are they right?**

This is completely bogus. Somebody should have asked if I looked at the definition of AGI and dissected it. We don't have one.

● **The one foreign AI company you would invest patient capital in.**

I like Google, given how much they're doing. They're really full-stack, and they have various components lined up.

● **One country aside from the US and China that has the potential to emerge as a leader in AI?**
India, of course.

● **Is there any other country we should keep on our radar that has got potential?**

Europe is an option. There are sovereign AI companies there.

● **The one task you would trust the following models most with.**

It does some funny videos. That's what I have heard.

It's really good for world knowledge, especially grounding on the web.

It's a systems company. I don't think the style of the model is particularly frontier on any particular thing, but really good, efficient models.

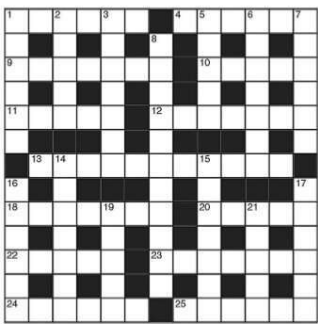
The best code.

It is the application. The older models are great, great coding systems.

CROSSWORD

6077

OVER THE HEDGE



ACROSS

- 1 Goal protest (6)
- 4 Discovers there's not much left (6)
- 9 Odd name for the chap in charge (7)
- 10 Sort of nut that is loose (5)
- 11 She tends to rush over certain points (5)
- 12 It clears one's view — to humbug? (7)
- 13 Told off for having caged a lift to work? (5,2,4)
- 18 Rushing madly from Tangier (7)
- 20 Preely traverse the mountains (5)
- 22 They help to get a side into shape (5)
- 23 Too he'd made of use to climbers (7)
- 24 Meal inside the German hotel (6)
- 25 He can't succeed by himself (2,4)

DOWN

- 1 Do wrong by not working to a finish (6)
- 2 He swears he's one of twelve (5)
- 3 She tells you whose turn is next (7)
- 5 The way to get out and about outside (5)
- 6 To snub a girl may be wounding (7)
- 7 Observe the cook in hot water? (6)
- 8 Give a test in a new form of study (11)
- 14 Forsake careless freedom (7)
- 15 Trooped out to see a naval weapon (7)
- 16 Maroon thread (6)
- 17 One inclined perhaps to be compassionate? (6)
- 19 Children's edition (5)
- 21 Ring in the nose for a rope (5)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6076 ACROSS: 1 Sidecar, 5 Aspic, 8 After a fashion, 9 Early, 10 Rampage, 11 Whinny, 12 Spread, 15 Dragnet, 17 Roost, 19 Whipping posts, 20 Renal, 21 Satisfy DOWN: 1 Kate, 2 Determination, 3 Carry on, 4 Reform, 5 Assam, 6 Private houses, 7 Contend, 11 Widower, 13 Parapat, 14 Stints, 16 Nepal, 18 Testy

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

— is the only refuge of the shallow — Oscar Wilde (11)

ERNES



GUMINS



OSSIA



CAUSER



SOLUTIONS: Ernest, Gumins, Ossia, Causer. **Answer:** The only refuge of the shallow — Oscar Wilde (11)

CALVIN & HOBBS



MARVIN



DIFFICULTY LEVEL 2s INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL

1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

SUDOKU6422



SOLUTION SUDOKU6421



BY MICHAEL FRY & T. LEWIS



BY BILL WATTERSON



BY TOM ARMSTRONG



ROYAL STARS

BY GEORGIA NICOLS

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): This is an excellent day for a practical discussion with someone older or more experienced. This might happen by talking to a partner, close friend or a member of the general public. Check the Moon alert if spending money. Tonight: Friendships.

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): People will notice you more than usual. Relations with co-workers are mutually supportive today. You also might benefit from behind-the-scenes research. Tonight: Be modest.

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): This is the perfect day to explore avenues in media, medicine and the law, but do so before the Moon alert. Romance with someone different might begin. You also might welcome the advice of someone who is older or more experienced. Tonight: Explore.

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): It's fortunate that you have some strong energy now with fiery Mars in your sign. It will stay there for another month. Discussions about shared property and banking could benefit home and family for you today. Tonight: Check your finances.

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): This is a great day to chat with others! It's curious, because even though you will be charming and diplomatic with everyone, it's in your best interests. Be cooperative. Tonight: Listen.

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): You might be interested in buying beautiful things. If so, be aware of the limitations of the Moon alert. Meanwhile, financial discussions will likely benefit you. Keep your pockets open. Tonight: Work.

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): You'll enjoy socialising with others today. Romantic connections will be particularly appealing. If shopping for wardrobe goodies, do be aware of the limitations of today's Moon alert. You have a soft spot in your heart for someone today. Tonight: Be playful.

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): A practical discussion with someone older, perhaps a family member, might introduce improvements at home or within the family. You also might be prepared to confide in someone about a secret flirtation or love affair. Continue to enjoy the company of others, especially younger people. Tonight: Coocon.

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): Conversations with neighbours and relatives will please you today. Someone older might have advice for you. Be reasonable if you face a dispute with someone about shared expenses. A casual friendship might turn flirtatious. Tonight: Discussions.

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): Financial discussions will go well today if you keep an eye on the restrictions of the Moon alert. Bosses and authority figures will favour you. You might be able to benefit home and family in a practical way. Tonight: Check your belongings.

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): It's a great day to make travel plans. An attraction to someone "different" might occur. Meanwhile, everyday discussions will be down to earth and practical. Tonight: You're strong.

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): Work going on behind the scenes will benefit you today. It could trigger money coming your way. If spending today, be careful and frugal. Keep an eye on the Moon alert and its financial restrictions. Tonight: Enjoy solitude and pleasant surroundings.



IREDA CMD Dr. Bijay Kumar Mohanty

received the CSR Lifetime Achievement Award at BridgeBharat 2026 in Bhubaneswar. Organised by the Odisha Corporate Foundation in collaboration with the Public Enterprise Department, Government of Odisha, the award recognises more than 27 years of contribution to CSR and inclusive development. His work has included implementing DDUGJY and SAUBHAGYA schemes to extend essential services to underserved regions, alongside other initiatives in education, skill development, healthcare, rehabilitation, drinking water and accessibility. The recognition highlights the link between clean energy, inclusive development and long-term community impact.



GAIL MC² + Ignite, a sector-specific accelerator programme for deep-tech startups, was launched at IIT Madras on 19 August 2026 in the presence of Dr. Neera Mittal, Secretary, MoPNG along with Rajeev Kumar Singhal, Director (Business Development), GAIL.



BHARAT will host the 5th Coast Guard Global Summit in New Delhi in February 2027, coinciding with the Swarnim Jayanti of the Indian Coast Guard. As part of preparations, the Indian Coast Guard conducted a Working Level Meeting in hybrid mode with representatives from Coast Guards, maritime agencies and international and regional organisations. Discussions covered institutional arrangements, meeting guidelines, information-sharing mechanisms, the summit website and future collaborative activities. The summit is expected to strengthen professional exchanges, operational cooperation and collective maritime capabilities. The initiative also aligns with India's MAHASAGAR vision and its stated commitment to safer, cleaner and more secure seas.



HURL was conferred the CSR Lifetime Achievement Award at BridgeBharat 2026, a National Seminar on Corporate Social Responsibility held in Bhubaneswar. The event was organised by the Department of Public Enterprises, Government of Odisha, in collaboration with the Odisha Corporate Foundation and Bridge Bharat Foundation. The award recognises HURL's sustained efforts in social development, empowerment of underprivileged and marginalised communities and the creation of a more inclusive and sustainable society. The recognition reinforces HURL's stated approach of treating CSR as a long-term commitment to empowerment, community development and meaningful social impact.



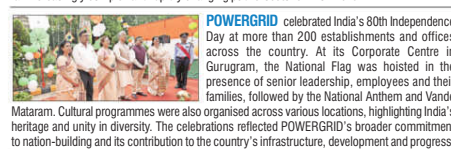
CORPORATE BRIEFS



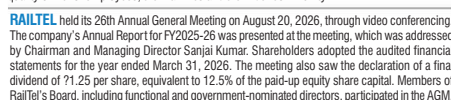
NCC launched its All India Girls High Altitude Long Trek Aparajita - Parang La 2026 from New Delhi on August 18. The expedition includes 28 girl cadets, led by women officers from the three Services, and will cover approximately 250 km over 30 days. The route crosses the 5,578-metre Parang La Pass between Himachal Pradesh's Spiti Valley and Ladakh's Changthang region. The expedition is designed to develop leadership, resilience, discipline and self-confidence among young cadets. Participants will traverse high-altitude deserts, glaciers, snowfields and river valleys, while being instructed to prioritise safety, environmental protection and respectful engagement with local communities.



SCOPE CBC's third DAKSH leadership programme for senior public-sector leaders commenced with a six-day educational immersion at the Indian School of Business, Hyderabad. The programme brings together 72 senior executives from 21 public sector enterprises. Designed as a 12-month leadership journey, DAKSH combines academic learning with global, industry and practical leadership experiences. Its curriculum focuses on Purpose-Driven Leadership, Digital and AI-Enabled Transformation and Strategic Renewal. The programme aims to develop strategic, behavioural and transformational capabilities among public-sector leaders. Building on the first two cohorts, the initiative seeks to prepare executives to navigate an increasingly complex and rapidly changing public-sector environment.



POWERGRID celebrated India's 80th Independence Day at more than 200 establishments and offices across the country. At its Corporate Centre in Gurugram, the National Flag was hoisted in the presence of senior leadership, employees and their families, followed by the National Anthem and Vande Mataram. Cultural programmes were also organised across various locations, highlighting India's heritage and unity in diversity. The celebrations reflected POWERGRID's broader commitment to nation-building and its contribution to the country's infrastructure, development and progress.



HURL celebrated India's 80th Independence Day at its Head Office and units in Baranui, Gorakhpur and Sindri. Beyond the traditional flag-hoisting ceremony, the celebrations featured a series of infrastructure and employee-welfare initiatives. At Baranui, the organisation conducted the Bhooni Pujan of a Chat Ghat Pond and 48 residential quarters, while also inaugurating a Township CCTV Server, Basketball Ground, Children's Park and Recreation Centre. The management also inspected locations for 43 proposed residential quarters. The initiatives reflect HURL's focus on improving infrastructure, safety, recreation and quality of life for employees, their families and the wider community.



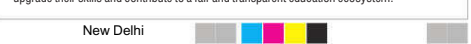
INDIAN OIL RESEARCH AND DEVELOPMENT CENTRE celebrated India's 80th Independence Day with a programme centred on national pride and the organisation's contribution to innovation. The event began with flag hoisting by Dr. Umish Srivastava, Executive Director in-Charge (R&D), followed by the National Song and National Anthem. Addressing employees, Srivastava highlighted the contribution of Indian Oil's R&D activities, particularly innovative products developed for use by the Defence and Armed Forces. A 30-metre National Flag was also dedicated as a tribute to the nation and freedom fighters, linking the organisation's technological capabilities with its broader contribution to national development.



POWERGRID: Amol Taori has assumed charge as Director (Finance) of Power Grid Corporation of India Ltd. with effect from August 18, 2026. A Chartered Accountant with nearly three decades of experience, Taori brings expertise spanning finance, treasury, international trade, marketing and compensation management. Before joining POWERGRID, he served as Executive Director (In-charge), International Trade at Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Ltd., where he managed crude procurement of approximately 700 ktd, international trade and oil price risk management. His career also includes managing a major corporate treasury, leading HPCL's maiden USD bond issue and developing innovative financing and treasury solutions.



GNN has increased the salaries of approximately 1,800 outsourced sanitation workers across the city's 100 wards. Monthly salaries have been raised from around Rs 11,700 to Rs 14,600, an increase of approximately Rs 2,900. The Corporation said the revised pay reflects the workers' rightful remuneration and announced that employees demonstrating exceptional performance and diligence would also be rewarded separately. Male and female Safai Mitras work across main roads and inner lanes, contributing to the city's cleanliness. Corporation officials also acknowledged the workers' contribution and encouraged continued public cooperation in maintaining cleanliness across Ghaziabad.



GDA organised a tree plantation programme under its 'One Tree for the Country' campaign on Independence Day, developing the 'Vande Mataram Garden' at the Madhuban-Bapudham project. Authority officials and schoolchildren participated in the initiative, planting Harishankari, Amla, fruit-bearing and shade-giving trees. The programme aimed to connect the national celebration with environmental protection, public participation and greater green cover. Children were encouraged to take responsibility for plant care and environmental conservation. The initiative forms part of efforts to make Madhuban-Bapudham greener and more environmentally friendly while promoting environmental awareness among younger citizens.

PNB has entered into an exclusive MoU with the Indian Army to offer PNB LUXURA and PNB Parakram Credit Cards to serving Army personnel, JCOs and other ranks. The partnership provides financial and lifestyle benefits tailored to the Army community. PNB LUXURA Metal is designed for Army officers, while PNB Parakram is intended for JCOs and other ranks. Benefits include 3% cashback on CSD purchases, domestic and international lounge access, zero forex mark-up, movie tickets and golf lessons. PNB Parakram also features a biodegradable card design. The partnership strengthens PNB's longstanding relationship with the Armed Forces.

SASTRA Deemed University, Thanjavur, launched six academic initiatives during its Ruby and Silver Jubilee valedictory celebrations on August 17. The initiatives include the TATA Communications Centre for Resilient and Unified Secure Technologies, SASTRA's Integrated AI Framework, SASTRA-MAITRI, SASTRA-STRIDE, DRISHTI and SMILE. The programmes span secure technologies, artificial intelligence, research and internationalisation, faculty development, technology-enabled higher education and student engagement. The initiatives aimed to strengthen institutional capabilities while supporting innovation and continuous skill development. The launch also featured a call for students to focus on innovation, upgrade their skills and contribute to a fair and transparent education ecosystem.

BCCI to discuss granting associate membership to Andaman & Nicobar



BCCI's AGM will be in Mumbai on September 18. REUTERS

Devendra Pandey
Mumbai, August 25

THE BOARD of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) has called its annual general body meeting on September 18 in Mumbai and one of the major topics for discussion will be whether to grant associate membership to the Andaman & Nicobar Islands.

The meeting is going to discuss granting associate membership to Cricket Association Andaman & Nicobar, which is the regional body promoting the game in the union territory, but it's not yet affiliated to the BCCI. This is the first time the board will discuss the possibility of having control over cricket in the archipelago of more than 800 islands located more than 1,000 kilometres from the Indian mainland, at the juncture of the Bay of Bengal and the Andaman Sea.

In a notice sent to all its members, the Indian board will seek the opinion of its member associations in this matter. Grant of Associate Membership to Cricket Association Andaman & Nicobar Island for the Union Territory of Andaman & Nicobar Islands, the agenda for the meeting reads.

If the request for membership is accepted, the BCCI will start hosting cricket matches on the islands and will provide all possible facilities for the development of the sport there. The board will not rush to include a team representing the islands on the domestic circuit but it is learnt that they will be gradually groomed before being included in tournaments. Currently, 38 teams take part in the annual domestic cricket competitions organised by the Indian board.

Another subject on the agenda is the appointment of BCCI's representative(s) at the International Cricket Council (ICC).

The meeting will also witness an election for two representatives of the General Body in the Governing Council of the Indian Premier League. The board will also induct one representative of the Indian Cricketers' Association in the IPL Governing Council.

SRI LANKA VS INDIA, SECOND TEST

Lankans won't go quietly, even as India close in at Colombo

Dinusha's unbeaten 85 & Sooriyabandara's 80 kept visitors toiling on a pitch that didn't break

Shankar Narayan
Mumbai, August 25

DAY 3 of a Test is often viewed as the moving day, when the match starts to go in one team's direction. In Colombo on Tuesday, the game moved in India's favour, but not before they had to toil hard on a surface that showed little sign of deteriorating, making batting look difficult. India took eight wickets, yet Sri Lanka refused to fold, ending the day on 265 for 8, still 238 adrift with two days to go.

India are in a strong position, but the scoreboard does not fully reveal the work that went into getting them there. The bowlers kept returning to their plans, almost accepting that wickets would not come quickly, and building pressure over long spells. It was a combined performance, rather than one bowler carrying the attack.

Prasidh Krishna was the standout. His 3 for 47 from 14 overs provided the pace and aggression India needed. He repeatedly went to the channel outside off stump, made the batsmen play, and kept them unsure which ball to attack. His short-ball plan was effective too. He tested Kamil Mishara with the bounce, and later used the same method against Kamindu Mendis, who pulled a delivery straight to Ravindra Jadeja at mid-wicket. Prasidh's willingness to change his lengths made it hard for Sri Lanka's batsmen to score freely against him.

Manav Suthar carried the bulk of the workload among the spinners. He bowled 21 overs, the most of any Indian bowler, and while his economy rate was higher, his role was to keep-attack on a surface offering only modest assistance. He was prepared to give the ball air, draw the batsmen forward, and look for mistakes. He dismissed captain Dhananayake de Silva, but his breakthrough in the post-test session was just as important. Keshara Nuwantha had stayed with Sonal Dinusha for a long period, but Suthar tossed one down and tempted him into a drive. Nuwantha didn't get the elevation he wanted, and picked out Saranah Jain at mid-off.

Jadeja was India's most economical bowler, going at



Manav Suthar was India's most effective spinner yet again, picking up three wickets for 83 runs. CREMAS

2.30 on a day when Sri Lanka's batsmen were looking for ways to keep the scoreboard moving. His accuracy meant the batsmen often had to take risks to score. He also held the catch that ended Mendis's innings.

Mohammed Siraj bowled only 11 overs through the day, but gave India the important wicket of Niroshan Dickwella, who had put on 146 with Sonal Dinusha in Galle, strangling him down the legside. The surface didn't offer enough to create more dents, but he remained economical for large parts of the day.

Saranah Jain, on debut, would have hoped for a more productive day. He was the only bowler without a wicket on Day 3, his 18 overs going for 51 runs. He bowled mainly from around the stumps, varied his pace, and found enough turn and bounce to create uncertainty. Lahiru Kumara was beaten several times, including by one delivery that turned sharply past the outside edge.

Jain also played his part when India needed control. As the light faded, the spinners were used from both ends, and he remained penetrative with the new ball. His spell left India

keep attacking without giving away too many runs.

Willingness to work

What stood out about India was the willingness to keep working. There were phases when the Sri Lankan batsmen defended well, used their feet against the spinners, and punished the occasional loose ball. The surface didn't crumble enough to make batting impossible. India had to create

Manav Suthar carried the bulk of the workload among the spinners. He bowled 21 overs, the most of any Indian bowler. His role was to keep attacking on a surface offering only modest assistance.

sustained pressure through the day, through accuracy, changes of pace, bounce and patience. The bowling figures underlined how collective the effort was. Prasidh and Suthar took three

wickets each, while Siraj and Jadeja claimed one apiece. No one dominated throughout, but together they kept Sri Lanka from building a partnership big enough to change the match. The final session summed up the day. Dinusha continued to resist, while Lahiru Kumara looked to survive. India kept their noses in front. Sri Lanka tried by a big margin and needed a few more runs to make India bat again. The hosts made the visitors work, but the moving day has still moved the Test India's way.

Prasidh Krishna and Sonal Dinusha deserve special credit. The right-hander combined caution with aggression, and looked set to reach his maiden Test hundred, but was bowled by Jadeja on 80. Dinusha was more stubborn, mixing sways, paddles and footwork to end Day 3 on 85. Their positive batting made India toil.

Scorecard

SRI LANKA vs INDIA

COLOMBO

Toss: India won, chose to bat

INDIA (503/9 DECLARED)

SRI LANKA (0/N/8/2)

Kamil Mishara c Jurel b Krishna 19 (25b, 3x4)

Prasidh Sooriyabandara b Jadeja 80 (133b, 9x4)

Kamindu Mendis c Jadeja b Krishna 32 (58b, 3x4, 1x6)

Dhananjaya de Silva c Rahul b Suthar 8 (14b, 2x4)

Sonal Dinusha not out 137b, 6x4, 2x6

Niroshan Dickwella c Jurel b Siraj 0 (3b)

Keshara Nuwantha c Jain b Suthar 18 (74b, 2x4, 1x6)

Lahiru Kumara not out 8 (50b, 1x4)

EXTRAS 12 (b 0, lb 6, w 1, nb 5, p 0)

TOTAL (83.4 Overs) 265/8

FOW: 3-35 (Kamil Mishara, 9.3 ov), 4-122 (Kamindu Mendis, 29.6 ov), 5-137 (Dhananjaya de Silva, 34.5 ov), 6-171 (Prasidh Sooriyabandara, 44.6 ov), 7-173 (Niroshan Dickwella, 45.3 ov), 8-230 (Keshara Nuwantha, 68.2 ov)

BOWLING: Mohammed Siraj 11-0-33-1 (Prasidh Krishna 14-41-3, Manav Suthar 21-14-33, Saranah Jain 18-5-51-0, Ravindra Jadeja 19.4-45-1)

'Prasidh has done the donkey's job for 2-3 years': Morne Morkel

AFTER A strong second-innings spell in Galle, Prasidh Krishna followed it up with another excellent performance in Colombo, returning figures of 3/47 in 14 overs.

Bowling coach Morne Morkel said the biggest change in Prasidh had been mental rather than technical. "As a team and as management, we always knew about the potential. For him, it is about quieting those voices and just playing cricket," he told reporters on Tuesday. Morkel added that Prasidh had learned to ignore the outside noise and trust his own game.

"Prasidh has got that extra pace. He's got that bounce for us. We're going to use him in certain phases where it might be risky, but we might get the reward as well. It is tough on him. It is sometimes a tough job, the donkey job, but I think he's done that very well for us in the last two or three years. With that, his game has grown into the bowler that can hit that fuller length much more consistently, which is great to see," he added.

Morkel said Prasidh's short-ball strategy is often a deliberate tactical call by the team, and credited the pacer for embracing the difficult job while growing into a more complete bowler. ENS

Consistency, pressure and hard lengths: Prasidh's success recipe



Prasidh Krishna scalped the first two wickets of Day 3. CREMAS

Shankar Narayan
Mumbai, August 25

THERE WAS a temptation, after Prasidh Krishna's spell in the second innings at Galle, to view his success as a product of conditions: steep bounce, movement off the surface and awkward lengths. Colombo offered a stern test. Could he reproduce that discomfort on a dissimilar pitch? On the third day, Prasidh responded to the doubts emphatically.

His Colombo spell was not a carbon copy of the one at Galle, which is encouraging for his overall development. The methods remained the same — hard lengths, bounce, movement and relentless pressure — but the execution changed based on what was on offer in Colombo.

From his fourth over, the pacer settled into the rhythm that had made him so awkward to face at Galle: attacking the body and the top of off-stump with hard lengths, mixing it with the short ball, before returning to the channel outside off. There was enough pace to hurry batsmen, and enough consistency to trouble them.

Kamil Mishara received an early warning in the eighth over. Prasidh angled a short ball into the left-hander, and it beat his attempted pull to strike the forearm. It wasn't a wicket, but it told Mishara he couldn't just line up and attack the rising delivery.

Prasidh followed it with a good-length ball outside off, which Mishara left alone. He then went short again before returning to the channel. The plan was clear: keep changing the length and don't let the batsman off the hook.

The reward came soon. On the third ball of the 10th over, Prasidh got the ball to climb onto Mishara. The opener had already looked uncomfortable against the shorter delivery, and when he tried to fend, it caught the gloves and lobbed through to Dhruv Jurel.

The consistency was evident against Prasidh Sooriyabandara as well. The first ball of the 12th over climbed onto the right-hander, forcing him into

a defensive shot on the on-side. The fourth ball was a bouncer.

A few overs later, Prasidh returned to the channel outside off, getting Sooriyabandara to play and miss. His feet hardly moved as he poked at a delivery that held its line.

No breathing space

That sequence captured what Prasidh had done so effectively in Galle. He was not relying only on movement. He kept the batsmen guessing by deliveries at the body, short of a length and outside off, while maintaining his pace.

With Kamindu Mendis and Sooriyabandara building a steady partnership, Prasidh didn't alter his approach radically, only tightening his lengths. The first ball to Kamindu angled in from round the wicket, followed by deliveries around good or back-of-length areas.

Then came the payoff. On the last ball, Prasidh bowled into the wicket. It was there to be pulled, but Kamindu failed to keep it down, and Ravindra Jadeja took the catch at mid-wicket. Once again, the wicket was less about an individual ball than the pressure build-up before it.

Prasidh's work against Dhananjaya de Silva carried the same underlying quality. Prasidh mixed hard lengths with fuller deliveries, leaving the right-hander uncertain whether to stay back or come forward.

There were reminders, though, that the method carried risk. Sonal Dinusha showed it later by rocking back and hammering a short ball to the deep backward-square boundary. But those moments were exceptions.

The larger picture, though, was of sustained pressure. That made Colombo a continuation of Galle. In the first Test, Prasidh showed he could use bounce and movement to take wickets. In Colombo, he showed that he could create the same pressure through discipline, pace and consistency.

His spell of 3/47 in 14 overs showed that his Galle performance was not just about helpful conditions. He carried the same method to Colombo and kept asking questions.

After returning to T20I & ODI teams, Ishan eyes Test comeback

Venkata Krishna B
Bengaluru, August 25

ISHAN KISHAN doesn't like to wait. At the start of the year, he broke back into India's T20I team and played a big role in the World Cup triumph. Then came the recall to the ODI team. In both instances, he was an outsider before taking someone's spot. While the wicket-keepers slot in India's Test squad appears locked with Rohit Pant and Dhruv Jurel in the playing XI, Ishan has his sights set. Perhaps, having done it in two formats, he knows what to do.

After the East Zone side, led by him, wrapped up an innings- & 210-run win over North-East Zone in the Duleep Trophy quarterfinal, Ishan was candid about his goal.

"One hundred percent," he says when asked if he wants to be part of the Test team. "Anybody who has played Test cricket would love this format. We know its importance and how it helps one get better. People don't believe me, but I really do enjoy red-ball cricket. My only job is to score runs and make my team win," he adds.



Ishan Kishan recently returned to India's white-ball plan. CREMAS

Since playing two Tests in the West Indies in 2023, Ishan hasn't added any years to his name. For the South Africa series later that year, India preferred KL Rahul with the gloves, following which Ishan flew home and even skipped the Ranji Trophy. But since returning to the domestic grind, he has been regarded those in front of him.

"I love this game (red ball). I enjoy it because when you are in the middle, the ball is moving, players are coming at you, there is banter going on with the other team. It's always fun

to be part of it because I love that challenge. Yes, it's easier to bat on flat tracks and fun as well, but the competition in Tests is different." The 28-year-old asserts.

But having played plenty of white-ball cricket for most of this year, Ishan knows switching formats doesn't come easily. The Duleep Trophy quarterfinal was Ishan's first red-ball fixture in 10 months.

"It's a challenge, but fun. It's not easy to succeed in all three formats. Here I was looking to play towards third man and got nicked out. I was like, 'what the heck was I trying to do?' I should know this is a long format and I need to leave a few balls. But sometimes when you think about something that you don't want to do, you end up doing it," Ishan says.

The path back isn't smooth. "I need a lot of effort to get back in the Test team. Dhruv and Rishabh are doing so well. They are continuously scoring runs. I'm very happy for both of them. At the same time, my job is to not think about what can go wrong for them, but to keep getting better. It's meant to happen, it will," he philosophises.

{ DULEEP TROPHY }

Musheer falls for 96 as North Zone bounce back

Venkata Krishna B
Bengaluru, August 25

GOING BY the scorecard, the North Zone vs West Zone Duleep Trophy quarterfinal is evenly poised heading into the final day on Wednesday. Chasing 287 for a win, West are still 67 runs away and have just three wickets in hand.

As Musheer Khan, who top-scored for West with 96, put it, "From my thinking, *yeh badhi baat nahin hai. Lekin batting abhi chalu hai* (It's not a big deal; we've got batters to come)," referring to Tanush Kotian and Shardul Thakur, still to come, they believe they're in with a chance. But North will feel the same, particularly after the manner in which they hauled the game back after Musheer, in the company of Ruturaj Gaikwad (66), had been in a hurry to chase down the total and book a semi-final clash against South Zone later this week.

This was a day on which both teams traded blows, and both ended up surrendering their advantage at some point. Given how well India's batters have handled spin-friendly conditions recently, a message has already gone out to the cu-

rators at the CoE ahead of the Duleep Trophy to roll out turning tracks. Over the three days here, spinners from both sides have enjoyed bowling on this red-soil surface, with turn and bounce causing all sorts of problems.

Starting Day 3 with a 171-run lead and six wickets in hand, North had the chance to bat West out of the game. Ayush Badoni scored 50 again, his footwork the best on show from either side, but, as in the first innings, he threw it away, going for another slash, this time off offspinner Tanush Kotian, who ended with another four-wicket haul in the match, 4 for 46.

Once Badoni departed, North's approach changed. With the pitch slowing a little, they ground their way through, Nishant Sindhu's 44 holding the innings together in the second half.

With a few useful contributions around him, they finished on 222. Shams Mulani, who had started the slide at the top of the order, cleaning up the tail to finish with four wickets. Given how West had crumbled against left-arm spinner Abid Mushtaq in the first innings, a target of 287



Alongside captain Ruturaj Gaikwad, Musheer Khan (in pic) constructed a 111-run partnership for the fourth wicket. EN

looked a long way off. When Arshdeep Singh and Anshul Kamboj reduced West to 28 for 2, North had the perfect start, before Musheer, alongside Shivalik Sharma, steadied things. But it was the 111-run stand between Musheer and captain Gaikwad that brought the game to life. Early on, Musheer used unorthodox methods to counter the seamers, jumping down the track, defending, or simply leaving the ball.

Once he read the surface, he began scoring more freely, but it was Gaikwad who in-

jected the real momentum into the chase. From the moment he walked in, he took the attack to the opposition, using his feet and the depth of the crease to make batting look easy on a tough surface. A strike rate of 94.28, 66 off 70, before he was run out, summed up his dominance.

Positive mindset

"We have similar wickets in Mumbai. At Azad Maidan we have wickets which are worse than this. I had a mindset that I should stand on the wicket as

much as possible. Since we were chasing, I was playing with a positive mindset. Both of us (he and Gaikwad) were backing our own game. It was not a conscious plan to attack. We just focused on the right shots to play. But I'm not regretting missing a century. I'm just regretting not finishing the game," Musheer said.

Gaikwad's run-out gave North the opener they'd been chasing. From there, wickets came in a rush. Sindhu removed Musheer, and Mushtaq claimed the twin wickets of Sams Mulani and Mukesh Choudhary off the last ball of the day. With Urvil Patel, capable of quickfire runs, and Kotian and Thakur still to come, West have reason to believe they can finish this off on Wednesday. It won't be easy, though. **BRIEF SCORES:** North Zone 251 & 222 (Ayush Badoni 50, Nishant Sindhu 44; Tanush Kotian 4/46, Shams Mulani 4/78) need 67 runs to win vs West Zone 287 & 220/7 (Musheer Khan 96, Ruturaj Gaikwad 66). **East Zone 111 & 146** (Pheerajm Jotin 39; Anukul Roy 5/37) an innings and 210 runs.

India to face Panama in football friendly next month

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 25

HOCKEY WORLD CUP

Factor hurting India on the turf: Inability to track back quickly

THE ALL India Football Federation on Tuesday announced that the Indian team will play Panama in an international friendly on September 26, during the FIFA Men's International Match Window. The venue for the fixture will be confirmed at a later date," the AIFF said in a statement.

The match was added to AIFF's calendar after India withdrew from the inaugural FIFA ASEAN Cup in June. Indonesia were named hosts, with India drawn alongside the hosts, Singapore and Malaysia. On 30 July, however, AIFF announced a friendly against Brazil, which will be played in Kolkata's Vivekananda Yuva Bharati Krangan on 3 October.

The AIFF had initially insisted that India would compete in both competitions, but it eventually became an unfeasible proposition.

The federation had explored the possibility of sending separate squads to the two competitions, but that option was ultimately ruled out on Tuesday.

This will be the first time that India and Panama will face each other and it's only the ninth different CONCACAF side India have faced in their history. Panama, currently ranked 44th in the FIFA World Ranking, had played in the 2026 World Cup and finished bottom of their group and were eliminated from the first round.

This will be the first of four matches India will play against this summer's World Cup nations in 2026, with Brazil to follow on October 3 and New Zealand on November 12 and 15.

Emami pulls out

PTI adds: Emami Group on Tuesday officially ended its role as an investor in East Bengal Football Club, transferring all its shares and associated voting rights back to the club, while continuing its association with the red-and-gold outfit as a sponsor. "While stepping away from its investment and management role, it will continue its association with East Bengal Club as a sponsor, supporting the Club and its ongoing sporting ambitions," Emami said in a statement.

It was already known that Emami and East Bengal were set to part ways as investors. This followed the club's victory last season under the group's ownership structure, which ended a 22-year wait for their maiden Indian Super League title. The triumph was followed by a revamp, with coach Oscar Bruzon stepping down and Antonio Lopez Ibañez taking over as head coach.

shutters across the world, and has watched stringing evolve from a sidelined activity into an absolute necessity at badminton's majors.

"I started back in 1994 when Yonex wanted to show people what stringing is. I had a shop that was probably the first to string rackets for world No. 1 Morten Frost. Yonex asked me to be part of the stringing team at the 1994 edition of All England, and well, I haven't stopped since then," Mark told *The Indian Express*.

Stringing station

Every major badminton event, the World Championships, Thomas and Uber Cup, Sudirman Cup, Junior Worlds, now has a dedicated stringing station, usually belonging to brands like Yonex, Victor or Li-Ning, where shuttlers get their rackets fixed before and after matches.

There was a time, though, when stringing was an afterthought at these events.

"When the All England moved from Wembley to Birmingham, that is when this concept of stringing the rackets during a tournament started," Mark recalled.

Now, stringers get a full team and a dedicated space to cater to players' needs. "Now, you see all this area which is well lit and we have multiple staff. Earlier we used to do the stringing on the side of the courts while matches were going on. Ten years into my career, I have done stringing on the arena floor."

Somewhere around 2005 or 2006, a dedicated space for stringers started taking shape, Mark said. Asked about the busiest tournament he's been part of, Mark said, "When World Championships and Sudirman Cup were held together, that used to be the busiest time for us."

At the Delhi World Championships, the first two days were the busiest for Mark and

Midfield didn't have the legs, leaving gaps for the opposition to run through

Mihir Vasavda
Mumbai, August 25

HARMANPREET SINGH had just given India a lifeline. His goal against the Netherlands halved the deficit and briefly changed the mood of India's World Cup campaign. He sprinted back to the dugout and lay down for treatment on his aching back. Within minutes, India lost possession in midfield, the Dutch broke at pace, and Thijs van Dam restored their two-goal lead.

It was one passage in one match. But the sight of the Dutch running into space India had failed to cover became a recurring image of their World Cup.

They call it repeat sprint ability. In hockey, it is the capacity to sprint, recover, and sprint again, repeatedly, over 60 minutes. It allows a midfielder to join an attack, lose the ball, and still get back quickly enough to cover the space before the opposition can run through the middle.

For Siddharth Pandey, technical director of Hyderabad Toofans and coach of Mumbai-based club CTC, India's World Cup campaign offered a fairly straightforward diagnosis. "For our midfielders, do not have the ability to come and cover the space in midfield on a defensive transition when they've lost the ball, that is the sure-shot sign that they do not have the repeat sprint ability," Pandey said.

The evidence, he said, was visible repeatedly: open spaces in midfield, opponents running through the centre. "They're not running back because they're not fit." It is a striking assessment, because fitness was once



India struggled to keep up with the pace of matches, unable to repeatedly produce high-intensity runs. ■

one of Indian hockey's biggest competitive advantages, built over the last 15 years.

Under previous coach Graham Reid and scientific adviser Robin Arkell, India's physical output was measured almost obsessively, and data became a source of competition. The aim was not simply to make India fitter. Arkell, drawing on his rugby background, wanted to turn Indian players into "powerful, strong, fast athletes." By the Tokyo Olympics, fitness had become part of India's identity, and India won bronze after playing eight matches in 13 days in excruciating heat.

Arkell left after Tokyo, and the physical setup changed. By the 2023 World Cup, concerns had already emerged about whether India had maintained the standards reached under him. That does not mean fitness was subsequently ignored. Alan Tan joined as scientific adviser in 2023 and continues to work with the team. Under

chief coach Craig Fulton, physical preparation has remained a focus. Hardik Singh has spoken about Tan pushing players through 400m and 1,600m runs and hill work, while Tan has described a data-driven, individualised approach.

So this is not a simplistic Arkell-versus-Tan story. India have continued to use sports science and focus on conditioning. The question is whether that preparation is translating into the kind of repeated high-intensity efforts that international hockey now demands. Pandey believes it did not, at this World Cup. The open spaces in midfield, he said, were a consequence of players failing to recover after losing possession.

The same problem may also have hurt India's attack. An Indian selector, speaking anonymously, pointed to a recurring pattern. Instead of running at defenders, eliminating a player through a forward pass, or hitting teams before they had re-

organised, India often played sideways or backwards after winning possession. That allowed opponents to settle.

By the time India created chances, the selector said, there were often seven defenders inside the circle. "You can't do every time," the selector said. "But unless you do it five, six times in a half, you're not spreading the defence."

Tough transition

There is a connection between the two criticisms. Counterattacking requires repeated high-intensity runs. Defensive transitions demand the same capacity in reverse. And this is where India's generational transition becomes relevant.

The average age of India's World Cup squad was around 28.4 years. That is not an exceptionally old team. There are players in their early and mid-20s who can become important members of the side. But several of the players who continue

Under previous coach Graham Reid and scientific adviser Robin Arkell, India's physical output was measured almost obsessively, and data became a source of competition

to carry major responsibilities are from the generation that formed the core of India's Olympic resurgence, and are in their early and mid-30s, middle age in sporting terms. The physical demands on that group have accumulated over years of international hockey.

That does not mean the answer is simply to replace older players with younger ones. Younger players need time to reach that level. There is a difference between being physically capable of producing a sprint and knowing, after years of international hockey, when to make that sprint, how to recover from it, and where to position yourself when the ball is lost.

Experience, tactical understanding, and physical maturity develop together. India's challenge, therefore, is not that their younger players cannot match the older generation. It is that they have not yet had enough time at this level to fully take over the responsibilities carried by the established players.

The concern is whether that transition has happened quickly enough. At the Tokyo Olympics, and even at Paris 2024, fitness allowed India to press, recover, and counterattack repeatedly through a gruelling tournament. At this World Cup, those same qualities were harder to see.

Virat Kohli recently halved the fitness levels of the Indian hockey team. This World Cup, and an ageing squad, raise an uncomfortable question: are they fit enough to keep running with the world's best teams?

Chelsea start Alonso era with 3-2 win over Fulham

Reuters
London, August 25

CHELSEA BEGAN life under new coach Xabi Alonso with a breathless 3-2 victory at West London neighbours Fulham in the Premier League on Monday as their exciting front three of Joao Pedro, Morgan Rogers and Cole Palmer all found the net.

Chelsea got off to a dream start after 31 seconds when Palmer – looking back to his best after struggling with an injury last season – passed to Joao Pedro and the Brazilian flicked the ball over goalkeeper Bernd Leno. Fulham equalised when Josh King beat goalkeeper Robert Sanchez at his near post in the 24th minute, giving the home fans something to cheer against their fiercest rivals. But two of Chelsea's new signings then came in the 41st as central defender Marc



Cole Palmer (L) scored Chelsea's third goal at Craven Cottage. ■P

right before cutting the ball back to the club's £117 million (\$159.47 million) record signing Rogers, who made no mistake.

Four minutes into the second half, Joao Pedro held up the ball in attack and fed Palmer, who angled a shot through Leno's legs, underlining the midfielder's return to form after

missing out on a place with England at the World Cup.

"It was a difficult season with injuries and whatnot but through the summer and since I've been back I've worked extra hard," Palmer told Sky Sports. "Obviously with the injuries I've had to try and prevent them and work extra hard day in, day out.

Chelsea's Enzo Fernandez – a lynchpin of World Cup runners-up Argentina who has been linked with a move to Manchester City – was greeted with loud boos from the home fans when he came on as a substitute midway through the second half.

Alonso's win in his first competitive match since taking over at Stamford Bridge came at the expense of his former Liverpool and Spain teammate Alvaro Arbeloa – similarly making his Premier League debut as his league debut after signing from Real Madrid, gave the hosts some hope by heading in after Sanchez could only parry a Timothy Castagne shot in the 54th.

Fulham then had a great chance to level again through Antonee Robinson in the 78th minute but his chip over a stranded Sanchez went wide and Chelsea held out to claim the points.

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Facing time trouble, Pragg holds his nerve to outsmart Keymer



R Praggnanandhaa (L) won the semifinal with four games to spare. He plays Fabiano Caruana in the GCT final. ■ENNART OOTIES/FIDE FLICKR

Mayank Chaudhary
New Delhi, August 25

4, 1 and 1. Those were the exact seconds left on R Praggnanandhaa's clock before he found his response on the 34th, 35th and 36th moves, the sequence that would eventually change the course of the second Classical semifinal against Germany's Vincent Keymer.

His moves may not have been all accurate. In fact, one of them was a mistake, and on another day, he might have paid the price for it. But what Pragg did just one move earlier left even seasoned commentators speechless. At stake was a spot in the final of the 2026 Grand Chess Tour Finals.

For the first time in the match, his clock dipped below a minute. And instead of rushing or panicking, he preferred to finish something else. With the timer dangerously hovering below 10 seconds, Pragganandhaa calmly reached down and adjusted a tumbling pawn, placing it perfectly back on its square before finally pressing his clock, which had ticked dangerously close to zero.

Praggnanandhaa was doing all of this while navigating an inferior position against the German.

The moment was so audacious that commentator Maurice Ashley stopped his analysis mid-sentence, unable to contain his disbelief. "That's uber cool, I am sorry! Adjusting pawn with nine seconds on the clock. Wow!" he exclaimed.

That one moment captured everything about Pragganandhaa: his nerve, his calm, and his ability to thrive in the most insane positions. And while both players flinched under pressure, Pragganandhaa found a way back. The German, however, didn't. Keymer's mistakes in the time scramble proved far more costly, allowing the Indian to seize the moment and book his place in the summit clash of the GCT Finals.

American Grandmaster Wesley So has a keen eye for observation. He had pointed out exactly where Vincent Keymer's game falls apart.

"The problem is that Vincent, with three minutes on the clock, loses a hundred or two hundred rating points! When he gets into time trouble, he starts making big mistakes. That's a problem," So said during Keymer's first Classical semifinal game against Pragganandhaa.

It may have sounded harsh at the time, but how Keymer's game unfolded across both Classical matches eventually

proved So's point.

In the first game, Keymer was cruising. He had played a better opening than Pragganandhaa and looked in control. But as soon as the clock started to bite, his grip loosened. He fell into time trouble, allowing the Indian to slip out of his grasp. It wasn't until a big mistake from Pragganandhaa himself that both players settled for a wild draw, sharing three points each.

Praggnanandhaa, however, does not like to repeat his mistakes. When Keymer gave him a second chance in the second Classical game, he grabbed it with both hands.

Coming back to his response with just one second on the clock, the 34th move was a bone fide positional blunder from the Indian. The engines favoured Keymer by +3, and Pragganandhaa had no time to swindle his way through. Fortunately, he didn't have to do anything extraordinary. Keymer handed him the game on a platter just one move later with the decisive blunder of the match.

From a +3 position, Keymer suddenly found himself in a -2 position after his Knight to d2 check. Playing White, Pragganandhaa got rid of Black's tricky Knight and most of the minor pieces, leaving himself with a queen and Knight endgame with an extra pawn. The German eventually folded in 55 moves, facing a mate-in-12.

Clinical in Rapid

After blowing up two favourable positions and conceding a 3-9 deficit in the clash, Keymer never seemed to recover in the shorter time controls. Pragganandhaa, on the other hand, was clinical and needed no help from the clock to dismantle the German's defences in both Rapid games. The Grandmaster from Chennai extended his lead to 17-3, nailing both Rapid wins to add 8 more points and seal the fate of the clash without the match-up needing to go to the Blitz rounds.

With the final spot already gone, Keymer still turned up for the final leg of the clash. But the first of four Blitz games crushed him further. He messed up another winning position and lost a wild game that swung both ways in the endgame. The scoreboard was screaming 19-3, and the German still had three more games to play.

That's when the Indian took his foot off the pedal. Keymer finally found his way through, eking his humiliating run with three back-to-back consolation Blitz wins.

● PUTTING STING IN THE STRINGS

Little-known craftsman whose hand is behind every badminton champ's racquet

Pritish Raj
New Delhi, August 25

"WHEN LAKSHYA Sen is on a winning run, his rackets need more stringing than anyone. His coach would bring five or six rackets after the game and he is probably the best customer when he is winning."

"Lin Dan had a very unique grip. Half of his handle was strapped while the other half, the tail, used to be wooden."

"The Chinese team carries their own stringers, given the large size of their squad. However, despite that, some of their players prefer to come to our stringing station during majors."

These are some of the anecdotes Yonex's head of operations, Mark Lawrence, has to tell.

In a career spanning over three decades, Mark has strung thousands of rackets for top



Mark Lawrence has been stringing for more than 30 years. ■NIP

him. "We had close to 500 stringings. The early days are busy, as there are so many players playing in a day. Once the tournament settles down, our work also gets a little eas-

ier, with fewer requests coming in," he said. Stringing stations at major championships also give players from countries outside badminton's traditional power-

Now, you see all this area which is well lit and we have multiple staff. Earlier we used to do the stringing on the side of the courts while matches were going on. Ten years into my career, I have done stringing on the arena floor"

MARK LAWRENCE
ON HIS EARLY DAYS IN STRINGING

houses, Brazil, the UAE, Myanmar, a chance to access the best strings. "Of course they have local stringers in their countries, but players from developing countries do come and take advantage of the fact that they are getting free stringing and good-quality strings," Mark said.

Beyond stringing as a service, string tensions in rackets have risen over the years. Tension is essentially the tightness of the string on the racquet: higher tension makes the string bed firmer and offers more control, while lower tension makes it softer and gives it more power. "When I started, the average tension for a racket used to be 28 or 29, but now anything above 30 is the standard. The Danish players used to have higher tensions back in the day," Mark said.

Interestingly, the highest and the lowest tension Mark has ever

strung both belong to Japanese players. "Kenichi Tago, one of the All England runners-up, had the highest tension I have ever done. He had string tension over 34 lbs. The lowest I have done is Akane Yamaguchi, who uses a tension of 25 lbs, while the average tension for women's singles hovers around 30," he said.

"Lower tension complements Yamaguchi's game. She is not the most powerful player, so with the lower tension, she gets a slightly bigger sweet spot in the middle of the racquet, which gives her good control. When the tension is lower, the shuttle stays for a fraction longer," Mark explained. As he headed back to the stringing area, Mark quipped, "Finally, I can watch the matches in peace, as there are no stringing requests. I missed watching PV Sindhu and Ayush Shetty in action."